

LIVEWELL BY JAMES

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Raising Believers
Christian Parenting and the Costly Work of Forming Faith in a Post-Christian
World

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INTRODUCTION

The Faith You Cannot Transmit

I have five sons. I have been a pastor for long enough to have baptized children I held as infants. I have sat in living rooms with parents in their sixties whose grown kids no longer claim the faith, and I have sat in living rooms with parents in their thirties who are terrified their kids will end up in that first room. Something has broken in the way Christian households form children, and no amount of curriculum is going to fix it.

This is a book for parents who know that. Parents who have done the bedtime devotionals and the Sunday school drop-offs and the youth group volunteering, and who still have this quiet sense that something is not taking root. They have done what they were told to do. And they are watching children they love quietly lose interest, or harden, or disappear into a phone that is catechizing them in a different gospel every seven seconds.

I want to be honest about what this book is and what it is not. It is not a program. It is not thirteen steps to raise godly children. There are enough of those on the shelf already, and most of them are selling the same quiet lie, which is that if you run the right process on your child, you get the right output. You do not. Children are not processes. Faith is not an output. And the parent who believes otherwise is going to be devastated either by a child who performs compliance without conviction or by a child who eventually stops performing.

So what is this book. It is the slow, uncomfortable argument that faith forms in children the way it forms in anyone. Through the weight of a life lived near other lives that are actually believing. Through the honest presence of adults who are not pretending.

Through questions that are answered rather than deflected. Through a household whose ordinary rhythms quietly say, over years, that God is real and that following Him is the most serious thing we do.

That kind of formation cannot be outsourced. It cannot be scheduled in thirty-minute family devotions that everyone dreads. It cannot be purchased in a curriculum. It cannot be delegated to the youth pastor, though God bless the youth pastor. The faith that forms in children forms in the soil of a home. And if that soil is thin, nothing grows, no matter how good the seeds are.

Here is the part I have to say up front, because it is the part that keeps me honest. I am in this indictment. I have been, at different seasons, the distracted father, the anxious father, the father who outsourced what I should have carried, the father who answered too quickly because I did not want to admit I did not know. I have performed spirituality in front of my sons when what they needed was a father who was actually praying. I have told them the right things while my life was teaching them something else. If any of that sounds familiar, you are not reading a man who has figured it out. You are reading a man who has been chastened enough to stop pretending.

Let me tell you where this book started. It did not start in a study. It started in my own kitchen, about six years ago, when one of my older boys looked at me during a family devotional and said, Dad, do you actually want to be doing this right now. He was not being disrespectful. He was being observant. He had watched me check my phone twice during the reading. He had watched my eyes glaze over my own questions. He had watched me rush through the prayer because I still had emails to answer. He was not questioning the faith. He was questioning me. He was asking whether the thing we were doing mattered to the person who said it mattered.

I wish I could tell you I handled it well. I did not. I gave a defensive answer about the importance of family devotions. He did not respond. He did not need to. He had already made his point. And

his point settled into me over the next several weeks like a stone dropping through water. He was right. The devotional had become a performance. I was checking a box. My sons could see it. And they were drawing the correct conclusion, which was that this faith thing was important enough for us to perform but not important enough for it to be real.

That evening was the beginning of a long dismantling of the model I had been running. Not the model I preached. The model I lived. Because those were not the same model, and my sons knew the difference even when I did not.

The diagnosis I want to give in this book is not that Christian parents are failing their children. It is that Christian parents have been sold a model of formation that was never going to work, and many of them have run that model with great faithfulness and are now grieving the results. If that is you, I am not here to add guilt. I am here to name what was wrong with the model, and to point toward something older and slower and harder and, I believe, more honest.

Let me tell you what I see from the pastor's chair, because the view from here is different than the view from the pew. I see families that are doing everything right by every metric the evangelical world has given them. Regular attendance. Small group participation. Missions giving. Bible memory programs. And I see their children leaving. Not at the margins. At the center. The most committed families in my church are sometimes the ones whose children walk away with the most resolve, because those children experienced the full version of the model and found it wanting.

I also see families that nobody would put on a poster for Christian parenting. Families that are messy, that miss Sundays, that have never completed a Beth Moore study. But their kids are walking with Jesus in their twenties and thirties, and when you ask those kids why, they say the same thing. My parents were real. They were not impressive. They were real. The faith in our house was not a program. It was the way my mom and dad actually lived.

That observation, repeated across twenty years of pastoral ministry, is what this book comes from. Not a theory. A pattern. The pattern is consistent enough that I am willing to call it a principle. The principle is that faith forms in proximity to a real life, not in exposure to a right program. And the implications of that principle are uncomfortable for a generation of Christian parents who have invested heavily in programs and lightly in their own interior lives.

I need to say something about the statistics, because some of you have seen them and they are part of what brought you to this book. The numbers vary depending on who is counting and how they define the terms, but the general picture is this. Somewhere between forty and sixty percent of young adults raised in evangelical Christian homes are walking away from the church by their mid-twenties. Not all of them are abandoning faith entirely. Some are moving to different traditions. Some are moving to a private spirituality that has no community. Some are moving to no faith at all. But the exodus is real, it is large, and it has been growing for three decades.

The most common evangelical response to these numbers has been to build better programs. Better youth ministries. Better apologetics curricula. Better college transition strategies. Better worship experiences designed to keep young people engaged. None of these responses are wrong in themselves. All of them miss the point. The point is not that the programs were bad. The point is that the programs were being asked to do something only a household can do, and the households, behind the program attendance, were running a different catechism than the one the programs were teaching.

This is not a comfortable diagnosis. It is the diagnosis I believe is true, and I have staked this book on it. If I am wrong, the rest of the book falls apart. If I am right, then the most important decision a Christian parent makes is not which church to attend or which school to enroll the child in or which curriculum to follow. The most important decision is what kind of person the parent is going to be, in their own home, when nobody from the church is watching.

The model I am naming goes something like this. Christian formation is primarily cognitive. You get the child to believe the right things. So you teach the content. Sunday school, Awana, VBS, youth group, Christian school if you can manage it. You stack the content. Then you add behavioral guardrails around their life. No this, no that, yes to this. You layer in the right music, the right friends, the right media. You maintain this fortress until age eighteen, at which point you release them into the world and hope.

I call this the fortress model. You build the walls. You fill the interior with the right content. You patrol the perimeter. You keep the bad out and the good in. And when you release the child, you hope the fortress held long enough that the child will carry the architecture into the world on their own.

The problem with the fortress model is threefold. First, the fortress is permeable. It always was. In 1985, the fortress had cracks. In 2026, the fortress has a smartphone-sized hole in the wall that connects to every idea, image, and ideology the human species has ever produced. The wall cannot hold. It was never going to hold forever. It was only designed to hold until the next Sunday, and even that is optimistic now.

Second, the fortress model produces a child who knows what is inside the walls and what is outside the walls but who has never been taught how to think. The child knows the right answers because the right answers were inside the fortress. The child has never been allowed to engage the wrong answers because the wrong answers were outside. When the child encounters the wrong answers for the first time, at college, at work, online, the child has no structure for processing them. They have been protected from the questions. They have never been equipped to handle them. And the questions, when they come, do not feel like an attack on the faith. They feel like the first honest conversation the child has ever had about whether any of this is true.

Third, and worst, the fortress model treats the child as a container

to be filled rather than a person to be formed. The child is a receptacle. Good content goes in. Bad content stays out. The child's own agency, curiosity, doubt, desire, complexity, and interior life are not part of the equation. They are not trusted. They are managed. And a child whose interior life has been managed rather than formed will, at the first possible moment, take ownership of the interior life that was never given to them. That taking of ownership usually looks, from the parent's perspective, like rebellion. It is not rebellion. It is a person becoming a person. The tragedy is that it happens outside the faith because it was never allowed to happen inside it.

I have a different model to offer. It is not new. It is very old. It has been the way faith has actually been passed down for most of Christian history, before the programmatic era, before the age-graded infrastructure, before the assumption that formation is something you do to a child rather than something that happens near a child.

The model is presence. Formed presence, over time, in ordinary rooms.

It works like this. A parent who is being formed by Christ, who is honest about that process, who has a real interior life with God, who allows that interior life to be visible to their children in ordinary moments, who answers hard questions rather than deflecting them, who lets their failures be visible and their repentance be real, who treats the faith not as a performance for the children but as the animating reality of the household, that parent is the primary formation environment. Not the curriculum. Not the church. Not the school. The parent.

This does not mean the parent must be impressive. It means the parent must be real. A parent whose faith is small but honest does more for formation than a parent whose faith is extensive but performed. Children do not need a parent who has all the answers. They need a parent whose life makes the questions worth asking.

There are several problems with the old model, and this book is going to work through them in order. The first problem is that it treats

faith like a transferable body of information rather than a formed way of being. The second is that it positions the parent as a manager of inputs rather than as a person whose own life is the primary curriculum. The third is that it outsources the part of formation that cannot be outsourced. The fourth is that it responds to a child's real questions with a performance of certainty that the child can usually see through by middle school. The fifth is that it mistakes compliance for conviction and treats behavior change as evidence of transformation. The sixth is that it does not reckon with how discipline and correction either form or deform a child's image of God. The seventh is that it does not account for what screens are actually doing to the attention of a human being under the age of eighteen. The eighth is that it ignores the fact that a child's first formation environment is the marriage, not the family devotional. The ninth is that it has no theology for the teenage years, when formation goes underground and the parent must learn a completely different posture. The tenth is that it has let fathers become ornamental. The eleventh is that it has no word for the single parent, the blended family, the grandparent raising grandchildren. The twelfth is that it has no place for the extraordinary role grandparents play in intergenerational faith. The thirteenth is that it does not have a theology for what you do when a child walks away.

All of that is covered in what follows. But underneath every chapter, I want to hold this one sentence in front of you, because everything turns on it.

You cannot give your children a faith you do not have.

If your own faith is thin, if it is running on performance, if it has been reduced to attendance and correct opinions, if you have not wrestled with God in a long time, if you have stopped being genuinely hungry for His presence, then what you pass on to your children is going to be thin faith. Not because they are rejecting anything. Because there is nothing substantial there to reject. You cannot transmit what you do not have.

I learned this the hard way. Not from a book. From watching my own children absorb not what I said but what I was. They did not absorb my sermons. They absorbed my Monday mornings. They did not absorb my theology of prayer. They absorbed whether I actually prayed when nobody was performing. They did not absorb my lectures about the importance of Scripture. They absorbed whether the Bible on my nightstand had been opened that week or whether it was furniture.

Children are the most honest theologians in the house. They are evaluating the adults every day. And they are not evaluating what the adults say. They are evaluating the gap between what the adults say and what the adults are. When the gap is small, faith forms. When the gap is wide, something else forms. Something that looks like faith on the outside and is hollow on the inside. Something that holds until the child is old enough to name what they have been watching.

This is the hope and it is also the cost. The hope is that the most important thing you can do for your children's faith is attend to your own. You do not need a better curriculum. You need a deeper life. The cost is that there is no shortcut. You cannot outsource this. You cannot catch up at age fourteen after twelve years of practical absence. The work of formation begins with the parent's interior life, and it works outward through the texture of a home, and it compounds quietly over years.

This book is for parents who are ready to stop pretending the curriculum is the problem. The curriculum is fine. It is not the issue. The issue is the house the curriculum lands in. The issue is the adults the child has watched since birth. The issue is whether faith is decoration in your home or the load-bearing wall.

I want to say a word about who this book is for, specifically. It is for the parent of young children who wants to start well. It is for the parent of teenagers who feels like they are starting over. It is for the single mother who is doing this alone and who has been told, usually by implication, that her household is incomplete. It is not. It is for the

father who has been present physically and absent spiritually and who is ready to change. It is for the grandparent who has been given a second chance at formation and does not want to waste it. It is for the stepparent who is trying to form faith in children they did not raise from birth and who is walking a line between authority and trust every single day. It is for the parent whose child has already walked away and who needs to know that God is not finished. It is for the married couple whose marriage is the first classroom their children attend and who have not thought about it that way.

All of you are in this book. I have tried to see you. I have tried to speak to your specific grief and your specific hope. If I miss you in places, it is my limitation, not yours. And the core argument applies to every one of you. Faith forms in the ordinary presence of a life that is actually turned toward God. You cannot give your children what you do not have. Start with what you have. Let God grow it. Let your children watch.

I am going to try to be useful. I will give you frameworks where frameworks help. I will give you specific practices where specifics help. I will tell you what I have done well and what I have done badly. I am not writing as an expert. I am writing as one father among many, trying to be faithful with five sons, still learning, still being corrected by God and by my wife and by my own children.

One more thing before we begin. This book does not end with a neat resolution. It cannot. The work of raising believing children is not the kind of work that resolves. It is the kind that continues. It continues past their childhood, past their adolescence, past their leaving home, past your ability to control any outcome. It continues into the years when your only tools are prayer and presence and the open door. This book will prepare you for as much of that road as I can see from where I am standing. The rest of it belongs to God, and His vision is longer than mine.

Turn the page if you are ready to stop looking for a program and start doing something much harder and much older. Turn the page if

you are willing to be the curriculum. Turn the page if you would rather have the truth than the comfortable lie that you can give your children what you have not let God give you.

That is where this begins.

Let me say one more thing before we begin, because the parents who need this book most are the ones most likely to feel disqualified by it.

You have already failed. I do not mean that as a judgment. I mean it as a fact. You have already said the wrong thing at the wrong moment. You have already lost your temper when your child needed your steadiness. You have already been distracted when your child was trying to tell you something that mattered to them. You have already chosen the screen over the conversation, the schedule over the person, the shortcut over the investment. You have failed. So have I. The question is not whether you have failed. The question is whether the failure is the last word.

It is not. And the reason it is not has nothing to do with your competence. It has to do with the grace of a God who has been forming people through imperfect parents since the garden. Abraham lied. Isaac played favorites. Jacob manipulated. Moses lost his temper. David was absent from his sons in the most critical years. And God kept forming a people through every one of them. Not because they were adequate. Because He was.

That does not excuse negligence. It does not make carelessness acceptable. It does mean that the door to faithful parenting is not locked to people who have already blown it. It is open. It has always been open. And the key is not perfection. The key is presence. Imperfect, honest, repentant, faithful presence over years.

I have counseled parents who came to me in their fifties, weeping, because their adult children wanted nothing to do with the faith. Some of those parents had done the best they knew how with the tools they had. Some had been negligent and they knew it. In both

cases, my counsel was the same. It is not too late to become the kind of person your child can find their way back to. It is not too late to pray. It is not too late to change.

One of those parents, a father in his late fifties, had spent his career building a business and his evenings watching television. His children had been raised in church but had never seen their father pray outside a meal. They had never heard him talk about what God meant to him. They had never watched him open a Bible that was not in a pew rack. His faith was real but invisible. And his children, now in their thirties, had concluded that his faith was a social convention rather than a living reality.

He came to me because his youngest daughter had told him, in a conversation that shook him, that she had stopped believing in God. Not because of any argument. Because she had never seen evidence that her father actually believed. He was devastated. And he asked me what he could do.

I told him three things. First, become the man you wish you had been. Not as a strategy to win your daughter back. As an act of obedience to the God who is still forming you. Second, tell your daughter the truth. Tell her you failed. Tell her your faith was real but you hid it, and hiding it was wrong. Third, pray for her every single day, by name, with specificity, and do not stop. He did all three. His daughter has not returned to the faith as I write this. But the father is a different man. And the door is open. It has been open for three years. And the daughter knows it is open because the father has become the kind of man who keeps the door open.

This book is for that father as much as it is for the mother of a toddler. It is for the parent who has time and for the parent who feels they have already run out of it. The principles in these chapters are not age-locked. They work in the home with a newborn and in the conversation with a thirty-year-old. Because formation is not a program that expires. It is a way of being that God can use at any point in the story.

I will say one more thing about what this book is not. It is not a guarantee. I cannot promise that if you follow every principle in these pages your children will walk with Jesus into adulthood. I know families who did everything right, or close to it, and their children walked away. I know families who did almost nothing deliberate and their children are among the most faithful believers I have met. The sovereignty of God is real, and it means that the outcome is not entirely in your hands. What is in your hands is the soil. You can tend the soil. You can pull the weeds. You can water the ground. Whether the seed sprouts and grows to full height is between the seed and the God who made it.

That should be both humbling and liberating. Humbling because you cannot guarantee the result. Liberating because you do not have to. Your job is faithfulness. God's job is the harvest. And the best thing you can do for that harvest is to become the kind of soil where faith has the best chance of taking root.

Now turn the page. We have rooms to walk through.

CHAPTER 1

What We Mean When We Say Formation

There is a word we throw around in Christian parenting circles, and most of the time we are using it to mean something it does not mean. The word is formation. We use it as a dressed-up synonym for teaching, or for discipline, or sometimes for the whole package of Sunday school and family devotions and good habits. But formation is something older and stranger than any of that, and if we are going to raise children in the faith, we need to recover what it actually is.

Formation is what happens to a human being who spends years near a particular kind of presence. It is slower than teaching. It is deeper than behavior. It does not produce outputs on a predictable timeline. You cannot measure it in a catechism quiz. You recognize it later, when you notice that a person thinks a certain way, responds a certain way, carries a certain weight, and you realize they did not get that from any single lesson. They got it from a life lived near other lives, over years, in a particular direction.

Name it honestly. Most Christian parents are running an education strategy and calling it formation. The strategy goes like this. Get the right content into the child. Protect the child from the wrong content. Structure enough repetition to make the content stick. Hope the content becomes conviction. That is education. It is not formation. It can be part of formation, but it is never the whole of it, and when it is treated as the whole of it, it produces children who know the right answers and have no interior connection to the God those answers describe.

I want to trace this confusion, because it matters. Somewhere in

the second half of the twentieth century, American evangelicalism made a decisive turn toward information as the primary vehicle of spiritual growth. There were reasons for this. The fundamentalist-modernist controversy of the early 1900s had produced a Christianity that was suspicious of experience, suspicious of mystery, suspicious of anything that could not be printed on a doctrinal statement. The way you knew someone was Christian was that they believed the right propositions. The way you formed a Christian child was that you got the right propositions into them early enough and often enough that the propositions stuck.

This was not entirely wrong. Doctrine matters. Content matters. A child who grows up with no biblical knowledge is not formed in the faith. But the emphasis on information did something the information advocates did not intend. It reduced the Christian life to a set of ideas to be believed rather than a way of being to be inhabited. And when you reduce the Christian life to ideas, you can deliver it through programs, because programs are how you deliver ideas. You can age-grade it. You can put it in a workbook. You can test for comprehension. You can measure it. The entire infrastructure of children's ministry in the American church was built on this assumption. Give them the right information at the right developmental stage, and formation will follow.

Formation did not follow. Not because the information was wrong. Because information is not formation.

I grew up without a father. I did not grow up Christian. I came to faith in college, through a roommate who did not lecture me and a visitor to our apartment who answered my actual questions rather than the questions he wished I were asking. What shaped my early faith was not a curriculum. It was being near people who were believing in a way I had not encountered before. They lived near me. I watched how they handled disappointment. I watched how they treated women. I watched how they talked about money. I watched how they prayed when they thought I was not listening. That was formation. The content came later. The formation came first.

The early church understood this. Before there were catechism books, before there were Sunday school curricula, before there were children's Bibles with cartoon illustrations, there was the catechumenate. The catechumenate was the process by which a person was formed into the faith over a period of one to three years. It included instruction, yes. But the instruction was embedded in a life. The catechumen lived among believers. They watched believers pray. They watched believers fast. They watched believers serve the poor. They watched believers suffer. They watched believers die well. The formation happened in the watching. The instruction named what the watching had already been teaching.

When Paul wrote to Timothy, he did not say, I taught you the right content and therefore you are formed. He said, you have followed my teaching, my conduct, my aim in life, my faith, my patience, my love, my steadfastness, my persecutions, my sufferings. That is a formation inventory. Teaching is first on the list. But the list does not stop there. The list includes conduct, aim, faith, patience, love, steadfastness. It includes suffering. Timothy was formed by proximity to a life. The teaching was part of the formation. It was not the formation itself.

Now consider how most Christian households operate. The parents have the content. They have the Bibles, they have the podcasts, they have the sermons, they have the small group material. The children are exposed to the content. But the children are not forming near believing parents so much as they are forming near parents who attend Christian events. There is a difference. A parent can be in Christian spaces every week and not have a formed interior life. A child raised near that parent receives the externals without the center, and the externals without the center is precisely the recipe for what we used to call pharisaism and now call church culture.

I have watched this play out for twenty years in pastoral ministry. The families where the children's faith has gone the distance are not the families that attended the most programs. They are the families where the parents had an actual life with God that was visible in ordinary moments. Where the father prayed and the children could

hear it. Where the mother opened her Bible on a Tuesday morning because she wanted to, not because anyone was watching. Where a crisis was met with real faith rather than Christian platitudes. Where a failure was met with real confession rather than blame-shifting. Where the home had a center that was not anxiety or performance or appearance but Christ, actually, in the mundane operations of a household.

Reframe it. Formation is not something you do to a child. It is something that happens in proximity. Proximity to what. Proximity to a life that is actually being lived under the lordship of Christ. Your kitchen is a formation space. Your car on the way to school is a formation space. The way you treat your spouse at seven fifteen in the morning is a formation space. The way you respond to the email from your boss that you did not want to receive is a formation space. Your child is reading all of it. The child reads what you actually are, not what you say you are, because the child has been watching you long enough to know the difference.

That is why formation is terrifying. You cannot fake it over the timeline a child has with you. You can fake it on Sunday morning in front of people who see you two hours a week. You cannot fake it in front of a seven-year-old who has watched you for two thousand five hundred days. The child knows. The child knows whether prayer in your home is a ritual that adults perform for the child's benefit or whether the adults in this house actually pray. The child knows whether the Bible is a reference book that gets pulled out for arguments or whether it is a book that the parent is being shaped by. The child knows whether church is performance for you or whether it is where you go because something in you is hungry for God.

This does not mean your interior life has to be impressive. It means it has to be real. A parent whose faith is small but honest does more for formation than a parent whose faith is extensive but performative. The child is not impressed by theological vocabulary. The child is watching for alignment. When the words the parent says about God line up with the way the parent is actually living,

something forms. When they do not line up, something also forms, but it is the thing we are all grieving in the generation leaving the church right now. They did not leave because the teaching was too demanding. They left because the teaching and the life did not match and they noticed.

Let me push this further. Formation is happening at all times, in all directions. You are not choosing whether to form your children. You are choosing in which direction. A home that runs on anxiety is forming anxious children. A home that runs on performance is forming performers. A home that runs on conflict avoidance is forming people who will not name truth when it costs them. A home that runs on consumption is forming consumers. None of those parents intended to form those things. They did not set out to teach their children anxiety or performance or avoidance. They did not have to. The household was the curriculum. The children absorbed it the way they absorbed language. Without effort. Without choice. By immersion.

This is why the formation of a child begins with the formation of the parent. I will say it a dozen times in this book because it cannot be said too often. The parent's own walk with Christ is not a private devotional matter. It is the soil in which the child's faith will grow or will not. A parent who is being sanctified, slowly, honestly, visibly, creates a different household than a parent who is performing sanctification. The child does not know the word sanctification. The child knows whether the parent is changing.

Here is the part I have to say because I need to hear it myself. You cannot curriculum your way out of your own lack of life with God. You can buy better books. You can enroll in better schools. You can join better churches. None of that touches the problem if the problem is that your own walk with Jesus has flattened out. Children form around the center of a parent's actual life. If the center is work, they will form around work. If the center is appearance, they will form around appearance. If the center is Christ, they will form around Christ. The center is not what you say it is. It is what your week

actually shows.

I want to name a particular failure I have seen in pastors' homes, including my own. Pastors are professionally Christian. Their work is Christ. Their calendar is church. Their social network is believers. It is easy for a pastor's child to conclude that the faith is a vocation rather than a life. The child watches the father prepare sermons, lead Bible studies, counsel the hurting, pray over the sick. And the child asks, perhaps not aloud: does Dad believe this, or is this what Dad does for a living. The distinction is crucial. I have had to work, deliberately, to let my sons see me as a believer and not only as a professional believer. They need to see me pray when I am not preparing to lead a meeting. They need to see me read Scripture when I am not preparing a sermon. They need to see me repent when the only person I have wronged is their mother. They need to see a man who follows Jesus at home, on a Tuesday, when the collar is off and the office is closed.

The costly hope in this chapter is small and heavy. It is that formation in your children is doable. Not easy, not quick, not guaranteed. But doable. Because the lever is not external to you. The lever is the thing you already have direct access to, which is your own life before God. You cannot control what your children will choose when they are grown. You can only be the kind of person near whom formation in a Christlike direction is more likely than not. You can only be honest instead of performative, hungry instead of settled, present instead of distracted, and slow to anger when the children press on the places your flesh wants to hide.

That is what formation is. Proximity to a formed life. Over years. In ordinary rooms. With a thousand small honesties along the way.

I want to give you a picture of what formation looks like in practice, because the concept can feel abstract. Let me describe two mornings in two different homes. Both Christian. Both with children under ten.

In the first home, the alarm goes off and the household

immediately enters management mode. The parent is on the phone before their feet touch the floor. Breakfast is functional. The conversation, such as it is, is about logistics. Who needs to be where. What needs to be signed. The parent is tense because they are late. The children absorb the tension. Nobody prays. Nobody mentions God. The Bible on the counter is under a stack of mail. The parent drops the children at school with a hurried goodbye and drives to work listening to a podcast about productivity. The morning has catechized the children in a theology of urgency. The world is demanding. There is not enough time. The most important thing is efficiency. God is not in the morning. God is somewhere else, for later.

In the second home, the alarm goes off and the household wakes up at roughly the same speed. The parent is tired. The morning is not serene. There is still cereal to pour and permission slips to find. But somewhere in the first fifteen minutes, the parent pauses. Not for a long time. For ninety seconds. The parent says, out loud, at the table: Lord, thank you for this day. Be with these boys today. Help me be patient. The children hear it. They do not respond. They are eating cereal. But they hear it. The parent is not performing a devotional. The parent is doing what the parent does every morning, which is taking thirty seconds to orient the household toward God before the logistics take over. On the drive to school, the parent asks the child about something the child mentioned the night before. Not school. Something personal. The child, surprised at being remembered, opens up for two minutes. The parent listens. The morning has catechized the children in a different theology. God is in the morning. The parent is paying attention. My interior life matters to the adult.

Neither of those mornings is dramatic. Neither will be remembered by the child as a specific event. But multiply each one by a thousand, and you have two entirely different formation environments. The first produces a child who sees God as an addition to an already full life. The second produces a child who sees God as the orienting reality of the household.

Formation is what a thousand mornings do. It is not what one sermon says. It is the accumulated weight of a life lived in a particular direction, and the child, who is in the room for all of it, absorbs the direction even when they are not paying attention.

I have heard parents say that they do not have time for formation. That life is too busy. That the schedule does not allow for it. I understand the feeling. I have felt it myself, many times. But the objection misunderstands what formation is. Formation is not an additional activity you add to the schedule. Formation is the character of the activities already in your schedule. It is not thirty minutes of devotions added to an otherwise secular day. It is the way you are present in the day you already have. You are already forming your children every hour they are with you. The only question is in which direction.

Before we go further, I want to name what this chapter is not saying. It is not saying that teaching does not matter. It does. Content matters. Scripture matters. Doctrine matters. What this chapter is saying is that teaching without formation produces a child who can defend a position they do not actually hold. And formation without teaching produces a child with a warm sense of spirituality and no structure to carry them when the world presses hard. The two belong together. But if I had to choose which one comes first, I would say formation. Because you can add teaching to a formed child later. You cannot add formation to a person who has been content-fed all their life without it. That person has to start over as an adult, and most of them do not.

Let me give you one more image. A child raised on formation without content is like a tree that grows strong but does not know its own species. It needs instruction. It needs to learn the name and shape of the thing it already is. That instruction comes, and when it comes, it confirms what the child already knew in their bones. A child raised on content without formation is like a blueprint without a house. The plans are precise. The specs are correct. But nobody built anything. The child has all the information and no structure to live in.

When the wind comes, the blueprint does not shelter anyone.

Build the house. Let the blueprint serve the house. Let the formation come first, and let the content fill the space the formation has opened.

So this is where we are starting. Formation is what your life is doing to your children in the rooms where nobody is performing. We will spend the next chapters in those rooms. The kitchen. The car. The pre-sleep conversation. The question you did not want to answer. The failure you had to own. The day your child saw you cry. That is where the faith forms or it does not.

Let us go into those rooms now.

But before we do, I want to address one more thing that I see in nearly every conversation I have with Christian parents about formation. The comparison trap.

You know what it is. You look at another family and you see what appears to be a seamlessly formed household. The children are polite. They quote Scripture. They lead worship at youth group. The parents seem calm. The home seems ordered. And you look at your own household, where the morning was chaos and the evening ended in tears and the Bible reading lasted four minutes before someone spilled milk on the table, and you think: we are failing.

You are not failing. You are comparing your interior to their exterior. You are comparing your Tuesday morning to their Sunday morning. You are comparing your actual life to the curated version of theirs that you are permitted to see. And the comparison is poisoning your ability to see what God is actually doing in your own home.

I have been inside both kinds of homes. The ones that look formed from the outside and the ones that feel chaotic from the inside. And I can tell you, from twenty years of pastoral observation, that the correlation between external polish and internal formation is weaker than you think. Some of the most polished-looking Christian families I have known produced children who walked away from the

faith the moment they left home. Because the formation was cosmetic. It was behavior management dressed in spiritual language. And some of the most chaotic, struggling, imperfect households I have known produced children whose faith is as deep as bedrock. Because the formation was real. It was messy and inconsistent and often interrupted by spilled milk. But the center held. And the center was not the parents' competence. The center was Christ, actually present, in the middle of the mess.

Stop comparing your home to the home that looks better from the outside. Start asking the questions that actually matter. Is Christ the center of this household, not in theory but in practice. Do my children see me turn to God when I am afraid. Do my children hear me pray when nothing is wrong. Do my children know that they are loved with a love that is not contingent on their performance. Those are the formation questions. And you can answer them honestly without looking at anyone else's home.

I want to name something else I see in parents that blocks formation before it starts. Fear. Specifically, fear that they will do it wrong. Fear that they will say the wrong thing about God. Fear that they will mishandle a theological question. Fear that their own doubts disqualify them from forming their children's faith.

That fear is understandable. It is also paralyzing. And it is based on a misunderstanding of what formation requires. Formation does not require theological expertise. It requires theological honesty. Your child does not need a parent who has every answer. Your child needs a parent who is honest about what they know, honest about what they do not know, and honest about where they go when the questions outrun the answers. A parent who says, I do not know, but let us find out together, is forming a child who believes that God is big enough for hard questions. A parent who pretends to know everything is forming a child who will eventually discover the pretense and wonder what else was fake.

I remember a conversation with my second son when he was

eight. He asked me if God could make a rock so big that He could not lift it. He had heard the question somewhere and it fascinated him. I could have given him the standard philosophical answer about the logical coherence of omnipotence. I did not. I said, that is a question philosophers have asked for a long time, and the short answer is that the question itself is built wrong, like asking if God can make a square circle. But here is what I want you to know. The fact that you are asking hard questions about God means your mind is working the way God designed it to work. Keep asking. I will always try to answer, and when I cannot, we will look for the answer together.

He does not remember that conversation. I remember it because it was one of the moments when I chose honesty over performance. I chose to let him see that his father thinks about hard things and does not pretend they are easy. That was formation. Not the content of the answer. The posture of the answerer.

Your home is a formation space. It became one the day your child entered it. The only question is what it is forming. And the answer to that question begins with you, the parent, and the God you are actually walking with when no one is watching.

Let us go into the rooms where that walking happens. The catechism room is first.

CHAPTER 2

The Home Is the Primary Catechism

There is a very old word that Christian parents should recover. The word is catechism. Most Protestants have forgotten it, and the ones who have kept it tend to treat it as a formal document, a book of questions and answers that a child learns by repetition. That is one meaning. It is not the deepest one. The deepest meaning of catechism is the shaping of a person through rhythms of teaching and life that form what they believe at the level below argument. In that older sense, every home is a catechism. The only question is which one.

Your children are being catechized from the day they are born. If they are in your home, you are the primary catechist. You are not the only one. The culture is catechizing them. Their friends are catechizing them. The algorithms they scroll through are catechizing them with great efficiency. But before all of those, for the critical early years of a child's life, the catechist is the household. Your house is teaching your children something every single day about what reality is. The question is whether what it is teaching them is true.

Let me be concrete, because this is the chapter where we start naming specifics. A household's catechism is communicated through four channels, running at all times, whether you intend them or not. The first is what the family praises. The second is what the family worries about. The third is what the family repeats. The fourth is what the family rests in.

Take the first. Children notice what their parents praise. Watch a child's eyes when a parent lights up. The child is learning what is worth lighting up about. If the parent lights up about money, the child learns that money is the thing. If the parent lights up about academic performance, the child learns that academic performance is the thing.

If the parent lights up when the child is kind, when the child is honest, when the child is courageous for the sake of someone weaker, the child learns something entirely different. I am not saying you should never celebrate a good grade. I am saying the pattern of your celebration is teaching. Your praise is a catechism.

I have watched this work in both directions. I knew a family in one of my earlier churches where the father was a successful businessman. Every achievement the children brought home was measured against the father's standard of excellence, which was high. The praise flowed when the children performed at the top of their class, when they won the game, when they got the lead in the school play. The father was not cruel. He was enthusiastic. He loved his children. And his enthusiasm, over years, catechized his children into a theology of performance. God loved you when you performed. God was pleased when you achieved. When one of those children hit a season of failure in their twenties, their faith collapsed, because the god they had been catechized to worship was a god who rewarded performance, and they had stopped performing. The father never said that. His house said it for him.

I knew another family where the mother praised character. When her daughter told the truth about something that would have been easier to hide, the mother stopped what she was doing, knelt to the girl's level, and said, that is the kind of person God is making you into, and I am proud of you. That was not a formula. It was a reflex. And the reflex was catechizing the child, day after day, in a theology of character that had nothing to do with output and everything to do with who the child was becoming. That girl is in her late twenties now. She is still walking with Jesus. She will tell you her mother's voice is still the loudest one in the room when she has to make a hard decision.

Take the second. Children read what their parents worry about. They are often more attuned to parental anxiety than parents realize. A child knows when you are stressed about the mortgage even if you have never said the word mortgage in front of them. A child knows

when you are anxious about a social situation, when you are afraid of a particular person's opinion, when you are obsessed with how your life looks to others. And children assume, rightly, that the things their parents worry about are the things that are actually worth worrying about. The content of the worry becomes the content of the child's imagined threat picture. If the home worries about appearance, children grow up afraid of being seen wrong. If the home worries about status, children grow up afraid of being passed over. If the home quietly entrusts these things to God, children learn that there is a Father who holds what the world told them to grip.

Let me tell you what worry catechizes in a child. It catechizes the nature of God. A worried household is teaching, at the catechism level, that God is not trustworthy. That the world is in the end in the hands of forces God cannot control. That the parent must grip tighter because letting go is too dangerous. A child raised in that home may learn all the right verses about trusting God. They will believe the worry. Because the worry was the catechism that ran all day, and the verses were the correction that ran for fifteen minutes at bedtime.

This does not mean you must never worry. It means you must bring the worry somewhere your children can see. When you are afraid and you take that fear to God, out loud, in the kitchen, where your child can hear you say, Lord, I am anxious about this, and I am bringing it to You because I cannot carry it, you are catechizing your child in the nature of God. You are teaching them, at the level below argument, that there is a Father who receives fear and does something with it. That catechism will run longer and louder than the anxiety, if you practice it.

Take the third. Children remember what the family repeats. Not what it says once. What it says a thousand times. The prayer over the food that stumbles out the same way every evening. The verse the mother quotes when something breaks. The phrase the father uses when he apologizes. The song that plays in the car. The way Sunday morning starts. These are the liturgies of a household, and they do their work below the level of conscious memory. My own children

will repeat phrases I have said for decades without knowing they are mine. The words will come out of their mouths under pressure, and they will not remember where they heard them. That is catechism. It is not content delivery. It is repetition that becomes reflex.

James K. A. Smith calls these liturgies. I find the word helpful. A liturgy is a repeated practice that forms desire. The church has understood this for two thousand years. When you repeat the Lord's Prayer weekly, you are not delivering information. You are forming a people whose desires are being shaped by the prayer, even when they are not paying full attention. The same principle operates in a home. When you repeat a blessing over your children before bed, you are not delivering information. You are forming a child whose sense of identity is being shaped by the blessing, even when they are half asleep. When you sing the same hymn in the car on the way to church, you are forming their emotional association with worship before they understand what worship is.

The danger of repetition is that it becomes empty. The grace before meals that nobody means. The bedtime prayer that is recited while the parent's foot is already out the door. Children know when the repetition has become hollow. They are not fooled by it. They are catechized by it, but what they learn from hollow repetition is that the words do not matter. That the rituals are performances. That the adults do not actually believe what they are saying.

The correction is not to stop repeating. It is to mean what you repeat. If the blessing before the meal has become rote, stop one night and say it fresh. Look your child in the eye and thank God, specifically, for the food, for the family, for the day, for the particular mercy that was visible that afternoon. Let the child see that the words are connected to something real. That is catechism. The words are the same. The life behind them makes them either empty or full.

Take the fourth. Children learn what is trustworthy by watching what their parents rest in. When the parent is exhausted, what does the parent turn to. When the parent is afraid, what does the parent

reach for. When the parent needs comfort, where does the parent go. Children are not fooled by stated values. They are watching the parent's rest, because rest reveals the true god of a household. If the parent rests in scrolling, in wine, in the next purchase, in the praise of a certain person, the child is receiving a theology of rest. If the parent rests in prayer, in the presence of God, in scripture, in the company of people who genuinely love them, the child is receiving a different theology.

I want to press on this one because it is the most revealing of the four. A household's resting point tells you more about its actual theology than its stated theology ever will. The parent who collapses into a screen every evening is not bad. They are tired. But the child is watching where the tired parent goes, and the child is learning where to go when they are tired. The parent who collapses into prayer, even briefly, even imperfectly, even while exhausted, is teaching the child something about where the weight goes. I have told my sons, more than once, I am too tired tonight to do much, but I am going to take this to God before I go to sleep. That is not impressive. That is honest. And honesty at the point of exhaustion is catechism.

So a household catechism is built from four materials. What you praise. What you worry about. What you repeat. What you rest in. The child is writing a book inside them whose chapters are constructed from those four. And the book the child finishes is the book they will enter adulthood with.

Now the reframe. Most Christian parents have tried to add content to the catechism without addressing the four channels above. They sit their children down for devotions at seven in the evening while the household runs all day on anxiety, appearance, and performance. The child receives mixed signal. Mom praises grades and mentions Jesus. Dad worries about work and says God is in control. The family repeats platitudes that the family does not actually live. The family rests in the phone. And then at seven PM, everyone opens a Bible together for fifteen minutes. The children receive the data. The catechism has already been written.

This is why so many adults leave the faith of their childhood and say they do not know why. They know why. They were catechized by a household that was running two catechisms simultaneously. One of them was explicit. The other was implicit. The explicit one said God is central. The implicit one said God is peripheral. The two could not both be true, so when the child grew up, they had to pick which one had been real. They usually picked the implicit one, because implicit lessons feel more honest than explicit ones. That is not rebellion. That is integrity. They believed what the household actually taught.

I want to name something I have seen in my own home that illustrates this. There was a period, several years ago, when Susanna and I were running hard. Ministry was demanding. The boys were at ages where everything required logistics. We were physically present and spiritually depleted. We kept doing the family devotional. We kept saying the prayers. But the boys could tell something had changed. Not in the devotional. In us. We were more irritable. We were more distracted. We were quicker to snap and slower to repair. The implicit catechism was drowning the explicit one. And our oldest, who has a gift for directness that I suspect he inherited from me, said one night at dinner: you guys seem different lately. Not bad. Tired. That was the kindest version of what he could have said. What he meant was: the thing you say is real does not seem to be reaching you right now, and I can tell.

That was a turning point. Susanna and I sat down the next week and made a decision that changed more in our home than any curriculum change could have. We decided that we would tend our own souls first. Before the family devotional. Before the children's ministry. Before the church calendar. We would get our own lives with God back into a sustainable, honest place. We started praying together again, as a couple, not for the family but for ourselves. We started reading Scripture again, not to prepare for anything but to be near God. And as that happened, the four channels of the household catechism began to shift. Not because we added a program. Because the adults in the house changed what they were resting in.

The costly hope is this. A parent can rewrite the household catechism. Slowly. Not by adding a program. By paying attention to the four channels and beginning to align them with the thing the household says it believes. Praise what is worth praising, and do it in front of the children. Let them hear you say, when your son tells the truth about something hard, that you are proud of him because that is the kind of man God is building him into. Worry less aloud, and when you do worry, take it to God in a way the children can hear. Not a performance. An actual prayer in the kitchen. Let the family repetitions become load-bearing. Say a particular blessing over them before they sleep. Pray the same prayer before trips. Read the same passage at the same table on Sunday evenings. Let the rhythms compound. And change what you rest in. Let them see you close the laptop and open the Bible, not every night, but often enough to count.

This is not a program. It is a repair of the channels that are already running. None of it requires a new curriculum. All of it requires honesty about what the house is currently teaching.

Let me give you a practical exercise, because I do not want to leave this chapter in the abstract. Take one week. Seven days. During those seven days, pay attention to the four channels in your household. Write it down if that helps. What did you praise in front of your children this week. What did you worry about aloud this week. What phrases did you repeat. Where did you go for rest when you were depleted. Do not judge what you find. Observe it. Because what you find is the catechism your household is currently running.

When I did this exercise for the first time, several years ago, I was startled by what I found. I found that I praised achievement far more than I praised character. I found that I worried aloud about money and time more than I trusted aloud about God's provision. I found that the phrases I repeated most were hurry up and not now and we will talk about it later. And I found that when I was spent at the end of the day, I reached for the screen before I reached for anything else. None of that was what I would have said my household catechism was. It was what it was.

Susanna and I sat with that for a while. We did not overhaul the household overnight. We chose one channel to work on at a time. We started with praise. We decided that every day, at least once, we would praise character in front of the boys rather than performance. We would name when one of them was kind. We would name when one of them was honest. We would name when one of them was brave in a situation where it would have been easier to be silent. That one shift, sustained over months, changed the feel of the house. Not because we had a new program. Because we were paying attention to a channel that had been running on autopilot.

Then we worked on worry. This one was harder because worry is reflexive. You do not decide to worry aloud. It escapes. But we began to practice something deliberate. When one of us caught ourselves worrying in front of the boys, we would follow it with a pivot. I am worried about this. And I am bringing it to God because He is the one who holds what I cannot. That is not a formula. It is a discipline. And the boys began to hear it enough that the pivot became part of the household's vocabulary. One of my sons, at age ten, said to his younger brother during a thunderstorm: it is okay to be scared. Dad says you bring the scared thing to God. He had absorbed the catechism.

The repetition channel was the easiest to change because it was the most concrete. We chose three phrases we wanted to become load-bearing in the household. The first was the Aaronic blessing, spoken over the boys before bed. The Lord bless you and keep you. The second was a question we began asking at dinner: where did you see God today. Not every night. Often enough that the boys expected it. The third was a sentence Susanna began saying to each boy in the morning: God has a plan for you today. These repetitions, sustained over years, are now embedded in my sons. They will carry those phrases into their own households one day, whether they know it or not. That is catechism.

The rest channel is the one we are still working on. It is the hardest because it touches the deepest part of us. Where do I go for

rest when I am depleted. If the honest answer is the phone, the television, or the pantry, then that is what my children are learning is the resting place. Changing that answer requires me to change myself, and that is the deepest work of all.

Now the hard part. The reason most parents resist this is that it implicates the parent. You cannot change the household catechism without changing the household. You cannot change what the household praises without changing what you yourself praise. You cannot change what it worries about without changing what you worry about. You cannot change what it rests in without changing where you yourself go for rest. Every one of these channels reveals the interior life of the adults. And that is the thing most of us do not want to reveal.

A parent who wants to raise a child in the faith has to come to terms with this. The house will catechize the child either way. The only question is whether it will catechize them toward Christ or away from Him. That is not a question of content. That is a question of alignment. It is a question that points inward before it points outward.

I am not writing as a man who has nailed this. I am writing as a man who has been confronted, again and again, with the gap between the catechism my sons say we have and the catechism my weekly life actually teaches them. When the gap narrows, formation follows. When it widens, nothing I say from a pulpit can fix it, and nothing a Sunday school teacher says can fix it either.

The household is the first and most honest seminary a Christian will ever attend. Most of us graduated from ours before we could speak. It is worth asking, slowly, with humility, what was the curriculum. And then, with as much humility, what is the curriculum in my own house now.

I want to add one more observation about the household catechism before we move on, because it touches something I have not named yet. The catechism of a household is not static. It changes. It changes when the family goes through a crisis. It changes when a

parent loses a job. It changes when someone gets sick. It changes when a child enters a new developmental stage and the dynamics of the home shift. The household catechism you ran when your children were toddlers is not the same one you are running when they are twelve. And the parent who pays attention to the shift can adapt the four channels to the new reality rather than running the old catechism on autopilot into a situation it no longer fits.

I noticed this in my own home when our boys hit adolescence. The catechism that had worked when they were small, the bedtime blessing, the dinner question, the Saturday morning Scripture reading, began to feel different. Not wrong. Different. The boys were changing. Their capacity for depth was growing. Their tolerance for routine was shrinking. And the catechism needed to grow with them.

We made changes. The bedtime blessing stayed because it was non-negotiable in our house, but it became shorter and more personal. Instead of a formal prayer over each boy, I started saying one sentence tailored to what that boy was carrying that day. The dinner question evolved from where did you see God today to something more probing. What was the hardest thing about today. What are you afraid of right now. What made you angry this week. Those questions opened doors that the simpler question had stopped opening. And the Saturday morning Scripture reading became a conversation. I stopped reading to them and started reading with them, asking what they thought, letting them disagree with me, letting the text be alive rather than recited.

The point is this. The four channels are permanent. What you praise, what you worry about, what you repeat, what you rest in. Those channels run for the life of the household. But the content that flows through those channels must adapt. A parent who is paying attention to their children, who is watching what the children need at each stage, who is willing to let the catechism mature as the children mature, is a parent whose household stays alive rather than becoming a museum of practices that used to work.

I have seen families lose their teenagers because the parents refused to adapt the catechism. The practices that formed the children at six were enforced at sixteen with no modification. The teenager, who needed depth and conversation and room to question, was given the same simple routine they had outgrown years ago. The teenager did not reject the faith. They rejected the version of the faith that was too small for who they were becoming. And the parents, who could not tell the difference, treated the rejection of the small version as a rejection of God.

Do not let that happen. Watch your children. Listen to what they are telling you, with their words and with their silence. Let the catechism grow as they grow. The channels stay the same. The content evolves. And the household that evolves with its children is the household that keeps the conversation alive through every stage.

The next chapter is for the parents who read that and thought: that is the church's job. I want to answer that one directly.

CHAPTER 3

When the Church Replaces the Parent

I am a pastor. I need to say that twice in the opening of this chapter because of what I am about to argue. I lead a local church. I love the local church. I have given my adult life to a particular congregation in a small Michigan town. And I am going to tell you that if you have handed the spiritual formation of your children to the church you attend, you have made a quiet mistake, and the church has too often been happy to receive what it was never built to carry.

Name it. Over the last fifty years, American evangelicalism quietly restructured itself on the assumption that spiritual formation of children is primarily the church's job. It built a whole infrastructure to do this job. Age-graded Sunday school. Children's church. Vacation Bible School. Awana. Mid-week kids programs. Youth group for middle school and high school. Christian summer camp. Retreats. Mission trips. Every one of those is good in the right proportion. The mistake was not in building them. The mistake was in building them in a way that let parents think this infrastructure was the formation, and that their job was to deliver their children to it on time.

I watch parents do this every week. They drop off a kindergartner on Sunday morning like they are dropping off a dry cleaning ticket. They pick up a fifth grader at the end of Wednesday night Awana and ask what he earned. They sign a youth retreat permission slip without ever asking what the retreat is covering. They are investing in their children's spiritual life by paying the registration fees and running the carpool. And when those children hit eighteen, twenty, twenty-two, and step away from the faith, the parents are devastated and they ask: what did we do wrong. And the honest answer is hard. You did everything you were told to do. What you were told to do was never

going to produce what you were hoping for.

Let me tell you how this happened, because it did not happen by accident. The explosion of children's and youth ministry in the second half of the twentieth century was driven by good intentions and market logic. The good intention was to reach young people with the gospel. The market logic was that specialized, age-appropriate programming would do this better than general worship services. Both of those things are partially true. Young people do need to hear the gospel in language they can receive. Age-appropriate teaching does have value. But the market logic carried an assumption that nobody challenged, which was that professional ministry workers, with training and curricula, could form children more effectively than parents could. The parent became the delivery system. The professional became the formator.

Think about what that communicated to the average Christian parent over three generations. It communicated that spiritual formation is specialized work. That it requires training the parent does not have. That the parent's role is logistical, not formational. Get the child to the program. The program will do the work. The parent supports the program by volunteering, by giving, by reinforcing at home what the program teaches. But the program is the center. The parent is the support staff.

That is backwards. It has always been backwards. And we are now living in the wreckage of a fifty-year experiment that proved it was backwards, because the generation that was formed primarily in church programs rather than in homes is the generation that is leaving the faith at historically unprecedented rates. Not because the programs were bad. Because the programs were carrying a weight they were never designed to carry. A youth pastor with forty students, two hours a week, and a six-year window cannot undo or redirect sixteen years of whatever the home has been teaching. The math does not work. It never did.

Here is the math most Christian parents have never done. Add up

every hour a child is in church programming from birth to age eighteen. Be generous. Sunday morning service plus Sunday school, two hours. Mid-week program, two hours. VBS one week a year, fifteen hours. Youth retreat, forty-eight hours. Camp, a hundred hours. Stack it all up across eighteen years. You will come to somewhere between two thousand and four thousand hours if the family is extremely consistent. Most families are not that consistent. Call it three thousand on the high end. That sounds like a lot until you do the other side of the equation. How many hours is a child in the home from birth to eighteen. Not present in the house. Awake, in proximity to a parent. Call it thirty-five thousand hours on the low end. More, realistically. A well-attended child is receiving ten times as much formation at home as they are at church. That is not a comparison. That is a structural reality. The home is the main event. The church is a complement to it, not a replacement for it.

Most of you reading this know that in your bones. The problem is you have been trained out of acting on it. You have been subtly led, over years, to believe that you are not qualified. The qualified people are the youth pastor, the children's director, the small group leader, the curriculum writer. You are a parent. Parents hand their children to the qualified people and the qualified people form them. That is the model. And it is a bad model because it assumes the child primarily forms in programmatic environments rather than in the ordinary weight of a home.

I want to name what I have seen from the pastoral side of this, because it adds a dimension most parents do not see. I have watched gifted children's workers burn out year after year, not because the work was too hard but because the expectation was impossible. The expectation, unspoken but real, was that these workers would produce spiritually mature children out of homes that were not doing the primary work. A children's ministry leader once told me, with tears, I cannot build in two hours what goes unbuilt the other hundred and sixty-six hours of the week. She was right. And she was carrying a burden that belonged to the parents.

I have also watched youth pastors absorb the blame when a student walked away from the faith. The parents looked at the youth pastor. The youth pastor looked at the parents. Neither of them said what was true, which was that the student's faith had been eroding at home for years, that the youth group had been the one place it was still alive, and that when the student left the youth group, the faith left too, because it had no roots outside the program. The program had been the faith. The home had been something else.

Reframe it. The church is not the primary catechist of your child. The church is the assembly of believers, including you, gathered around word and sacrament and mission. Your child belongs in that assembly, learns from that assembly, is shaped by that assembly. But the assembly is not a parenting replacement. It is a parenting context. The congregation is the extended family within which you are doing the primary work. Not the contractor you hired to do the work on your behalf.

When parents understand this, two things change. The first is that they stop expecting the youth pastor to do the impossible. A good youth pastor has forty students, forty different family contexts, maybe two hours a week of programmed time with each one, and a limited window before those students graduate. Ask yourself whether two hours a week for six years is enough to undo or redirect sixteen previous years of family-formed assumptions about what life is for. It is not. It never was. You are not being fair to the youth pastor. You are also not being fair to your child, because your child is carrying an expectation, communicated to them by you, that this is where their formation happens. It is not. And when it does not produce the results you hoped for, you blame the church, and the church quietly wonders why the Christian home has stopped functioning as a Christian home.

The second thing that changes is that parents begin to see the church not as a vendor but as a partner. You bring your children into the life of the congregation not to outsource, but to reinforce what you are already doing at home. You want your children near other believing adults, not because you are delegating the teaching, but

because you want them to see that your house is not the only house where Christ is Lord. You want them in a room with other people singing, because you want them to hear that your faith is not a private family quirk. You want them around older believers, because your mother-in-law has been walking with God for forty years and you have been walking with Him for eight, and the older saints are a gift your household can borrow from. You are not outsourcing. You are integrating.

Let me say it differently. The church is the community in which your home's catechism is confirmed. Your child hears you pray at home and then watches the congregation pray together. The two reinforce each other. Your child watches you serve and then sees other adults serving for the same reasons. The pattern confirms itself. Your child hears you talk about grace and then hears the pastor preach grace from the pulpit. The message becomes larger than one household. That is what the church does for formation. It takes the small, private catechism of the home and places it in a larger story. It shows the child that the faith is not a family tradition. It is a global, historical, living reality that their family happens to be part of. That confirmation is essential. The home cannot provide it alone. The church can. That is the partnership.

I want to be careful here, because I do not want to swing too far the other way. There is a family-worship subculture in the church that has overcorrected against the outsourcing model by pulling children out of age-graded ministry entirely, keeping them in the adult service, running rigorous family devotions at home, and treating the programmatic side of the church as unnecessary or corrupting. I think that subculture has named a real problem and responded to it with a posture that sometimes hardens into isolation and pride. That is not where I am pointing. I am not asking you to withdraw your child from the youth group. I am asking you to stop treating the youth group as the load-bearing wall of your child's faith. It is not. Your home is.

Let me say it the other way around. If your home is teaching a

true faith and the children are forming near it, a mediocre youth group will not undo that. I have seen it. I have known kids whose youth group was not much, whose parents were quietly serious about Jesus, and those kids grew into men and women whose faith went the distance. I have also seen the opposite. Top-shelf youth ministry. Engaging teaching. Great relationships. And parents whose actual life at home communicated that God is not really the center. Those kids aged out of the youth group and the faith did not stick, because the youth group was carrying a load the home refused to carry. The youth group cannot win that fight. Nothing can win that fight except a change at home.

I want to name one more thing that the outsourcing model does to children that is rarely discussed. It teaches them that faith is compartmentalized. It teaches them that faith is something that happens in certain buildings, with certain people, at certain times. The rest of life is something else. Church is church. Home is home. School is school. Faith lives in the church compartment. When the child leaves the church compartment, the faith stays behind, like a coat hanging in the closet. The child has learned, through the structure of the outsourcing model, that faith is not integrated into ordinary life. It is a department. And departments can be closed.

A home that is doing its own formation work teaches the opposite. Faith is not a department. It is the operating system. It runs in every room, during every conversation, through every decision. The child raised in that home does not know how to separate faith from life, because the two were never separate in their experience. When that child leaves for college, the faith goes with them, because the faith is not located in a building or a program. It is located in the way they see the world. It is in their marrow. You cannot leave it behind.

The costly hope. You get back what you were told you could give away. You are the primary catechist of your children. You do not need a degree. You do not need curriculum certification. You need a life with Christ and the willingness to let your children see that life, and

the maturity to bring your children into the life of a congregation where that shared life is reinforced and expanded. That is a weight. It does not feel like relief. It feels like the responsibility you thought you had handed off has quietly landed back on your shoulders.

It has. Because it was always there. It was never the church's to take. The church's role is to come alongside you, to preach the word to the whole household, to teach your children in ways that complement what you are already teaching, to surround you with other families trying to do the same thing. The church is there for the help you cannot provide alone. It is not there to do what only a parent can do.

If you are a pastor or a children's worker reading this, you know what I am saying is true. You have been sold to parents as a service. You have sometimes believed the sales copy. And you have watched families for years and you know which ones are forming children and which ones are delegating. You know what makes the difference. It is not the family that is more religiously active in the church. It is the family whose home is running a real catechism. Those children track. Those children come back even if they wander. Those children have something in them that was planted somewhere other than your classroom.

You cannot do their parents' job. You can do your job. Your job is to come alongside the parent, equip them, encourage them, love them, and serve their children as a partner in what the parent is primarily carrying. Your job is not to be the parent. It never was. When you try, both you and the parent lose, and the child loses worst of all.

So this is the chapter where we stop pretending that the church is where this happens. The church is where it is reinforced, celebrated, expanded, and held in common with other families. Where it happens, primarily, is the place where no one else can see, and the parent is the one being watched. That is your house. That is your Tuesday at six thirty in the evening. That is the fifteen minutes before

your children go to bed.

Now we turn to what those children are quietly asking while they watch you.

But before we go there, let me say something to the parent who read this chapter and felt guilty for every Sunday school drop-off they have ever done.

That is not my intent. The church's ministry to children is good. It is a gift. I have watched Sunday school teachers pour years of their lives into children who were not their own, driven by nothing but love for God and love for the next generation. I have watched youth pastors stay up until two in the morning with a teenager who needed someone to talk to. I have watched children's ministry volunteers build sets, write scripts, learn songs, and arrive early on Sunday mornings for years without recognition. Those people are not the problem. They are the church at its finest.

The problem is the system that tells parents those people are the primary formation agents. The problem is the assumption, embedded in the infrastructure of American church life, that spiritual formation is a service the church provides rather than a life the household cultivates. The volunteers are doing their part. The parents need to do theirs. And doing theirs does not mean adding church activities. It means becoming the kind of people whose daily lives form their children toward Christ.

I want to tell you about a conversation I had with a children's ministry director at a church in another state. She had been in the role for twelve years. She was tired. Not physically tired, though she was that too. Soul tired. She told me that the hardest part of her job was not the curriculum or the logistics or the volunteer recruitment. The hardest part was watching parents drop their children off with an expectation that she could accomplish in ninety minutes what the home was contradicting the other one hundred and sixty-six hours of the week.

She described a specific family. Two parents, both professionals, both active in the church. Their son was in her class every Sunday. Smart kid. Well-behaved. Knew the Bible stories. But she could see something in him that the parents could not. He was performing. He knew the right answers because he had been taught the right answers. But there was no fire behind the answers. No curiosity. No wonder. She told me, that boy has been taught about God the way he has been taught about the solar system. It is information. It is not personal.

She tried to talk to the parents about it. They were defensive. They pointed out that their son attended every program the church offered. He was in Sunday school, Wednesday night, VBS, summer camp. He had more church programming than any child in the building. She did not know how to tell them that the programming was not the problem. The disconnect between the programming and the household was the problem.

That boy is in his twenties now. He does not attend church. He is not hostile to the faith. He is indifferent. And indifference, as I have said before, is harder to reach than hostility. Because indifference means the thing never became real enough to fight against. It was always information. It never became life.

Let me also address the pastors reading this, because I am one of you, and this chapter implicates us directly. We have built children's ministry models that incentivize parental outsourcing. We have done it because it fills programs, because it looks good on the annual report, because parents want it, and because it is easier to run a program than to challenge a household. When a parent brings their child to every church event, we count that family as engaged. We should be asking whether the home is engaged. We should be measuring formation, not attendance.

I am not saying we should dismantle children's ministry. I am saying we should redefine its purpose. The purpose of children's ministry is not to replace parental formation. It is to supplement it. It is to provide what the household cannot provide on its own.

Community with other believing families. Instruction from teachers other than the parents. Worship in a corporate setting. The experience of belonging to a body larger than the family. All of that is valuable. None of it is a substitute for the household.

The most effective children's ministry I have ever seen was at a church that spent half its children's ministry budget on training parents. Not on curriculum for the children. On training for the parents. They ran workshops on how to have spiritual conversations at home. They provided resources for family worship. They paired younger parents with older ones who had walked the road. They sent materials home every week that connected what the child learned on Sunday to what the family could practice on Tuesday. The children in that church were not notably more Bible-literate than children in other churches. They were notably more formed. Because the church had invested in the formation environment that mattered most, which was the home.

That is the model I am advocating. Not the abolition of children's ministry. The reorientation of it. Toward the household. In service of the parents. As a supplement to the life the family is already living rather than a substitute for the life the family is not.

Let me name one more thing before we leave this chapter. The guilt. Because I know many parents reading this are now feeling it. You have been dropping your children at church programs and hoping the programs would do the work. You have been outsourcing what this chapter says you should be owning. And the guilt is rising.

Here is what I want to say to the guilt. Do not stay there. Guilt that produces change is useful. Guilt that produces paralysis is not. If this chapter has shown you something about your household that needs to change, then change it. Do not wallow in what you should have done. Start with what you can do tonight.

Tonight you can sit at the table with your children and ask them a real question. Tonight you can pray out loud in a room where they can hear you. Tonight you can say the blessing over them before bed.

Tonight you can turn off the television and read a passage of Scripture, not because you are performing a devotional but because you want to be near God and you want them to see you wanting to be near God. Those are small things. They are also the entire argument of this book. Small things, done consistently, in a household where the adults are actually walking with Christ, over years, in ordinary rooms. That is the curriculum. You have everything you need to start it tonight.

The church is not the enemy of parental formation. The church is the partner. But the church needs to understand its role, and the parent needs to understand theirs. When both understand their role, the child receives what neither could give alone. The church gives community, corporate worship, teaching from multiple voices, and the experience of belonging to something larger than the family. The parent gives proximity, daily formation, honest answers, emotional safety, and the lived demonstration of what it looks like to follow Jesus when nobody is watching.

Together, those two forces produce a formed child. Apart, each one is incomplete. The church without the home produces a child who knows about God but has no lived reference for what it means to walk with God in the ordinary. The home without the church produces a child who may know God intimately but has no experience of community, no experience of corporate worship, and no connection to the broader body of Christ.

You need both. Your child needs both. And the goal of this chapter is not to pull your child out of church programs. It is to make sure that when your child walks through those church doors on Sunday morning, they are walking in from a household where the faith is already alive, not from a household where the faith is on hold until the professionals take over.

CHAPTER 4

The Questions Children Actually Ask

Somewhere around age eight, a child begins to ask real questions. Sometimes earlier. They come out at strange moments. In the back of the car. At the dinner table when the conversation is about something else. Right before the child falls asleep, when they know the parent cannot easily walk away. The questions are usually plain on the surface and devastating underneath. If God is good why did my dog die. If God is real why did grandma die. Is heaven real. What if I do not feel like I love Jesus. Why are there other religions. How do we know the Bible is true. Why do bad people seem to win. What happens to my friend who does not believe.

How a parent answers those questions in the first ninety seconds tells the child everything. Not about the answer. About whether the question is welcome. And children are taking notes.

Name what most of us do. We answer too quickly. We answer with a phrase we half remember from a sermon. We answer with a verse that does not quite fit. We change the subject. We say a version of because God said so. We try to shut the question down before it unsettles us. Or worse, we communicate to the child, through tone or through impatience or through the speed of our response, that the question itself is the problem. That Christians do not ask this. That faithful children do not doubt. That their curiosity is a temptation to be resisted rather than a door to be walked through together.

When we do that, we are teaching the child something far more damaging than the content of our too-quick answer. We are teaching them that questions do not belong in this household. The child learns, very early, that if there is a question underneath their belief, it has to be hidden from the adults. And because children are not stupid, they

keep asking their questions. They stop asking them to you. They ask them to Google. They ask them to their friends. They ask them to the algorithm that is quietly curating the videos they fall asleep to. They ask them at two in the morning, to themselves. And they build, over years, a parallel life of unresolved doubt that runs alongside their polite church attendance.

I want to trace how this works, because the mechanism matters. A child asks a question. The parent's response creates one of two outcomes. In the first outcome, the question is received. The parent's face is open. The parent does not rush. The child learns: this house is a place where I can think about God honestly. The question gets discussed, over days or weeks, and the child learns not only the content of the discussion but the posture of it. The posture is: faith and questions live in the same room. In the second outcome, the question is deflected or shut down. The parent's face is tight. The parent responds too quickly. The child learns: this house is not a place where I can think about God honestly. The question goes underground. The child learns to perform belief while conducting their real intellectual life elsewhere.

The second outcome is the one producing the crisis we are in. A generation of young adults who were raised in Christian homes and who will tell you, if you ask them, that their first honest conversation about faith happened in college. Not because their parents were bad people. Because their parents could not handle the questions. And the children, being loyal, stopped asking.

Eventually one of two things happens. They hit an age, usually somewhere between sixteen and twenty-two, where the parallel life overwhelms the church one, and they walk away. Or they continue performing belief while no longer holding it, because they do not want to disappoint the people who clearly could not handle their doubt. Neither outcome is faith. Both of them are the result of households that could not tolerate a child's honest question.

Reframe it. A child who is asking you a hard spiritual question is

not drifting from faith. They are often doing the exact opposite. They are trying to make their faith fit the reality they are seeing. That is a sign of spiritual seriousness, not spiritual weakness. The child who never asks is not the child who has settled faith. The child who never asks is often the child whose curiosity has already migrated elsewhere because the home did not feel safe for it. When a child asks you a hard question, be grateful. It means they still trust you with it. Do not blow that trust by answering in ninety seconds.

Here is what I have learned in raising five sons and in pastoring for twenty years. The three sentences below will carry you through almost every hard question your child asks you, if you mean them and if you have the courage to say them slowly.

First sentence. That is a really good question. Not as a filler. As an honest response. Because the question is a good question. You are welcoming the question before you answer it. The child is watching your face while you say it. If your face is honest, the child lets the conversation breathe. If your face is tight, the child already knows this was a mistake.

Second sentence. I have wondered that too. Say it only if it is true, and in my experience, it will almost always be true. Children ask the same questions grown adults ask quietly. If you are a Christian who has never wondered whether God is real, whether suffering makes sense, whether other religions might be right, whether the Bible can be trusted, you are either lying to your child or you are not a mature believer. Mature faith has sat with hard questions and come through them to confidence, which is different from never having the questions. When you tell your child you have wondered what they are wondering, you are giving them a gift. You are telling them that doubt is part of faith, not the opposite of it. You are telling them they are not broken for asking.

Third sentence. Let us think about it together. Not: here is the answer. Let us think. That language is slow on purpose. It refuses to perform certainty. It models the posture of a believing mind that is

willing to look at the question honestly. It invites the child into the thinking. It makes the conversation collaborative rather than corrective. And it often takes more than one conversation, which is the most important thing of all.

I want to explain why those three sentences work, because it is not a technique. It is a theology. The first sentence says: your question has dignity. The second sentence says: your doubt is human, not sinful. The third sentence says: we find truth together, not by decree. All three of those are theologically loaded. A Christianity that cannot say those three things to a child is a Christianity that does not trust its own claims enough to let them be examined. And a Christianity that does not trust its own claims will never convince a child who is watching whether the adults actually believe what they say.

I cannot count the number of times one of my sons has asked me a question I could not answer well in the moment. A few years ago one of the older ones asked me why God commanded the Canaanites to be wiped out in the book of Joshua. He had been reading it on his own, which I want to note for a minute. He had been reading the Bible on his own, not because I made him but because he had watched me read mine, and he had picked it up for his own reasons. That is formation. But the question was real. He was eleven. He was bothered. And I did not have a clean answer in ninety seconds. What I had was the three sentences. That is a really good question. I have wondered that too. Let us think about it together. And then I told him the truth, which is that I do not think there is a tidy answer, that Christians have wrestled with this passage for two thousand years, that I have a tentative way of understanding it, and that I want to walk through it with him over the next few weeks. We came back to it. More than once. We read some commentators together. I did not resolve it for him. I let him stay with it, with me. That is what formation looks like on a hard question.

Here is what I did not do. I did not pretend I had a clean answer. I did not give him a Sunday school platitude. I did not fast-talk past the

difficulty. I did not act like the question itself was unfaithful. And I did not walk away feeling like a failure because I had not converted his question into certainty on my timeline.

Let me name another kind of question that is different from the intellectual kind, and that requires a different posture. It is the emotional question. It is the question that is not really about information at all. It is about pain. A child whose grandfather has died asks if grandpa is in heaven. The child is not asking for a theological position paper on the intermediate state. The child is asking: is grandpa okay. Will I see him again. Is death the end. And the child is asking something even underneath that: is this world safe. Is there someone holding what hurts. The parent who responds to the emotional question with an intellectual answer has missed the child entirely. The child needed a hug first. They needed tears. They needed to hear that grief is okay and that God is near to the brokenhearted. The theology can come later. The presence comes first.

I have made this mistake. I have answered emotional questions with theological precision when what my son needed was his father's arms and his father's honesty that death is painful and that we grieve with hope but that the grief is real and we do not have to pretend it is not. The child who receives a theological lecture when they needed a human presence learns that faith is cold. That is not what we mean to teach. It is what we teach when we reach for our head before we reach for our heart.

Let me name one of the most common parental mistakes with questions. The mistake is believing that every hard question requires an immediate settled answer or you have lost your authority. That is not true. Your authority as a parent does not come from your ability to answer every theological question in real time. Your authority comes from your presence, your integrity, your faithfulness over time, and the obvious reality that you love your child. You can hold an unresolved question in front of your child for a whole season, and your authority grows rather than shrinks, because you are modeling

what a grown believer looks like. Grown believers do not have an answer for everything. They have a God they trust with the things they cannot answer. The modeling of that trust, in real time, with your child, is one of the most formative things you can do.

There is another mistake, and this one is harder to see. It is the mistake of answering a question the child did not ask because the question the child asked scares us. A child asks about hell. We turn it into a lesson about sin. A child asks why a relative died. We turn it into a platitude about heaven. We are answering our own discomfort rather than the child's actual question. Children can tell. They learn not to ask.

I want to address a specific category of questions that terrifies many Christian parents. These are the questions about other religions and other worldviews. A child comes home from school and says their friend is Muslim, or Hindu, or atheist, and the child wants to know why their friend believes something different and whether their friend is wrong. This question is terrifying to the parent who has been taught that exposure to other worldviews is dangerous. But the question is not dangerous. The question is the beginning of apologetics. The child is asking you to give a reason for the hope that is in you, and if you cannot do it with gentleness and respect, as Peter commanded, the child will conclude that your faith cannot withstand comparison. That conclusion is devastating. And it is reached not through exposure to other religions but through the parent's inability to engage them.

Answer the actual question. If you do not know, say so. If it is complicated, say so. If there is more than one Christian position, name that. You are not required to pretend the Christian tradition is monolithic. Children are impressed, not destabilized, by a parent who says, there are faithful Christians who see this passage differently, and here is how your mother and I see it and why. You are giving them a model of thinking. You are also giving them permission to think, which most of them are already doing anyway.

I want to tell you what happens when a household handles questions well over years. I have watched it. The child who grows up in a home where questions are welcome does not stop asking questions. They ask better ones. Their questions mature. At eight it is why did the dog die. At twelve it is how do we know the resurrection happened. At sixteen it is what do we do about suffering in the world. At nineteen it is how do I hold my faith when my roommate's arguments are good. The progression is striking if the home has kept the door open. Because at every stage, the child's faith is being refined by the questions rather than eroded by them. The questions are doing what fire does to gold. They are burning away what is false and leaving what is true. A child whose questions have been welcomed for fifteen years has a faith that has been tested, and a tested faith is a faith that lasts.

I have also watched what happens when a household shuts down questions. The child who grows up in a home where questions are unwelcome does not stop having questions. The questions go underground. They multiply in the dark. They attach to resentment. And when the child finally encounters an environment where the questions are welcomed, usually a college classroom or an online community, the child experiences that environment as more honest than the home. Not because the college professor has better answers. Because the college professor did what the parent would not do, which was to treat the question as worth asking. The parent lost the child not to better arguments but to a better posture. That is preventable. That is the thing this chapter is trying to prevent.

One more practical word. Build question-asking into the rhythms of your household. Do not wait for the questions to emerge at random. Create spaces where questions are expected. At the dinner table, ask your children what they are thinking about. Not what they learned at school. What they are thinking about. At bedtime, after the prayer, ask if there is anything they have been wondering about. On car rides, turn off the music for ten minutes and ask them. You will get silence at first. You will get shrugs. Keep asking. Over weeks and

months, the child will begin to believe that you mean it. And when they believe you mean it, the questions will come. And they will come to you, which is the whole point.

The costly hope in this chapter is plain and heavy. Be the safe person your child can ask the hardest question in their life, now, so that ten years from now, when the question is the one that will determine whether they stay in the faith, they are still coming to you with it. Not to Google. Not to the friend who is also confused. To you. That requires starting now, when they are six and eight and ten and the questions are small enough to practice on. If you cannot handle a small question now, you will not be the one they trust with the large question later. And the large question is coming. It always does.

One more note. Some of you are parents of teenagers who have already stopped asking you. You feel the loss. You know when the questions went underground. You wonder if it is too late. It is not too late. But you will have to start by being honest with them that you know you did not handle their questions well when they were smaller, and you want to try again. You might get silence. You might get an eye roll. You might get a door opening, slowly, over months. Do not rush it. Do not retaliate against the slowness. A parent who is willing to earn back the conversation, who does not demand it or get bitter when it is slow in coming, is a parent doing holy work. Keep doing it.

Your children have questions. Thousands of them. Most of them do not know yet what those questions will grow into. You cannot give them certainty. But you can give them a seat at your table while they figure it out, with a Bible open between you and the Holy Spirit doing what He does best, which is drawing people to Christ in the slow and honest way.

We are not done yet. Because underneath questions there is another issue, one that shapes whether the child is even asking for truth or asking for permission. That is the next chapter. Obedience

without gospel.

But I want to push the questions conversation further before we leave it, because the questions children ask change as they age, and the parent who handles a six-year-old's question well may be caught off guard by what a twelve-year-old asks.

Young children ask concrete questions. Where is heaven. What does God look like. Can God see me in the dark. These are spatial, physical, imagination-level questions. They are asking because they are trying to locate God in the world they can see. The parent's job at this stage is to be concrete in return. God is everywhere, but He is especially close to you when you pray. God does not have a body like ours, but Jesus did, and Jesus looks at you with love. Yes, God can see you in the dark, and He is watching over you right now. Direct. Warm. The child is not looking for philosophical sophistication. They are looking for assurance that God is real and God is near.

Older children ask moral questions. Why did God let the dog die. Why are there poor people if God loves everyone. Why did my friend's parents get divorced. These are justice questions. The child is developing a moral sense and they are testing whether God fits inside it. The parent who answers these questions with theological precision but no emotional engagement will lose the child's trust. The child is not asking for a theodicy lecture. The child is asking whether God is good in a world that does not always look good. The parent needs to hold both truths. The world is broken, and that breaking causes real pain. And God is in the middle of the pain, doing something about it, even when we cannot see what He is doing. That answer is not neat. It is honest. And honest answers at this stage build a foundation for the harder questions coming.

Teenagers ask identity questions. How do I know God is real and not something I believe because my parents believe it. Why should the Bible have authority over my life when other smart people think it is mythology. What makes Christianity different from any other religion that claims to be true. These are existential questions. The

teenager is not trying to be difficult. They are trying to own their beliefs rather than borrow yours. And the parent who reacts to these questions with fear or anger will confirm the teenager's suspicion that the faith cannot survive examination.

I have seen parents panic at this stage. They hear their teenager express doubt and they treat it as a crisis. They call the youth pastor. They ground the child. They increase the Bible reading schedule. Every one of those responses tells the teenager the same thing. Your honest questions are dangerous, and the adults in your life are afraid of them. That is the opposite of formation. That is suppression. And suppression produces one of two outcomes. Either the child learns to hide their questions, which means the questions go underground and fester. Or the child escalates the questions into rebellion, because rebellion is the only way to get the adults to take them seriously.

The better response is to welcome the question and honor the questioner. When my son asked me, at fourteen, how he could know that God was real and not something he believed because I was a pastor, I felt pride before I felt anything else. Because that question meant he was doing the work. He was not content to carry a borrowed faith. He wanted his own. And the process of getting his own required him to test the one he had been given.

I told him several things. First, that his question was one of the best questions a person can ask, and that I was glad he was asking it. Second, that I had asked the same question when I was not much older than him, and that my faith survived the asking. Third, that there are good reasons to believe that God is real and that Christianity is true, and that those reasons have been articulated by some of the brightest minds in human history, and that I would be glad to walk through some of them with him. Fourth, that faith is not the absence of doubt. Faith is trust in the face of doubt. And the God of the Bible is not threatened by honest questions. He invites them.

We spent the next several months reading together. Not the Bible, initially. We read parts of C.S. Lewis. We read parts of Tim Keller.

We watched some lectures together. We talked about what he found persuasive and what he did not. And somewhere in those months, something shifted. He moved from testing a borrowed faith to building his own. The content was similar. The ownership was different. And that difference is everything.

I also want to speak to the questions that children ask with their behavior rather than their words. A child who starts lying is asking a question about safety. Am I safe to tell the truth in this household, or is the truth going to get me hurt. A child who starts withdrawing is asking a question about belonging. Do I still belong here if I am not who you want me to be. A child who starts acting out is asking a question about attention. Does anyone in this house notice me when I am not performing.

These behavioral questions are harder to hear than verbal ones, because the behavior triggers the parent's frustration rather than their curiosity. The parent sees the lie and responds to the lie. The parent sees the withdrawal and takes it personally. The parent sees the acting out and reaches for discipline. In each case, the parent is responding to the surface behavior rather than the deeper question underneath it.

The parent who can look past the behavior to the question is the parent who can actually form the child. That does not mean the behavior goes unaddressed. It means the behavior is addressed after the question has been heard. You lied to me, and we need to talk about that. But first, I want to understand something. Are you afraid of what happens when you tell me the truth? Because if you are, that is something I need to change about how I respond to you. That kind of response forms a child. It teaches them that the adults in their life are paying attention to the person, not managing the performance.

CHAPTER 5

Obedience Without Gospel

There is a particular brand of Christian parenting that raises atheists. It does not mean to. It often comes from parents who love their children and believe they are doing the most serious work of their lives. They are. They are running the wrong version of it. The version produces a child who behaves well, who checks the right boxes, who does not give the parent trouble, and who, somewhere around age twenty, quietly concludes that the whole thing was about compliance and that they have outgrown it.

Name it. The version is obedience without gospel. The version treats the Christian life primarily as a set of behaviors the child must perform. Do not do this. Do this. Do not watch that. Do watch this. Memorize these verses. Avoid those people. Stay in church. Stay off the phone at certain hours. Dress a certain way. Speak a certain way. The content of the rules varies by tribe. The logic is the same. If the child complies, the child is spiritually healthy. If the child does not comply, the child is spiritually sick. The parent's job, in this model, is to engineer compliance. Rewards, punishments, shaming, praise, social pressure. The goal is a behaviorally conforming child.

This model has two problems. The first is that it is not the gospel. It is moralism with Christian vocabulary. The second is that even when it works, it produces the wrong kind of person. Because the point of the Christian life is not a well-behaved child. The point of the Christian life is a child whose heart has been confronted with the love of God and has learned to love God back. Behavior flows out of that. Behavior engineered without that is a hollow performance that holds until adolescence and then breaks.

Let me say it more directly. If you get the behavior without the

heart, you have not succeeded. You have delayed a crisis. The crisis will come, usually when the child is old enough to resent the control they cannot remember agreeing to. And when it comes, they will not be throwing away a relationship with Jesus. They never had one. They were performing a relationship with their parents. The moment they could get out from under that performance, they did. And they were right to. The performance was unsustainable because it was never the real thing.

I want to trace how this works in practice, because many parents running this model do not know they are running it. They think they are teaching their children the faith. They are teaching their children a behavioral system that uses the vocabulary of the faith. The difference is everything.

Take a common scenario. A child lies to a parent about something. The moralist parent responds with: lying is a sin. God does not like it. You will be punished. Do not do it again. The gospel parent responds differently. The gospel parent starts with the relationship: I love you. You are safe here. Then the truth: what you did was wrong, and lying hurts people, including you. Then the gospel: the reason we tell the truth in this house is not to avoid punishment. It is because God made you for truth. He loved you enough to tell you the truth about yourself, even the hard parts, and He is making you into a person who can carry truth. The correction is real. The punishment may be real. But the frame around it is grace and identity, not fear and compliance.

The child raised on the first version learns: God is a rule enforcer. Stay in line or face consequences. The child raised on the second version learns: God is a father who loves me and is forming me. The obedience that flows from the second is a different species of obedience than the first. The first is fear-driven. The second is love-driven. Fear-driven obedience expires the moment the enforcer is removed. Love-driven obedience deepens the moment the person is alone, because it is internally motivated, not externally coerced.

I see the fruit of this in my pastoral work constantly. A couple comes to me grieving a grown child who has walked away from the faith. The story they tell me is always the same in its broad outlines. We raised him in the church. We had family devotions. We homeschooled, or we sent him to a Christian school. He was respectful, well-behaved, a good student. He went on mission trips. And then he got to college and something broke. We do not know what happened. I listen. I ask careful questions. Almost every time, what emerges is that the faith the child grew up with was primarily a behavioral contract, enforced by parental pressure, with gospel language draped over it. The child was not apostate. The child was released from a contract the moment the enforcer was no longer present. The contract broke because it was never the real thing.

I have sat with enough of these parents to see a pattern. The parents who ran the behavioral model usually cannot name when their child last had a personal, uncoerced encounter with the grace of God. They can name every program the child attended. They can name the child's baptism date. They can name the child's commitment card from camp. But they cannot name the last time the child was met by God in a way that was not managed by the parent. Because the child's entire spiritual life was managed. It was supervised. It was directed. And the child, therefore, never owned it. It belonged to the parent. When the parent was no longer in the room, the faith was no longer in the room.

Reframe it. The gospel is not a set of behaviors. The gospel is the announcement that God has acted in Christ to rescue people who cannot rescue themselves. It is news before it is command. The commands follow. They do not precede. They do not substitute. The moral life of a Christian is a response to the news, lived out of the power the news releases, which is the power of the Holy Spirit at work in a heart that has been brought into relationship with God through Christ. This is the order. News first. Then relationship. Then transformed behavior. Not the reverse.

If you reverse it, which is what much of American Christian

parenting does, you produce a child who has never heard good news. They have only heard demand. They have heard you say Jesus loves you, but the texture of the household communicated that Jesus accepts you if you behave, and that therefore God's love is transactional and conditional and tied to your performance. That is not the gospel. That is the opposite of the gospel. And children raised on the opposite of the gospel will, at their first real chance, reject it, because it is not good news. It is exhausting news dressed up in Christian language.

I need to name something that is difficult for many parents to hear. The moralist model is attractive because it produces visible, measurable results. A well-behaved child is a relief. A compliant child is socially acceptable. A child who never questions, never pushes back, never makes a scene is a child the parent can point to as evidence of successful parenting. The moralist model gives the parent what the parent wants, which is a child who makes the parent look good. That is not formation. That is reputation management. And the child can feel the difference, even if they cannot name it, between a parent who wants them to be good and a parent who wants them to know God.

Here is what gospel parenting looks like in practice. When your child fails, which will happen every day, the first word out of your mouth is not correction. The first word is grace. That does not mean no correction. Correction comes. But it comes inside a frame that communicates: nothing you can do will make me love you more. Nothing you can do will make me love you less. You are secure here. And the same is true of God. He loves you. He is not waiting for you to get it right to love you. He loves you so much that He is going to do the slow work of forming you into someone whose heart actually wants what He wants. That is the direction we are going. Not perfect behavior. Formed heart. Everything we do in this house is toward that.

Your children will test whether you mean it. They will do things that trigger your moralism. They will act out in ways that expose whether your first instinct is control or grace. And you will fail. I

have. Many times. The test is not whether you get it right the first time. The test is whether you are willing to go back and repair. A parent who blows up in moralistic anger at a child and then, later, comes alongside that child and says I am sorry, I responded in my own frustration, that was not how God meets you, let me tell you how He actually meets you, that parent is teaching the gospel at that moment. The failure, handled with repentance, is itself the lesson. The parent who never fails is not teaching the gospel, because the gospel is for failures, and if your children think you have never been one, they will not know how to be one in your presence, and they will hide from you the parts of themselves that God most wants to meet.

I will say something that will bother some of my readers. Your child's obedience is not the measure of your parenting. I know that contradicts everything you have read in certain Christian parenting books. I mean it anyway. Your child's heart is the measure. And you cannot control your child's heart. You can tend the soil. You can preach the gospel in ordinary language over years. You can be the kind of person near whom heart change is more likely than not. You cannot force heart change. And if you mistake external compliance for heart change, you will be satisfied with something God is not satisfied with. You will stop pressing in at the level where it actually matters. You will be relieved by the quiet child and alarmed by the child who is struggling openly, when it may be the struggling one who is actually alive and the quiet one who has learned to perform.

Let me tell you about two children I have known over the years. I will not use their real names. The first was a model child. Well-behaved, polite, never in trouble, always at church, always with the right answers. The parents pointed to this child as their crowning achievement. The child left the faith at twenty-one, completely, and the parents were blindsided. They should not have been. The child had been performing for fifteen years. The performance ended when the audience was no longer watching.

The second child was a terror. Argued with everything. Pushed every boundary. Got in trouble at school. Drove the parents to their

knees, literally, because they had no other place to go. That child is in their thirties now, walking with Jesus, leading a small group, parenting their own children with a faith that has been tested by their own rebellion and refined by it. The parents will tell you that the years of chaos were the years of formation, because the chaos forced everyone in the family to stop pretending and start being real with God.

I am not saying rebellion is good. I am saying that the parent who sees a compliant child and assumes formation has occurred is making a dangerous assumption. Compliance and formation are not the same thing. Sometimes they overlap. Sometimes they do not. The only way to know is to look at the heart, and the heart is not visible in behavior alone. It is visible in whether the child is growing toward God on their own, in moments you did not orchestrate, in choices you did not supervise.

Here is another thing. Your children need to hear the gospel for themselves, personally, often. Not a sermon. A sentence. You are loved by the Father. Jesus came for you. The cross is for your sin, specifically. The Holy Spirit is with you, actually. Say these things to them. Name them by name. Say, Caleb, God loves you. Say it because it is true and because they need to hear it from their parent's mouth. The child whose parent has spoken the gospel over them by name, hundreds of times, over years, has something in their marrow that the child who only heard it in Sunday school does not have.

The costly hope here. You can stop running the behavioral contract. You can start preaching the news, at home, over your own children, out loud, in language they understand. You can let grace have the first word in your house. You can let correction come inside that frame rather than replacing it. You can admit your own need of the same gospel in front of your children. That is not weakness. That is strength. The parent who can say in front of a child, I needed Jesus today because I was short with your mother and I was wrong, and I have asked God's forgiveness and I am asking yours, is teaching a deeper lesson than any devotional can teach. The child watches grace

at work in the parent. And the child learns, slowly, that this faith is not a performance. It is real. It is for failures. It is for me.

One more caution. Do not over-correct the other way. I have seen parents react against moralism by removing all structure, all correction, all expectation. That is not gospel parenting. That is permissive parenting with Christian language. Gospel parenting has real correction, real discipline, real consequences. What it does not have is correction without love, consequences without explanation, discipline without repair. The gospel does not remove the law. It fulfills the law. It changes why we obey. We do not obey to be loved. We obey because we are loved. The structure in your home remains. The source of the structure changes. It is not earning. It is responding.

Your children need to see a home where the rules make sense because of who God is and what He has done, not because mom and dad demand it. If you cannot answer the question why in your own rules, at a level deeper than because I said so, your rules are not formation. They are control. And control produces the very rebellion you feared when your children are old enough to notice that the emperor has no theology.

Preach the gospel in your house. To your children, by name, often. Let it be the center of the thing, so the behaviors become fruit rather than root. Raise children whose obedience grows from love rather than fear. That takes years. It will not appear on any one metric. But it produces something that can last when the child is finally out of your reach.

That is what we want. Not compliance. Conviction. Not performance. Formed loves.

Before I move on, I want to name one more thing that the moralist model produces, because it is the thing that grieves me most as a pastor. The moralist model produces adults who cannot receive grace. They were raised in a system where performance was the currency and grace was the reward for good behavior. When they fail as adults, and they will fail, they do not know how to bring their failure to God.

They hide it. They perform harder. They white-knuckle their way through guilt, because the only model they have for dealing with failure is to work harder, produce more, and earn their way back into favor. That is not the Christian life. It is the exhausting counterfeit of the Christian life, and it produces burnout, hidden sin, and collapsed faith in the middle of adulthood.

I have counseled adults in their forties who cannot pray after a moral failure because they believe, at the gut level, that God is disappointed in them the way their parents were disappointed in them when they misbehaved at age nine. The disappointment was the catechism. The gospel was the footnote. And the footnote did not survive adulthood.

The parent who preaches the gospel at home is doing something for their child that will bear fruit thirty years from now, in a crisis the parent cannot foresee. That child, as an adult, will know how to bring their failure to God. They will know that the Father does not withdraw when they sin. They will know that the cross already settled the question of whether they are loved. They will know that repentance is the door back into the warm place, not the price of admission. They will know these things because their parent's home taught them these things, not in a class, but in the daily rhythm of how failure was handled.

I cannot overstate this. The way you respond to your child's failure today is forming the way your child will respond to their own failure at age thirty-five. If the response today is wrath, withdrawal, or conditional love, the thirty-five-year-old will expect wrath, withdrawal, and conditional love from God. If the response today is truth spoken in love, consequences paired with grace, and repair that restores the relationship, the thirty-five-year-old will know, in their bones, that God meets sinners the same way.

You are not raising children. You are raising adults. And the adults you are raising will carry the theology of your home into their own homes, their own marriages, their own failures, and their own

encounters with God. What they carry will either free them or bind them. The gospel frees. The moralist counterfeit binds. Choose the gospel. Choose it today. Choose it again tomorrow. Let it be the air your house breathes.

The next chapter follows directly from this one. Because if the gospel changes why we obey, it also changes how we discipline. And most Christian households have not thought carefully enough about what their discipline is actually teaching.

But let me push this one more step before we leave. Because moralism does not announce itself. It disguises itself in the language of faithfulness. And the parents most susceptible to it are often the parents who care the most about raising their children in the faith.

Here is how it happens. A parent who loves God genuinely wants their child to love God too. That desire is right and good. But the parent cannot make the child love God. Love cannot be compelled. It can only be cultivated. And when the parent feels the gap between their desire for the child's faith and the child's actual interior state, the parent reaches for the tool closest at hand. Control. The parent cannot make the child love God, but the parent can make the child act like someone who loves God. And so the moralism begins. Not with bad intentions. With the best intentions misapplied.

The child learns to perform devotion. They learn that the parent's mood improves when they read their Bible without being told. They learn that the household relaxes when they volunteer for the mission trip. They learn that praise flows when they lead prayer at the dinner table. None of those activities are wrong. All of them, in a moralist household, become transactional. The child is not pursuing God. The child is purchasing the parent's approval with spiritual currency.

I have watched this dynamic harm young adults. A woman in her thirties told me she could not pray without feeling like she was performing for an audience. Every time she closed her eyes, she felt her mother watching. Not literally. But the habit of performing prayer in her mother's presence had become so deeply embedded that prayer

itself felt like a performance. She had to unlearn everything about prayer before she could learn to actually pray. She had to sit in silence for months before God's presence became distinct from her mother's approval.

That story is not unusual. I have heard versions of it from dozens of adults who grew up in moralist Christian homes. The common thread is this. The child's spiritual life became fused with the parent's emotional state. When the child performed well spiritually, the parent was happy. When the child performed poorly, the parent was anxious or disappointed. Over years, the child's entire experience of God became mediated through the parent's emotional response. God was happy when Mom was happy. God was disappointed when Dad was worried. The parent became the child's functional mediator, and Christ, the actual mediator, was crowded out.

Let me describe what the alternative looks like in practice, because naming the error without naming the correction is half a chapter.

A gospel household has expectations. Children pray. Children learn Scripture. Children attend worship. Children treat others with respect. The expectations are real. But the expectations are held inside a frame that moralist households lack. The frame is this. Your obedience does not earn your standing. Your standing is already secured by the love of God, and your obedience is a response to that love, not a means of purchasing it.

In practical terms, this means the parent responds differently to the child's failure. In the moralist household, the child who refuses to pray receives disappointment, anxiety, correction that carries emotional weight beyond the moment. In the gospel household, the child who refuses to pray receives honesty. You do not want to pray tonight, and that is between you and God. I am not going to force you. But I want you to know that God is not angry with you right now. He is waiting for you. And He will still be waiting tomorrow.

That response costs the parent something. It costs them control. It

costs them the assurance that the child is performing correctly. It requires the parent to trust God with the child's interior life rather than managing that interior life through behavioral enforcement. And that trust, that costly trust, is itself formation. The child who watches a parent trust God with their disobedience learns something about God that the child who watches a parent panic over their disobedience never learns. They learn that God is patient. That grace is real. That the relationship survives failure.

I practiced this with one of my sons during a period when he did not want to read his Bible. He was eleven. He had been reading nightly with me since he was old enough to sit still. And one week, he said he did not want to. He said it was boring. He said he did not see the point. My instinct was to lecture him about the importance of Scripture. My instinct was moralism dressed as discipleship. Instead, I said this. I hear you. Reading the Bible can feel boring sometimes. It has felt boring to me too. I am not going to make you read tonight. But I am going to keep reading, and if you want to talk about what I am reading, I am here. He did not read for three weeks. On the fourth week, he sat down next to me while I was reading and asked what the passage was about. We talked for thirty minutes. He has read voluntarily since.

What happened in those three weeks of silence was not a failure of formation. It was formation. He learned that his father's love for Scripture was not dependent on the son's participation. He learned that the Bible was something his father wanted, not something his father was administering. He learned that the relationship between father and son was not contingent on spiritual compliance. And those three lessons, absorbed in three quiet weeks, taught him more about the gospel than three years of compulsory reading could have.

The moralist household fears silence. The gospel household trusts it. Because the gospel household knows that the Holy Spirit is at work in the silence, and the parent's job is not to fill the silence with pressure but to fill it with presence.

CHAPTER 6

Discipline, Correction, and the Shape of Grace

Every parent disciplines. The question is not whether you will correct your children. The question is what your correction is forming in them. Because correction, like everything else in the household, is catechesis. The way you handle a child's failure teaches the child something about who God is, what sin does, how grace operates, and whether restoration is real. If your discipline teaches the wrong things about those four, you will produce a child who has a distorted image of God that no sermon will easily undo.

Name it. Most Christian households discipline reactively. The child does something wrong. The parent responds. The response is driven by whatever the parent is feeling at that moment, which is usually some combination of anger, embarrassment, fear, and exhaustion. The punishment fits the parent's emotional state more than it fits the offense. And the child learns, over hundreds of these interactions, a theology of correction that the parent never intended to teach.

Let me describe two common patterns I have seen in twenty years of pastoral counseling with families. Both produce damaged theology in children. Both come from parents who love their children.

The first pattern is wrath-based correction. The child sins. The parent erupts. The eruption is angry, loud, sometimes physical, and disproportionate to the offense. The child is scared. The parent eventually calms down. The incident is never revisited. No repair is made. The child learns: when I sin, God erupts. God is angry. God is unpredictable. God calms down eventually, but the eruption is what I

remember. The child develops a theology of fear. They obey because they are afraid of the explosion. They do not obey because they love. And the fear produces either a child who is rigid and terrified of making a mistake, or a child who learns to hide everything, because hiding is safer than being seen.

I have met adults in their forties who still flinch internally when they pray, because the God they are praying to sounds like the father who screamed at them when they were nine. The father did not intend to teach that. He was angry. He was also, in many cases, repeating what was done to him. The cycle of wrath-based correction runs through generations unless someone breaks it. And breaking it requires something most angry parents do not want to hear, which is that their anger is their problem, not their child's, and that bringing their unprocessed anger into the correction of a child is sin.

I have been in this indictment. I have raised my voice at my sons in ways that were about my frustration, not their formation. I have confused my own emotional overflow with parental authority. I have had to go back to a child, more than once, and say: the way I corrected you was wrong. Not the correction. The way. I was angry, and I brought my anger into the room, and you absorbed it. That is on me. And I want you to know that God does not correct you the way I corrected you in that moment. God corrects you because He loves you, and His correction does not come with the kind of anger that makes you afraid to be near Him.

That repair is essential. It is also deeply uncomfortable. A father who goes back to his son and admits that his anger was the problem, not the child's behavior, is a father who is losing the illusion of infallibility that many men cling to. But the illusion was never serving the child. It was serving the father's ego. And the ego is not the basis of parental authority. Christ is.

The second pattern is withdrawal-based correction. The child sins. The parent does not erupt. The parent goes cold. Withdraws affection. Becomes distant. The child feels the withdrawal and learns: when I

sin, love is removed. God withdraws from me when I fail. The distance between me and God grows when I am bad and shrinks when I am good. This is a more subtle distortion than the wrath pattern, and in some ways more damaging, because it teaches the child that God's love is conditional. That the cross did not settle the question of God's affection. That you must earn your way back into the warm place.

Withdrawal-based correction does not look as dramatic as wrath-based correction. It looks calm. It looks controlled. But the child who grows up with a parent who goes cold after a failure learns something devastating about the nature of love. They learn that love has conditions. That closeness must be earned. That failure creates distance. And they carry that into every relationship they have, including their relationship with God.

I have counseled married adults who cannot receive grace from their spouse because they were raised by a parent who withdrew. They do not know how to stay close after a failure. They expect distance. They have been trained for it. The training happened in a thousand small withdrawals over fifteen years of childhood. And undoing that training is the work of decades in some cases.

Reframe it. Hebrews 12 is the text most Christian parents know on this subject. The Lord disciplines those He loves. That is true. But the verse is embedded in a passage about endurance, about running the race, about the great cloud of witnesses. The discipline of the Lord in Hebrews 12 is not punitive. It is formative. It is the discipline of a trainer, not a judge. The word in Greek, *paideia*, means training, instruction, the formation of a child. It is the same word used for the education of the young in the classical world. It carries the idea of a father investing in the growth of a child over years. It does not carry the idea of a father punishing a child into submission.

This distinction matters. Punitive discipline asks: how do I stop this behavior. Formative discipline asks: how do I use this moment to shape who this child is becoming. The first is about control. The

second is about growth. The first produces compliance or rebellion. The second produces a child who is learning, over years, to see their own sin honestly, to receive grace, and to grow.

Here is what formative discipline looks like in a home. The child fails. The parent responds, not from anger, but from purpose. The parent is clear about what happened. You lied. You hit your brother. You disobeyed what we agreed on. The naming is honest. No minimizing. No euphemism. The child needs to hear the truth about what they did, because truth is what God gives, and it is a gift even when it hurts.

Then the parent names why it matters. Not because I said so. Because lying breaks trust. Because violence hurts people made in God's image. Because obedience in this house is not about my power. It is about the kind of person God is forming you into. The why connects the behavior to something larger than the parent's preference. It connects it to the character of God and the dignity of other people.

Then the consequence. Consequences are real in a gospel household. Grace does not mean no consequences. It means consequences inside the context of unbreakable love. The child loses a privilege. The child makes restitution. The child apologizes to the person they hurt. The consequence is proportionate, clear, and connected to the behavior. It is not random. It is not excessive. It is not designed to inflict pain. It is designed to teach.

Then, and this is the part most Christian parents skip, the repair. After the consequence, the parent comes back. Not grudgingly. Not with lingering coldness. With warmth. The parent says: that is done. You have been corrected. You are still loved. Nothing has changed about your place in this family. Nothing has changed about God's love for you. Let us keep going. The repair is what teaches the child the gospel. Because the gospel says that sin is real and consequences are real and grace is real and restoration is real. All four. Not three. Not two. All four, in order.

A household that practices all four is teaching its children the shape of grace. The shape of grace is not: sin does not matter. The shape of grace is: sin matters enormously, and God has dealt with it in Christ, and because He has dealt with it, you are not defined by it, and you can grow through it rather than being destroyed by it. That is the most important thing a child can learn about the moral life. And they will learn it not from a theology class but from the way their parents handle their Tuesday evening failure.

I want to address the parent's anger directly, because it is the elephant in most Christian homes. Your anger at your child's behavior is usually about you. It is about your embarrassment that your child acted that way in public. It is about your fear that you are failing. It is about your need for control. It is about your own unprocessed wounds from your own childhood. It is rarely, in the moment, about the child's formation. And a correction delivered in anger is a correction the child receives as attack, not love. They will not hear the content of your correction over the volume of your fury.

This does not mean you should never feel anger. Anger is sometimes appropriate. When a child endangers themselves or another person, anger is a reasonable response. But appropriate anger is focused, brief, and connected to the severity of the situation. What most parents experience in the daily corrections of childhood is not appropriate anger. It is accumulated frustration expressed at the nearest available target. And the child knows the difference.

Here is a practice I learned late, and I wish I had learned it earlier. When one of my sons does something that triggers my anger, I pause. Not because I am serene. Because I know, from experience, that the words I say in the first ten seconds of my anger are the words my son will remember for years. If I want those words to form him rather than wound him, I need to choose them rather than react with them. The pause is not natural. It is learned. And it is one of the most important disciplines a parent can develop, because it is the discipline of bringing your own flesh under the authority of the Spirit before you try to bring your child under the authority of the household.

Let me also address the spanking question, because it comes up in every conversation about Christian discipline. I am not going to tell you whether to spank your children. I am going to tell you what I have observed in twenty years of pastoral work. The families where spanking was administered in calm, controlled, infrequent doses, connected to specific behaviors, followed by immediate repair and affection, produced children who were not notably different from families that used other forms of correction. The families where spanking was administered in anger, frequently, as the primary mode of discipline, without repair, produced children who were afraid of their parents and who associated God with physical pain. The issue was never the method alone. It was the spirit behind the method. Any discipline delivered in wrath, whether physical or verbal, teaches a theology of wrath. Any discipline delivered in love, with appropriate firmness and genuine repair, teaches a theology of grace.

The costly hope in this chapter is that you can change. If you have been a wrathful parent, you can repent. If you have been a withdrawing parent, you can learn to stay close. If your discipline has been reactive, you can make it purposeful. And the repair for what you have already done wrong begins with honesty. Go to your child. Name what you did. Apologize for the spirit behind it. Tell them what God's correction actually looks like. And then begin, today, to correct differently. Children are remarkably forgiving when the repentance is real. They have been waiting for you to see what they have been seeing for years. When you see it and name it, the relationship does not weaken. It strengthens. Because the child learns that even the parent is under God's formation, and that gives the child permission to be under it too.

Your discipline is forming something. It is forming either a child who understands grace or a child who fears God. Not the holy fear of Scripture, which is awe in the presence of holiness. The other kind. The fear that flinches. The fear that hides. The fear that will not come near. That fear is not the fruit of Christian parenting. It is the fruit of parenting that forgot the gospel at the moment it mattered most.

Correct your children. Do it clearly, honestly, proportionately, and with repair. Do it in a way that when your child thinks about what God is like, the first thing they remember is not your anger. It is your steadiness. Your honesty. Your willingness to call the thing what it is and to love them through it anyway.

That is the shape of grace. That is what the home is supposed to teach.

I want to address something that comes up in every conversation I have with parents about discipline. The question of consistency between parents. Because one of the most damaging things in a child's formation is a household where the two parents discipline differently, where the child learns to play one parent against the other, and where the correction feels arbitrary because it depends on which parent catches the behavior.

This happens in almost every home with two parents. One parent is stricter. The other is more lenient. One responds with heat. The other responds with calm. One follows through on consequences. The other forgets or relents. And the child, who is watching everything, learns that the moral structure of the household is not stable. It shifts depending on who is in the room. That instability does not produce formation. It produces a child who is learning to manage adults rather than learning to manage themselves.

The correction is not for both parents to become identical. Temperamental differences between parents are real and they are not going away. The correction is alignment. The two parents need to have a conversation, away from the children, about what the household's discipline philosophy is. What are we trying to form. What are the non-negotiable behaviors. What are the proportionate consequences. And when one of us is in the moment with a child, what does the other one do. That conversation, had in advance, prevents the breakdown that happens when two parents are trying to figure out the response in real time while the child is watching.

I will tell you where Susanna and I failed at this and what we

learned. Early in our parenting, we had no alignment. I was the stricter parent. Susanna was more lenient. The boys learned quickly that if Dad said no, there was a chance Mom would say yes if they caught her at the right moment. We were being played. Not maliciously. Children are natural strategists. They identify the weak point in any system and they exploit it. That is not sin. That is intelligence. The problem was that our system had a weak point, and the weak point was our lack of alignment.

We sat down one evening after a particularly chaotic day and made a rule that changed everything. The rule was this. If one parent has made a decision about discipline, the other parent backs it in front of the child. Always. Even if the other parent disagrees. The disagreement happens later, in private, between the parents. But in front of the child, the response is unified. This did not mean we always agreed. It meant the child always saw agreement. And the consistency of that presentation gave the moral structure of the household a stability it had lacked.

After the children were in bed, we would debrief. I would say, I think you were too harsh on that one. She would say, I think you let that one go too easily. We would talk it through. We would adjust. And the next time a similar situation arose, we were closer to aligned. Over years, this practice produced something neither of us could have produced alone. A household discipline culture that was firm, consistent, and gracious. Not because either of us was naturally all three. Because together, through conversation and compromise, we became all three.

I also want to address the question of public correction versus private correction. This matters more than most parents realize. A child who is corrected in front of their siblings, their friends, or other adults receives not only the correction but the shame of being corrected publicly. And shame, as we have discussed, is not the same as conviction. Conviction says you did something wrong and here is how to make it right. Shame says you are wrong and everyone can see it.

Whenever possible, correct in private. Pull the child aside. Take them to another room. Speak to them where their siblings cannot hear. This communicates respect. It communicates that the purpose of the correction is their formation, not their humiliation. And it removes the social pressure that turns a formative moment into a shaming one.

There are exceptions. When a child's behavior is dangerous or harmful to another person in the moment, immediate correction is necessary. When a child is being defiant in a way that affects the entire household, the household needs to see the correction addressed. But even in those cases, the detailed conversation, the why and the consequence and the repair, should happen in private. The public moment is for stopping the behavior. The private moment is for forming the person.

One more thing about discipline that I have learned late and wish I had learned early. The most effective discipline I have ever administered was not the strictest. It was the most connected. The correction that changed my son's behavior most was not the one with the biggest consequence. It was the one where he felt most known. Where I named what he did, connected it to who he was becoming, applied a consequence that made sense, and then held him. Where the whole sequence, from naming to repair, took place inside a relationship that he knew was unbreakable.

Children will accept correction from someone they trust. They will resist correction from someone they fear. And the difference between trust and fear is not the severity of the consequence. It is the quality of the relationship. A parent who has invested in the relationship, who has been present, who has listened, who has played and laughed and been available, that parent has earned the right to correct. And the child, who knows they are loved by that parent, will receive the correction as love rather than punishment.

Build the relationship first. The discipline will follow. And the discipline that follows a strong relationship will form character. The

discipline that precedes or replaces relationship will form resentment.

Now we need to talk about the thing that is catechizing your child more hours per day than you are. We need to talk about their phone.

CHAPTER 7

Screens, Algorithms, and the Catechesis of Attention

You cannot write a book about forming faith in children in the year 2026 without addressing the device in their pocket. It would be pastoral malpractice to pretend the old questions are still the only questions. They are not. Your child's primary catechist, for many hours of most days, is not you. It is an algorithm trained to maximize their attention by any means available. And whatever that algorithm is forming in them is competing directly with whatever you are trying to form. You should know what you are up against.

Name it. A smartphone is not a television. A smartphone is not a radio. A smartphone is not a video game. Those are older technologies, and a generation of Christian parents has tried to apply the old rules from those technologies to this one. Limit screen time. Use parental controls. Put the computer in a central room. Those rules worked, imperfectly, in the old world. They are profoundly insufficient in this one, because the smartphone is a qualitatively different kind of object. It is not a thing you watch. It is a system that watches you back. It studies your child. It learns their attention signature. It adjusts in real time. It delivers to them, precisely, the content that will keep them scrolling longest. It is adversarial to their interior life. It was designed that way. It is doing its job.

If this sounds like overstatement, I would invite you to read the public testimony of the engineers who built these systems. They have largely said in recent years that they do not let their own children use the platforms they helped create. They know what those platforms do. They know because they built them to do it. The platforms are not neutral tools your child uses for homework and occasionally for fun.

The platforms are active formation environments that have a theology of the human person, and their theology is that the person is a consumer of stimulus whose attention is a resource to be extracted.

That theology is in direct opposition to the Christian one. The Christian one says the person is a soul made for communion with God, whose attention is a gift to be given back to the Creator in worship and to the neighbor in love. The smartphone's theology says your attention is yours only in the legal sense, and it exists to be harvested. These two theologies cannot both shape your child at the same rate. One of them will win. If your child is receiving forty-five minutes a week of the Christian theology on Sunday morning and six hours a day of the smartphone theology the rest of the week, the math is not complicated.

I want to go deeper into what the smartphone actually does to a developing mind, because most parents think the danger is content. They worry about what their child is seeing. They should. But the deeper danger is structural. It is what the device is doing to their child's capacity for the kind of attention that faith requires.

Jonathan Haidt has documented this extensively. The adolescent mind is being reshaped by the platform-based childhood in ways that are producing unprecedented levels of anxiety, depression, and attention fragmentation. These are not incidental side effects. They are the natural result of training a developing brain on intermittent variable reinforcement, which is the same mechanism that makes slot machines addictive. The platform delivers a reward, withholds a reward, delivers a larger reward, withholds again. The brain chases the reward. The chasing becomes the state of mind. The child is not choosing to be distracted. The child's brain has been trained to be distracted. The distraction is now the default.

This has direct spiritual consequences that most Christian parents have not considered. Prayer requires sustained attention. Scripture reading requires sustained attention. Listening to a sermon requires sustained attention. Sitting in silence with God requires sustained

attention. Confession requires sustained attention. Repentance requires sustained attention. Every practice of the Christian life depends on a capacity that the smartphone is systematically dismantling in your child. You are trying to form a child in a faith that requires slow, focused, interior attention, and the device in their pocket is training their brain in the exact opposite direction. The device is winning. Not because it is smarter than you. Because it has more hours.

I am not saying no phones. I am not saying throw out the internet. I am a pastor who communicates daily through these tools. My sons have graduated levels of device access over time. I am not a Luddite. I am saying something more specific. I am saying that if you do not have a deliberate theology of attention for your household, the platforms have one for you, and they are winning. Name it. Act on it. Or accept what you are accepting.

Reframe it. Attention is a spiritual matter. The historic Christian tradition has understood this for centuries. The capacity to attend to God, to the neighbor, to the word of Scripture, to one's own soul, is the substrate of the Christian life. The saints trained this capacity. They treated attention as a muscle that strengthens through use and atrophies through misuse. They understood that a scattered mind cannot easily pray, cannot easily love, cannot easily meet God in Scripture. They did not have our devices. But they knew what ours do, because they knew what the disordered soul does when it has no disciplines of attention. It becomes shallow. It becomes frantic. It becomes incapable of the long, slow, quiet attention God requires.

Simone Weil wrote that prayer is attention. She meant it technically. The capacity to hold one's mind before God, without distraction, without chasing the next stimulus, is the very thing prayer is. A child raised on a smartphone that delivers a new stimulus every few seconds is having their attention trained, all day, in the opposite direction of the one faith requires. The child is being formed in a rhythm. Short. Shorter. Shortest. Stimulus. Stimulus. Stimulus. No silence. No boredom. No rest. No waiting. That is catechesis. The

child who cannot tolerate five minutes of silence cannot be still before God. The child who cannot tolerate a slow story cannot read a Gospel account. The child whose reward circuits have been trained by infinite scroll cannot easily accept that faith is a long obedience. The formation has already been done. You are not working against a neutral baseline. You are working against a trained one.

I want to name a specific danger that pastors see and parents often do not. The smartphone is not only training attention. It is training desire. The algorithm learns what your child wants and gives them more of it. Over time, the child's desires are being shaped by what the algorithm has trained them to want. The child does not want God because the child has been trained to want stimulus. The child does not want Scripture because the child has been trained to want content that confirms what they already believe. The child does not want the hard, slow work of spiritual growth because the child has been trained to want immediate satisfaction. The platform has not corrupted your child's morals, although it may have done that too. The platform has corrupted your child's desires. And desires are the engine of the spiritual life. A child who desires God will grow toward God even through difficulty. A child whose desires have been trained elsewhere will not grow toward God no matter how many programs you put them through.

This is the part where Christian parents have to make peace with the fact that this will be harder than they wanted. You will not solve it with a weekend family conversation. You will have to take a stand that costs you. And your child will resent you for a while, because you are asking them to do something their peers are not doing, and peer conformity at age twelve is its own gravitational pull. Name it. Take the loss. Take the hostility. It is the cost of what you are trying to do.

Here is what I would suggest, in practice. Five things, and none of them are easy.

First, delay. Delay hard. The research on adolescent phone use is

not ambiguous, and the delay of a personal smartphone into the teenage years is one of the most load-bearing parental decisions you will make. A dumb phone or a watch for safety is fine. A smartphone with social media and infinite access is not. Delay it until your child is old enough to have any chance of using it with some formed resistance, which is not twelve and not thirteen and, in most cases, is older than you would like. You will be in a minority. You are already in a minority by pursuing serious Christian formation. This is one of the places the minority is right.

Second, keep devices out of bedrooms. Every device, including yours. The bedroom is a sanctuary. Nothing that wants a piece of your child's attention at two in the morning gets into that room. This is non-negotiable in a serious household. It is also one of the hardest rules to keep because parents themselves break it. If you want your children to leave their phone downstairs at nine PM, you will leave yours there too. Your phone is catechizing you at the same hours it is catechizing them. The rule applies all the way up.

Third, replace before you remove. Removing screen time without replacing it with something that fills the human need the screen was meeting is a setup for failure. Children who have had their screens taken away without a richer life offered in exchange will find their way back, because nature abhors a vacuum, and a bored child is not a child on the path to deep formation. A child needs embodied life. Physical work outside. Time with animals. Time with older people. Time with younger people. Projects that take weeks to complete. Books. Real books, not audio books, though audio books are fine. Long walks. Hand tools. Sports played for love rather than trophies. Instruments. Chores that matter. Failure that is not life-ending. Conversations at a table with adults who are not performing. All of that is formation. All of it is displaced by a scrolling device. A home that fills the day with embodied life has less need for screen-time enforcement because the screen is no longer the most interesting thing in the house.

Fourth, model it. You will not win any of this if your own

attention is captured. Your children watch you. They watch you pick up your phone at the first break in conversation. They watch you disappear into it at the dinner table. They watch you fill every quiet moment with input. They know. They are being catechized by your relationship with your device as much as by their own. If you want your children to hold their phones loosely, you will have to hold yours loosely, and that means some specific practices that cost you. Phones in a basket during dinner. No phone in the bedroom. One day a week of extremely limited use. Daily time with your own Bible, in paper, at a table, where the children can see you doing it. You cannot give them a relationship with God and simultaneously model a relationship with your phone that is more intimate than your relationship with God. They will read the real one.

Fifth, talk about it openly. Your children are not blind. They know the platforms are not neutral. They often know more than you do about what the platforms are doing to them. If you come to them in humility and say, I want us, as a family, to think carefully about how these devices are forming us, and I want your help in figuring out what is wise here, you will get a more honest conversation than you expect. Children resent rules imposed from outside. They respond to invitation to think together about a real problem. Invite them. Let them surprise you. Let some of the rules come from them. They will hold rules they helped design more than ones that came down from above.

The costly hope is that attention can be retrained. It is slow. It is difficult. But a child whose attention has been fed for years on the platforms can, with time and discipline and help, recover the capacity for slower, deeper attention. I have seen it happen. It requires the parent to be in the process with the child. It requires the household to change. It cannot be done to the child. It has to be done with them.

There is no Christian formation without trained attention. There is no trained attention without protection from the forces actively training it the other way. That protection is the parent's job. Nobody else will do it for you. The schools will not. The church cannot. The

broader culture is the one doing the harm. You stand between your child and a system built to harvest them. Stand there. It is one of the most pastoral things a parent can do.

And when you fall short of this, which you will, go back to the principle we learned two chapters ago. Repair. Admit what you are doing. Tell your children you are trying to get better at it too. Let them see you struggle with this the way they struggle with it. Do not pretend you have it under control if you do not. The honesty will go further than the rules.

The next chapter is about the thing your child watched before they watched your phone. The thing they have been watching since the day they were born. Your marriage. And what it is teaching them about God, love, and the possibility of covenant.

But I want to close this chapter with a word to the parent who has already handed the phone over and is now trying to get it back. Because undoing a decision is harder than making one, and the parents living inside the regret of premature screen access need something more than guilt.

You are not the only one. You are not even in the minority. Most parents I counsel gave their children a device earlier than they now wish they had. They did it because the child was the last one in their friend group without one. They did it because the school required a device. They did it because the child was bored and the parent was tired and the screen was the easiest solution. They did it because they did not know what the device would do to the child's attention, sleep, social development, and spiritual life. Now they know. And the knowing feels like an indictment.

Let me offer something other than guilt. You made a decision with incomplete information. The research on adolescent mental health and smartphone use has developed rapidly in the last several years. What we know now, we did not know five years ago. And even what we did know five years ago was not being communicated clearly by the people selling the devices. You are not a bad parent for

making that decision. You are a parent who now has better information and needs a strategy for acting on it.

Do not give up. The battle for your child's attention is the battle for your child's soul. Fight it with patience, with honesty, with your own example, and with the confidence that the God who formed your child's mind is greater than the algorithm that is trying to capture it.

I want to add one more dimension to this conversation about screens, because it touches the question of worship in a way most parents have not considered.

Worship is not a Sunday activity. Worship is the orientation of a person's deepest attention toward whatever they regard as most worthy. The phone is a worship device. It trains attention. It directs desire. It forms what the user regards as most worthy of their time, their emotion, their energy. When a child spends four hours a day on a device, they are being formed in worship. The question is what they are worshipping.

The algorithm does not care about your child's soul. The algorithm cares about engagement. It measures what your child watches longest, what they click on most, what produces the strongest emotional response, and it feeds them more of that thing. Over time, the algorithm learns your child better than your child knows themselves. It knows their fears, their insecurities, their desires, their triggers. And it exploits all of them. Not because the algorithm is evil in a moral sense. Because the algorithm is designed to capture attention, and captured attention is the raw material of profit.

When Paul wrote that we should take every thought captive to Christ, he was describing what happens when a person's attention is oriented toward the right thing. The phone is doing the opposite. It is taking every thought captive to the feed. And the child whose thoughts are captive to the feed is a child whose worship is being redirected without their knowledge or consent.

I want you to think about what your child is worshiping when they are on their phone. If they are scrolling social media, they are worshiping the opinion of their peers. If they are watching content about body image, they are worshiping appearance. If they are consuming outrage content, they are worshiping the feeling of being right. If they are gaming for hours, they are worshiping achievement in a world that offers faster rewards than the real one. None of these are neutral activities. All of them are forming what your child considers worthy of their deepest attention. And whatever has your child's deepest attention has your child's worship.

The Christian response to this is not to ban all technology. That is neither possible nor wise. The Christian response is to teach your child to think about attention the way a disciple thinks about worship. Where is your attention going. What is it forming in you. Is the thing that has your attention worthy of it. Is it making you more like Christ or less like Him. Those questions, asked regularly, in the context of a household where the parents are asking the same questions about their own attention, produce a child who can use technology without being used by it. That distinction, between use and mastery, is the distinction Paul makes in 1 Corinthians 6:12 when he says all things are lawful for me, but I will not be mastered by anything.

I have started asking my sons a question when I see them on their phones for extended periods. It is not, how long have you been on that. It is, what is that doing to you. The question is different. The first question is about time. The second question is about formation. And the second question invites the child to think about what is happening inside them, not what they owe the parent in terms of compliance.

My sons do not always like the question. But they have started asking it of themselves. And a child who can ask, what is this doing to me, is a child who is learning to steward their own attention. That stewardship is one of the most important skills a young person can develop in this generation. Because the forces competing for their attention are fierce, relentless, and growing. And the only defense

against a captured attention is a trained one.

Train their attention. Not by taking the phone away forever. By teaching them what attention is, what it costs, what it produces, and where it belongs. Teach them that attention is the currency of the soul. And then teach them, by your own example, to spend that currency on things that are worthy.

CHAPTER 8

Marriage as the First Classroom

Before your child watched you pray, they watched you love your spouse. Before they heard you read Scripture, they heard you argue. Before they saw you worship on Sunday morning, they saw you at the breakfast table, and they saw whether the person across the table from you was treated with tenderness or with indifference. Your marriage is the first classroom your child ever attended, and they enrolled on the day they were born.

Name it. Most Christian parents think about their marriage and their parenting as two separate concerns. Marriage is the relationship between the two adults. Parenting is what they do for the children. The two overlap at practical points. Scheduling. Discipline decisions. Financial priorities. But most parents do not think of their marriage as a formation environment for their children. It is. It is the primary one in the house, because it teaches the child, at the level below argument, what love is, what covenant looks like, whether commitment is real, and whether God's promises can be trusted.

A child watching a marriage is learning theology. They are learning a theology of love. Is love patient, or does it erupt when it is inconvenienced. Is love sacrificial, or does it keep a running scoreboard of who has given more. Is love honest, or does it perform in public and deteriorate in private. Is love durable, or does it fracture under pressure and never get repaired. The child is not thinking in these categories. The child is absorbing them. The categories are being written into the child's assumptions about what human relationships are, what God's relationship with His people looks like, and whether the kind of love the Bible describes actually exists or whether it is aspirational fiction.

I have watched this play out for two decades. The families where the children's faith was most durable were not the families with the best children's ministry involvement. They were the families where the marriage was alive. Where the parents were kind to each other in the kitchen. Where the father looked at the mother with something in his eyes that the children could see. Where conflict happened, because it happens in every marriage, but where repair happened too, and the children watched both. Those children grew up believing that covenant is real, because they saw it. They grew up believing that love can survive difficulty, because they watched it. They grew up with an intuitive trust in the faithfulness of God, because the first covenant they observed, the marriage of their parents, was a covenant that held.

The reverse is also true. I have watched children grow up in homes where the marriage was cold. Not violent. Not dramatic. Cold. The parents functioned as coworkers. They managed the household. They divided responsibilities. They slept in the same bed and lived in separate emotional worlds. The children, in those homes, grew up with a theology of love that was functional rather than intimate. God is useful. God provides. God manages the world. But God is not close. God does not know you. God does not delight in you. The children absorbed the emotional temperature of the marriage and projected it onto God. And the god they ended up with was a manager, not a father.

Reframe it. Your marriage is not a background condition to the work of forming your children. It is the foreground. It is the primary text the child is reading. Every other text, the Bible, the sermon, the devotional, is read against the backdrop of the marriage. If the marriage says love is real, the other texts confirm it. If the marriage says love is a performance, the other texts are undermined by it. You cannot teach your child about the love of God while living in a marriage that contradicts it. The child will believe the marriage.

Let me name specific things a child learns from watching a marriage. These are the invisible lessons that no curriculum teaches

and no program can replace.

The child learns about conflict. Every marriage has conflict. The question is what the conflict teaches the child. In a marriage where conflict is avoided, the child learns that disagreement is dangerous, that peace means the absence of honest conversation, and that love cannot survive a hard truth. In a marriage where conflict is explosive, the child learns that love is volatile, that anger is power, that words said in heat are normal, and that you never know when the safe person will become unsafe. In a marriage where conflict happens honestly and is repaired faithfully, the child learns something rare and precious. They learn that two people can disagree, can even hurt each other, and can come back together. They learn that repair is real. They learn that love is not the absence of conflict but the commitment to stay in the room and do the work. That is a theology. It is the theology of a God who does not abandon His people when they fail Him. The child learns it from watching their parents fight and recover.

I want to tell you something about my own marriage, because I owe it to the argument. Susanna and I have had seasons where the marriage was not teaching our sons what we wanted it to teach. There was a year, not long ago, where ministry demands and personal exhaustion had pushed us into a functional partnership rather than an intimate marriage. We were efficient. We were not close. And one of our boys, the one with the eyes that miss nothing, said to Susanna one evening: you and Dad do not laugh together anymore. He was not criticizing us. He was observing. And his observation was devastating in its accuracy. We had stopped laughing. We had stopped looking at each other with the thing that the children needed to see. We had become coworkers in a household, and the household was running, but the marriage was not alive, and the children knew it.

That observation was a turning point for us. We made a decision, together, to invest in the marriage as a spiritual act on behalf of our children. Not because the children needed to see a perfect marriage. Because they needed to see a marriage that was being tended. A marriage where the adults were choosing each other. A marriage

where the kindness was not accidental but deliberate. We started dating again. Not as a formula. As a need. We started praying together again, as a couple, not in front of the children but for each other, because the intimacy of a shared prayer life between husband and wife creates a warmth in the home that the children can feel even when they do not know what it is.

The child learns about affection. Physical affection between a husband and wife, in age-appropriate ways, in front of the children, teaches the child that love is not abstract. It has a body. It is expressed. It is given and received. I kiss Susanna in the kitchen. I hold her hand at the table. I hug her when she walks in the door. I am not performing. I am doing what married people who love each other do. And my sons are watching, and they are learning what a man who loves a woman looks like. They are learning that tenderness is not weakness. That affection is not embarrassing. That a marriage that has physical warmth is a marriage that is alive. Some of you reading this have stopped touching your spouse in front of your children because the marriage has grown cold or because you are uncomfortable. Your children have noticed. They are learning from the absence of affection as much as they would learn from its presence.

The child learns about respect. How a husband speaks to his wife and how a wife speaks to her husband is one of the most formative things in a household. A husband who dismisses his wife, who corrects her in front of the children, who treats her opinions as less important than his own, is teaching his sons how to treat women and teaching his daughters what to accept from men. A wife who belittles her husband, who criticizes him in front of the children, who rolls her eyes at his ideas, is teaching the same lessons in reverse. Children are cataloging every interaction. They are building a database of what marriage looks like. That database will be their reference when they are old enough to form relationships of their own. Whatever is in it will feel normal to them, because it is what they grew up with.

The child learns about forgiveness. This may be the most

important lesson of all. Your child needs to see you forgive your spouse. Not in a general sense. Specifically. They need to hear you say to your husband, or your wife, in the aftermath of a conflict that the children witnessed: I was wrong. I am sorry. Will you forgive me. And they need to hear the other person say: yes. That exchange, repeated over years, teaches the child more about the gospel than any sermon can. Because the gospel is the story of a God who forgives, and the child who has watched forgiveness in action, in the most important relationship in the house, has a frame for receiving and giving forgiveness that the child who has never seen it does not have.

I want to address a difficult reality. Some of you reading this are in marriages that are not well. The marriage is strained. The affection is gone. The conflict is constant or the silence is total. And you are reading this chapter with a growing weight, because you know what your marriage is teaching your children and you do not know how to change it.

Hear me. I am not writing this chapter to add guilt. I am writing it to name the thing honestly, because naming it is the first step toward changing it. If your marriage is not teaching your children what you want it to teach, the answer is not to perform a better marriage in front of them. They will see through the performance. The answer is to actually tend the marriage. To get help. To go to a counselor. To talk to your pastor. To start doing the work of repair that has been deferred for months or years. That work is not a distraction from the work of raising your children. It is the work of raising your children, because the marriage is the first classroom and you cannot reform the classroom while the curriculum stays broken.

Let me also speak to the question of what the marriage teaches about covenant. We live in a culture that treats commitment as provisional. You commit until you do not want to commit anymore. You stay until staying costs more than leaving. Children absorb that message from every direction. The marriage in the home is the counter-message. It is the place where the child sees two people who have made a promise and who are keeping it. Not because keeping it

is easy. Not because every day is good. Because the promise is real. Because covenant means something. Because the vows are load-bearing.

When your child sees you choose your spouse on a hard day, choose to be kind when you are tired, choose to stay when staying is difficult, you are teaching them that covenant is not a contract. A contract has exit clauses. A covenant has steadfastness. And the God of the Bible is a covenant God. He does not exit. He does not leave. He does not abandon. Your marriage, kept in faithfulness over decades, is the child's first evidence that this is true.

The costly hope is this. It is not too late to change what your marriage is teaching. Even if the children are older. Even if the damage has been done. A marriage that begins to heal in front of the children, that begins to warm after a cold season, that begins to show signs of genuine renewal, teaches the children something about restoration that changes the air in a home. It teaches them that dead things can come alive. That cold things can be warmed. That broken covenants can be repaired. And if that is true in a marriage, maybe it is true with God. Maybe restoration is not a theory. Maybe it is the way God actually works. The children will believe it if they see it.

Tend your marriage. Not for the marriage alone. For the children who are watching it, learning from it, and building their theology of love from what they see in it every day.

I want to add one more practical word before we leave this chapter. If you are in a marriage that is alive, guard it. The forces working against a Christian marriage in this culture are relentless. Exhaustion, distraction, unresolved conflict, the slow drift of two people who stop choosing each other because the logistics of life have replaced the intimacy. Guard against all of it. Make time for each other that is not about the children. Talk about something other than the schedule. Pray together, even when you do not feel like it. Confess to each other. Forgive each other. Touch each other. Laugh together. Your children need you to do these things, not because they

are watching a performance, but because they are absorbing a reality. The reality of a marriage that is being tended is a reality that teaches them what God's faithfulness looks like.

If you are in a marriage that is not alive, do not resign yourself to it.

Talk to each other first. Not about the children. Not about the schedule. About what has gone cold between you and why. Many marriages die not from a single catastrophe but from a thousand small neglects. The conversation that was skipped because you were tired. The touch that stopped because the affection felt forced. The prayer you used to pray together that you stopped praying because it felt awkward after a fight you never resolved. Those small neglects accumulate. And the accumulation eventually produces a marriage where two people share a house but not a life.

I have counseled couples who sat in my office and could not remember the last time they had a conversation that was not about logistics. When I asked them what they talked about when they were dating, they both got quiet. They remembered. They remembered talking about their dreams. Their fears. Their faith. What they wanted their life to look like. What they believed about God. Those conversations had been replaced, gradually, by conversations about who was picking up the children and whether the mortgage payment had cleared. The replacement was not deliberate. It was erosional. Life eroded the intimacy, and nobody noticed until the river had cut through to bare rock.

The repair begins with a decision. Not a feeling. A decision. We are going to talk to each other again about things that matter. We are going to pray together again. We are going to touch each other with tenderness, even when tenderness does not come naturally, because discipline precedes desire and the tenderness will follow the decision if we sustain it. That decision is not romantic. It is covenantal. And covenantal decisions are the ones that save marriages.

I also want to speak to the specific dynamic I have seen in

ministry marriages, because I live inside it. The pastor's marriage carries a weight that other marriages do not. Not because the pastor is more important. Because the pastor's marriage is more visible, more scrutinized, and more subject to the demands of a community that does not always understand what it is asking. The pastor gives emotional energy to the congregation all week. The congregation expects the pastor to be available, to be present, to be steady. And the person who absorbs the cost of that expenditure is the spouse.

Susanna has told me, more than once, that she sometimes feels like she gets whatever is left over after the church has taken what it needs. She is not wrong. There have been seasons where I gave the best of my energy to the congregation and came home with the scraps. Where I was patient with church members and impatient with her. Where I listened carefully to a counseling appointment and dismissed her concerns at the dinner table. That is not pastoral faithfulness. That is pastoral idolatry. Making the church the center rather than the God of the church, and sacrificing the marriage on the altar of ministry productivity.

If you are in ministry, hear me. Your marriage is not an obstacle to your ministry. Your marriage is your first ministry. If you are preaching about the love of God on Sunday and your spouse does not feel loved by you on Tuesday, something is broken, and the thing that is broken is not the sermon schedule. It is you. Fix the Tuesday before you preach the Sunday.

I have had to learn this the hard way. More than once. And each time I have had to learn it, the lesson has been the same. The congregation can survive a week without my best. Susanna should not have to. The children should not have to. The household is the first call on my energy, and when I get that order wrong, everything else suffers, including the ministry I was prioritizing over the household.

Let me also say a word about physical intimacy in marriage, because it matters to the argument of this chapter even though it is

not something most Christian parenting books address. Your children are not aware of the details of your physical relationship with your spouse. But they are aware of its effects. A marriage where physical intimacy is alive produces a different emotional climate in the home than a marriage where it has gone dormant. The warmth between the parents, the ease of touch, the look that passes between them in the kitchen, the willingness to be close, all of these are visible to the children even when the intimacy itself is private. The child does not know why the house feels warm. The child feels that it is warm. And that warmth is part of the formation environment.

When physical intimacy dies in a marriage, it takes emotional warmth with it. The parents become roommates. The children feel the chill. I am not reducing marriage to the bedroom. I am saying that the bedroom affects the kitchen, and the kitchen is where the children eat, and the meals they eat in a warm kitchen form them differently than the meals they eat in a cold one.

Guard the whole marriage. Not the parts the children see. The whole thing. Because the children are formed by the whole thing, whether they can name what they are sensing or not.

Seek help. Talk to your pastor. Find a counselor. Read the books that have helped others. Do the work. Not because a dead marriage is a personal failure, though it may involve confession. Because the children in your house are building their theology of love from what they see, and what they see right now is not what you want them to carry. The repair of a marriage, done in front of children over months and years, teaches them that dead things can be raised. That is a resurrection theology. It is the most Christian thing a married couple can do.

And if your marriage has ended, through death or divorce, hear this.

The formation of your children is not over. The household looks different now. The catechism has changed. But the four channels are still running. What you praise, what you worry about, what you

repeat, what you rest in. Those channels are still forming your children. And the way you handle the grief, the transition, the rebuilding, is itself formation.

A parent who grieves honestly, who leans on God in the brokenness, who refuses to become bitter, who keeps loving the children through the upheaval, is teaching a theology of resilience that the child in the intact marriage may never learn. Your household is not disqualified. It is different. And God is in different the same way He is in whole.

Let me speak specifically to the parent walking through divorce, because the formation challenges are particular. Your children are watching how you treat their other parent. They are watching whether you speak with bitterness or with restraint. They are watching whether you use them as messengers or as weapons or as people. They are watching whether the faith you profess survives the worst thing that has happened to your family.

I have counseled parents who handled divorce in ways that devastated their children's faith. Not through the divorce itself. Through the behavior during and after the divorce. The parent who badmouthed the other parent in front of the children. The parent who used the children as leverage. The parent who became so consumed by their own pain that the children's pain became invisible. In each case, the child's theology of love, covenant, and faithfulness was damaged not by the fact of the divorce but by the conduct of the parents during it.

I have also counseled parents who handled divorce in ways that preserved and even deepened their children's faith. The parent who said, your father and I could not make our marriage work, and that is a grief I carry, but he is still your father and I will not speak against him in this house. The parent who said, I am angry and I am hurt, and I am bringing those things to God because they are too big for me to carry alone. The parent who prioritized the children's stability over their own need to process publicly.

Those parents taught their children something about grace under pressure that no sermon could have taught. They taught it by living it, at the hardest moment of their lives, in front of the people who needed to see it most.

If you are in that situation, hear me. Your conduct during and after the divorce is one of the most significant formation moments in your children's lives. You did not choose the situation. You can choose the conduct. And the conduct you choose will form your children's understanding of what it means to follow Jesus when everything falls apart. Choose well. Not perfectly. Well. With as much grace and restraint and honesty as you can gather, and with the confidence that God is forming your children through this, even through this, if you will let Him.

The next chapter is for the parents of teenagers, because the teenage years are the season when everything we have discussed goes underground, and the parent must learn an entirely different posture.

CHAPTER 9

The Teenage Years, When Formation Goes Underground

There is a day that comes for every parent, and you will not see it coming. Your child, who used to tell you everything, stops telling you things. Your child, who used to crawl into your lap during family worship, sits on the other side of the room and says nothing. Your child, who used to ask you questions about God at bedtime, starts putting in earbuds the moment they get in the car. The door that was open is closing, and you did not hear it happen. You only noticed the silence.

Name it. The teenage years are the season when formation goes underground. Everything you have been building in the first twelve or thirteen years of your child's life does not disappear. It goes below the surface. The child who was open becomes private. The child who was eager becomes skeptical. The child who was compliant becomes confrontational or withdrawn. And the parent, who had gotten used to a certain kind of access, suddenly has very little. The adolescent is pulling away. Not necessarily from the faith. From you. From dependence. From the childhood version of themselves. They are becoming a separate person, and the process of becoming a separate person requires distance from the people they are separating from, which is you.

This is normal. It is also agonizing. Because from the parent's perspective, it feels like loss. It feels like the child is drifting. It feels like the work of formation has stopped, or worse, has been undone. The parent panics. The panic produces one of two wrong responses. Either the parent grips harder, increasing control, increasing surveillance, increasing the pressure to perform the old patterns of

closeness. Or the parent withdraws, interpreting the adolescent's distance as rejection, and matching distance with distance.

Both responses damage the very thing they are trying to protect. The parent who grips harder produces an adolescent who either submits in resentment or rebels in desperation. The parent who withdraws produces an adolescent who interprets the withdrawal as confirmation that their pulling away was wrong, that the parent's love was conditional on the child's accessibility. Neither response leads to a young adult with a mature faith. Both responses lead to a young adult who learned, during the most critical years of their identity formation, that the parent could not handle who they were becoming.

Reframe it. The adolescent pulling away is not the end of formation. It is the most critical phase of formation. Everything that has been planted in the first twelve years is now being tested. The child is testing it. The culture is testing it. The child's own doubt and desire are testing it. And the test cannot happen under the parent's supervision. That is the terrible truth. The faith that was formed in proximity to you must now be tested in distance from you, or it will never become the child's own.

Think of it this way. For the first twelve years, the child's faith was held inside the parent's faith. The child believed because the parent believed. The child prayed because the parent prayed. The child attended church because the parent took them. The child's faith was, in a real sense, the parent's faith, borrowed. During adolescence, the child must decide whether to keep it. Whether to make it their own. Whether the faith they inherited is the faith they will carry. That decision cannot be made under supervision. It can only be made in the privacy of the adolescent's own mind and heart. And the parent's role, during this phase, is not to control the decision. It is to be present enough that the child knows there is a safe place to land, whatever the decision turns out to be.

I have five sons. Some of them have been through this already. Others are in it now. I can tell you, from the inside of it, that nothing

in my pastoral training prepared me for the experience of watching my own child work out their faith in a way I could not direct. I could preach about it. I could counsel other parents about it. But when it was my son closing the bedroom door, my son answering my questions in monosyllables, my son showing no visible interest in the things that used to light him up, I felt the same fear every parent feels. And I had to do the thing I counseled other parents to do, which was to keep my hands open rather than clenched.

Let me tell you what the adolescent brain is actually doing, because the neuroscience matters here. The teenage brain is undergoing a massive reorganization. The prefrontal cortex, which handles executive function, long-term planning, impulse control, and the capacity to hold competing ideas in tension, is not fully developed until the mid-twenties. During adolescence, the brain is being pruned and rewired. The emotional centers are running at full power. The rational centers are still under construction. This means the adolescent is feeling everything at maximum intensity while having a diminished capacity to process those feelings with the kind of balance an adult has.

This is why teenagers are so confusing to their parents. The teenager feels with the intensity of an adult but processes with the capacity of a still-developing brain. They are not choosing to be irrational. Their brain is in a construction zone. And the faith they are evaluating is being evaluated by a brain that processes ideas through the emotional centers first. This means the adolescent's experience of faith is heavily mediated by feelings. If God feels distant, God is distant. If prayer feels empty, prayer is meaningless. If church feels boring, church has nothing for them. The parent who tries to argue the teenager out of their feelings with logic is arguing against a brain that is not wired to receive the argument yet.

This does not mean you abandon logic. It means you lead with relationship. The adolescent brain is wired for relationship above almost everything else. Peer relationships become paramount. But parental relationship does not disappear. It goes underground, like

everything else. The teenager who will not talk to you at the dinner table is still tracking whether you are present. They are tracking whether you notice their absence. They are tracking whether you care enough to keep trying even when they are giving you nothing back. They are watching from behind the closed door to see if you are still there.

Here is what I have learned about parenting teenagers in the faith. Five things, earned at cost.

First, reduce the number of hills you are willing to die on. When children are small, the parent sets the boundaries on everything. When children are teenagers, the parent must choose which boundaries are essential and which are negotiable. If you fight over everything, hair, music, friends, curfew, phone, chores, church attendance, clothing, language, you will lose the teenager entirely, because they will conclude that you are more interested in control than in relationship. Choose your battles. Hold the line on safety, on moral integrity, on respect in the household. Be flexible on the rest. The teenager who has some agency, some space to make choices you would not make, is a teenager who is learning to be a person. That learning is messy. It is also necessary.

Second, stay in the room. When the teenager pushes you away, stay in the room. Not physically. The teenager needs physical space. Stay in the room relationally. Keep asking about their day, even when you get one-word answers. Keep inviting them to things, even when they say no. Keep telling them you love them, even when they roll their eyes. Keep making their favorite meal. Keep being interested in what they are interested in, even when their interests confuse or concern you. The parent who stays in the room, who refuses to withdraw even when the teenager withdraws, is the parent the teenager comes back to when the phase shifts. And the phase will shift. It always does. But the parent who was there when it shifts is in a different position than the parent who left.

Third, answer the questions they are not asking aloud. Teenagers

are asking theological questions with their behavior, even when they are not asking them with their words. The teenager who refuses to go to church is asking: is this faith real or is it forced. The teenager who starts dating someone the parent disapproves of is asking: will you love me if I do not do what you want. The teenager who experiments with ideas that contradict the family's beliefs is asking: is this faith strong enough to survive examination. These are not rebellions. They are questions dressed in the clothing of rebellion. The parent who sees the question underneath the behavior can respond to the question rather than reacting to the behavior. That changes everything.

Fourth, let them see your faith in its adult complexity. When children are small, you give them faith in simple terms. God loves you. Jesus died for you. The Bible is true. When children are teenagers, those simple terms are not enough anymore. The teenager needs to see that faith has an adult version. That it can hold doubt. That it has wrestled with hard questions. That it has survived suffering. That it is not naive. If the only version of faith the teenager has seen is the children's version, they will discard it, because they are no longer a child. Give them the adult version. Tell them about the hard parts of your faith. Tell them about the time you almost lost it. Tell them about the questions you still carry. Tell them about the books that challenged you and the arguments that made you think. Show them that faith is not something you outgrow. It is something that grows with you, into the hardest parts of adult life.

Fifth, pray more and lecture less. During the teenage years, the parent's primary spiritual work for the child shifts from instruction to intercession. You have said what you needed to say. You have planted what you could plant. Now you pray. You pray specifically. You pray by name. You pray for their friends, because their friends are shaping them right now more than you are. You pray for their minds, because their minds are being exposed to ideas that challenge everything you taught them. You pray for their hearts, because their hearts are being drawn in multiple directions and you cannot control which one wins. You pray for the Holy Spirit to do what only the Holy Spirit can do,

which is to take the seeds you planted and bring them to life in a soul you can no longer reach directly.

I want to address one more thing. Many parents of teenagers are terrified that they started too late. They did not do the work in the early years. They did not build the household catechism. They did not answer the questions. They outsourced to the church. And now the teenager is pulling away and the parent has very little foundation to work with. If that is you, I want to be honest. It is harder. Starting at fourteen is harder than starting at four. But it is not impossible. Because God is not bound by your timeline. And a parent who begins to be real with a teenager, who starts being honest about their own failures, who starts asking rather than lecturing, who starts being present rather than controlling, can rebuild a relationship that becomes the bridge the teenager crosses when they are ready.

The teenage years are not the years you lose your child. They are the years your child decides whether to keep what you gave them. Your role is not to force the decision. It is to be the kind of person they want to come back to when the decision is made. That is enough. It does not feel like enough. It is.

Let me tell you a story about my own household, because it illustrates what I mean. One of my older sons went through a season, around age fifteen, where he stopped wanting to go to church. He did not announce a departure from the faith. He did not give a speech. He started saying he was tired on Sunday mornings. He started finding reasons to stay home. He was not hostile. He was distant. And I felt the fear rise in me, the same fear I have counseled dozens of other parents through.

My first instinct was to mandate attendance. My son lives under my roof. He will go to church. That instinct came from fear, not from wisdom. Susanna and I talked about it. We prayed about it. And we decided to take a different approach. We told him that church attendance was important to our family and that we wanted him there. We also told him that we were not going to force him, because

forced worship is not worship. We told him that if he chose not to come on a particular Sunday, that was his decision, and we would love him the same way regardless. We asked him to tell us honestly what was going on.

He told us. He said church felt boring. He said the sermons did not connect to his life. He said he felt like he was going through motions. He was not rejecting God. He was rejecting the experience as he was having it. That is different. And because we listened rather than reacted, we learned something we would not have learned if we had forced him into the car.

We made some changes. I started talking with him after services about what the sermon was about, not as a quiz but as a conversation. I asked him what he disagreed with. I asked him what confused him. I let him push back on things I had said from the pulpit. That was uncomfortable for me. It was essential for him. Over the course of several months, he came back. Not because we forced him. Because we made the faith a conversation rather than a mandate. He is engaged now in a way he was not before, and I believe the engagement is deeper because it was chosen rather than coerced.

Not every story ends that way. Some teenagers pull away and stay away for a long time. Some never come back to church, even if they come back to God. The point of the story is not the outcome. The point is the posture. The parent who listens, who does not panic, who keeps the relationship above the compliance, is the parent who gives the teenager the best chance of owning the faith for themselves. Whether they take that chance is not in your hands. The posture is.

One final word for the parent of a teenager who is in a genuinely dark place. Not questioning the faith. In a dark place. Using substances. In a destructive relationship. Engaging in self-harm. Expressing hopelessness. That is a different situation than the one I described above. That situation requires intervention, not patience. If your teenager is in danger, get help. Talk to a counselor. Talk to your pastor. Do not wait for the phase to pass. Some phases do not pass on

their own. The parent who intervenes in a crisis, who says I love you too much to watch this happen, is not violating the teenager's autonomy. They are exercising parental love at its highest and most costly level. Do not confuse the patience I described for ordinary adolescence with passivity in the face of genuine danger. They are not the same thing.

Let me add a few more things about the teenage years that I have learned from the inside of them.

The first is about the role of the teenager's friends. During adolescence, the peer group becomes the primary social world. This is normal. It is also terrifying for parents, because the peer group is shaping your child in ways you cannot control and often cannot see. The friends your teenager chooses are, in a real sense, choosing the catechism your teenager will absorb during the most impressionable years of their life.

This does not mean you should choose your teenager's friends for them. That level of control will produce rebellion, not formation. But it does mean you should know who your teenager's friends are. Invite them to your house. Feed them. Talk to them. Watch how your child acts around them. A teenager who becomes a different person in the presence of certain friends is a teenager whose formation is being pulled in a direction you need to understand.

I have made it a practice to make our home the gathering place. I want my sons' friends in our house rather than my sons in houses I do not know. This is not surveillance. It is hospitality with a purpose. When the friends are in our home, I can see the dynamic. I can hear the conversations. I can observe whether these friends bring out the best in my son or something else. And my son, who sees me being kind to his friends, does not feel policed. He feels that his world is welcome in our world.

There have been friendships I was concerned about. In those cases, I did not forbid the friendship. I named what I saw. I told my son what concerned me. I asked him what he thought. And I trusted

him with the decision, while making clear that I was watching because I loved him, not because I did not trust him. In some cases, the friendship ran its course. In others, my son made the decision I was hoping he would make. In one case, my son told me I was wrong about the friend, and he was right. I had misjudged. The friend turned out to be a good influence. I told my son I was wrong and thanked him for helping me see it.

The second thing I want to say about the teenage years is about the role of other adults. Your teenager needs adults in their life who are not you. Adults they respect. Adults who share your faith. Adults they can talk to when they cannot talk to you. This is not a failure of your parenting. It is a feature of adolescent development. The teenager is individuating from you, and part of that individuation requires them to find other models of adult faith.

A youth pastor, a mentor, a coach, a family friend, an uncle or aunt, a grandparent. These people are not replacing you. They are extending you. They are giving your teenager a way to see that the faith you hold is not something peculiar to your household. It is something other adults hold too, in their own way, with their own stories. And the teenager who sees the faith confirmed in multiple adult lives is a teenager whose faith is more likely to survive the testing.

I have intentionally placed my sons in relationship with other men in our church who I trust. Men who will tell my sons the truth. Men who will pray with them. Men who will not let them get away with things they should not get away with. My sons have conversations with those men that they do not have with me. I am not offended by that. I am grateful for it. Because my sons need to hear the faith from more than one voice. And the more voices they hear it from, the harder it is to dismiss as one man's opinion.

The third thing is this. The teenage years will end. I say this to the parent in the middle of them who cannot see the end. The withdrawal will ease. The resistance will soften. The door that is closed will open

again. Not on your timeline. On theirs. But it will open. And the parent who was still standing at the door when it opens, who did not walk away, who did not retaliate, who did not match the teenager's distance with distance of their own, that parent will be the one the young adult comes back to.

I have watched this happen enough times that I can say it with confidence. The parents who stay, who keep loving, who keep praying, who keep the relationship above the rules, those parents see their children come back. Not always to church. Not always on the parent's terms. But back. Back to relationship. Back to conversation. Back to the faith they tested and found, after testing it, that it was real.

The teenage years are a tunnel. It is dark in the tunnel. The parent cannot see where the tunnel goes. But there is light at the other end. And the parent who keeps walking, keeps praying, keeps loving, will emerge from the tunnel with their child. Changed, both of them. Deeper, both of them. And connected in a way that the easy years of childhood could never have produced.

Trust the process. Not the therapeutic cliché. The actual, theological process. God is at work in your teenager. The Holy Spirit is pursuing them with a persistence that exceeds your own. Your job is not to be the Holy Spirit. Your job is to stay close enough that when the Spirit does His work, your teenager has someone safe to tell about it.

The next chapter is for the fathers, because everything I have described in the last several chapters depends, in a particular way, on the presence and posture of the man in the house.

CHAPTER 10

Fathers, Presence, and the Weight of Blessing

I grew up without a father. I have said it once already in this book and I will say it a few more times before the end, because it is the place everything in me starts. I know what absence does to a boy. I know what it does to a girl. I have watched it work its slow damage in the lives of the men I have pastored for twenty years. And I know something else. I know that the conversation about fatherhood in Christian circles has gotten so sentimental that it no longer lands on the men who most need it. So this chapter is going to be blunt. If you are a father reading this, I am asking you to be in the indictment with me, because I am in it too.

Name it. American Christian fatherhood has become largely ornamental. In a great many professing Christian homes, the father is physically present and spiritually peripheral. He provides. He appears for the big moments. He takes his family to church. He is not absent in any legal sense. He is absent in the sense that matters most for the formation of his children, which is the sense in which his interior life before God is not visible to his children, and therefore is not shaping them. He is around. He is not present.

This absence has a signature. Ask a child in a Christian home who prays for them by name at night. In the homes where the mother does it, God bless her, she is often doing it alone. Ask who reads Scripture with them. Often the mother. Ask who walks them through the hard conversations about life, purpose, sin, sex, failure, calling. Often the mother, or no one. Ask who blesses them when they leave the house. Often no one. The father is at work, or he is on his phone, or he is decompressing, or he is not thinking about it. He is not antagonistic

to the faith. He is not carrying the weight.

I have a theory about why this happens, and it goes deeper than laziness. Most Christian men were not fathered well themselves. Their own fathers, if they were present at all, modeled a version of fatherhood that was economic at best and absent at worst. The previous generation of Christian fathers provided and protected. Many of them did not pray with their children. They did not bless them. They did not speak over them. They did not do the intimate, exposed work of spiritual fatherhood, because nobody did it for them and because the culture told them that intimacy was the mother's domain. The current generation of Christian fathers inherited this void. They know something is missing. They do not know what it is. And because they lack a model, they default to the only version they know, which is the functional father. Present. Employed. Attending. Absent at the level where formation actually happens.

The weight is the word. The biblical image of a father is a man who carries weight on behalf of his household. The weight of provision, yes. But also the weight of prayer. The weight of blessing. The weight of correction delivered in love. The weight of deciding, often, what direction the household will face. The weight of being the first one to repent when he has been wrong. The weight of being home when his people need him to be home. The weight of being a presence, not a paycheck. A father who carries only the economic weight is not carrying the biblical weight. A father who carries the biblical weight is doing something his children are shaped by for life, whether or not they can articulate it at the time.

Reframe it. The Bible's understanding of fatherhood is not cultural. It is covenantal. The father represents something that cannot be outsourced. He represents, however imperfectly, the Fatherhood of God to his children. He is the first picture they get of what a Father is like. That is an enormous thing to put on a man, and it is supposed to be. It is supposed to drive him to his knees. It is supposed to make him afraid of getting it wrong. It is supposed to send him to the actual Father, daily, for the grace he needs to represent Him at all. A

Christian father is not a man who has figured out how to be patriarchal in the old cultural sense. He is a man who has become small enough before God to be used as a window through which his children get their first glimpses of the Father's character.

If the father is angry, the children will struggle for decades to believe God is not angry. If the father is absent, the children will often struggle to believe God is not absent. If the father is always disappointed, the children will often carry the quiet sense that they have disappointed God. If the father is harsh, the children will often pray to a harsh God, even if their theology says otherwise. Theology in the head competes with the theology in the marrow. The theology in the marrow was planted by the father. It usually wins.

I want to tell you a story. A man in my congregation came to me about three years ago. He was in his late thirties. He had two sons, ages eight and six. He had been raised in a Christian home by a father who was doctrinally precise and emotionally unavailable. The father could explain substitutionary atonement. The father had never told his son he loved him. The man sitting in my office was carrying a wound he had never named, and it was manifesting in his own fathering. He was repeating the pattern. He knew it. He did not know how to stop it. I asked him a question that changed the conversation. I asked him when the last time was that he had blessed his sons by name. He looked at me like I was speaking a foreign language. I explained what I meant. Lay your hand on your son's head. Tell him who he is. Tell him who God is making him. Speak a future over him. Speak the Aaronic blessing if you do not have your own words yet. He said he had never done that. He said his father had never done that. And he started crying, because he realized, in that moment, that the hollow place inside him was the place where a father's blessing was supposed to be.

He went home that night and blessed his eight-year-old for the first time. He told me later that his son looked at him with wide eyes and said, Dad, do that again. The boy was hungry for it. He did not know what it was called. He knew it was the thing his soul had been

waiting for.

This is why Christian fathers have to take their own formation seriously. You cannot offer your children a God you do not know. You cannot represent a Father whose face you rarely see. Your children are going to absorb your actual relationship with God, not the one you wish you had. If that relationship is thin, their inheritance from you is a thin God. If that relationship is alive, their inheritance is a living one. This is the most important pastoral work any man ever does. It is the work he is usually the least resourced to do, because the church has not usually disciplined men to do it, and because the culture has not usually given him any categories for it beyond breadwinner and occasional disciplinarian.

Let me be practical. There are three things a father can do, starting this week, that change the spiritual climate of a home more than almost anything else I can name.

The first is to bless your children by name, out loud, regularly. Not as a performance. As a pattern. Lay your hand on your child's head. Speak words of blessing over them. You are my son. I love you. I am proud of the way God is building you. May the Lord bless you and keep you. May His face shine upon you. May He give you peace. Some of you are reading that and thinking it sounds strange, maybe foreign. I understand. The first time I did it with one of my sons, I was self-conscious. I kept doing it anyway. It is now one of the most load-bearing practices in my household. My sons expect it. They want it. They ask for it when I forget. There is something in a child that is designed to receive blessing from a father and that starves without it, and starving is not too strong a word. A generation of men is walking around today with a hollow place where a father's blessing was supposed to be. Do not let your children become those men. Bless them. Now. While they are small. Keep blessing them when they are large.

The second is to pray with your children, out loud, often. Not for them. With them. Bring them into the practice. Let them hear you

thank God for specific things, by name. Let them hear you ask God for mercy when you were wrong. Let them hear you intercede for people outside the family, including people who are hard for you to love. Let them hear you bring your worries to God rather than to the television. Prayer that is practiced in front of children catechizes them in what God is for and how He is to be approached. You cannot skip this. You cannot outsource this to a grace before meals that nobody actually means. Your children should hear you pray often enough that they begin to pray the same way when you are not there. That is the mark.

The third is to repent in front of your children. This one is harder. Most men avoid it. They think authority in the home is maintained by not showing weakness. That is a cultural script. It is not a Christian one. A father who is never wrong in front of his children is teaching them that Christianity is a performance of rightness, which is the opposite of the gospel. A father who, when he has blown it, turns to his child and says I was wrong, I was short with you, that came out of my own stuff, I have asked God's forgiveness and I am asking yours, is teaching something profoundly Christian. The authority does not shrink. It grows. Because the child learns that authority in this house is not brittle. It is weighty. It is honest. It is rooted in God, not in the father's ability to pretend.

I have had to do this many times. More than I would like. I have snapped at my sons. I have been withdrawn when I should have been present. I have come home from ministry with nothing left and taken it out on the people I most love. Every time I have gone back, admitted it, asked for forgiveness, and prayed with the child about it, I have seen the relationship strengthen rather than weaken. Children do not need an unimpeachable father. They need an honest one. They need a father who is being sanctified in front of them, not a father who is pretending he has arrived.

I want to speak a specific word to fathers of sons. Your boys are watching you to learn what a man is. Our culture will not tell them. Our schools often will not tell them. The internet will tell them a

thousand broken versions of manhood in the hope of making them ashamed or making them bitter. You get the first word. Speak it. A man is a servant of God who carries weight for the sake of others. A man is not afraid to kneel before God. A man is not afraid to apologize. A man is not afraid to weep in the right contexts. A man is strong enough to be gentle. A man works hard and plays hard and protects what God has put under his care. A man is patient with his wife. A man is tender with his children. A man is honest when it costs him. Let them see it. Do not lecture them. Let them see it. They will become what they see, not what they hear.

I want to speak a word to fathers of daughters. Your daughters are watching you to learn what a man is like. They are also watching you to learn how they should expect to be treated by men. The way you love their mother is setting a template. The way you speak to your daughter is setting a template. The way you listen to her, or do not, is setting a template. One day a man will come along and try to win her. Whether she can tell a good one from a false one will have been shaped, in significant part, by you. Do not underestimate this. Do not leave it to chance. Give her so much evidence of what love looks like that she can see counterfeit at a hundred yards.

I want to speak a word, finally, to men who did not have a father, or had one whose presence wounded them. Many of you are reading this and feeling the old grief. I know. I have lived in it. I want to tell you something. Your story is not your verdict. You do not need a father who modeled it for you in order to become one. God is the Father. He is faithful to give you, over time, as you walk with Him, what no earthly father gave you. He can give it to you at thirty. He can give it to you at fifty. And the thing He gives you, you can give to your children. I am living evidence. I did not have it. He has been giving it to me for twenty-five years, slowly, and He has let me give pieces of it to my sons, and those pieces of it are carrying. If He did it for me, He will do it for you. The past did not finish you. Go to the Father. Let Him father you. Then father them.

I want to add a word here that I have not seen in other books on

fatherhood, and it is about the specific temptation of the ministry father. I am one. I know this temptation from the inside. The ministry father gives his best hours, his best energy, and his best emotional availability to the congregation. He comes home spent. He has been present all day, for other people's families. He has nothing left for his own. His wife sees it. His children see it. The children learn that other people's needs come before theirs. That God's work, as represented by the church, is more important than God's work in this home. That the pastor's family is the sacrifice the pastor makes for the ministry.

That is a lie. It is a lie that has destroyed more pastoral families than I can count. The ministry father who gives his family the leftovers is not honoring God with his ministry. He is dishonoring God with his household. And his children will carry that dishonor into their own relationship with God and with the church, often for decades.

I have been in this sin. There have been seasons when I gave my church my best and gave my family my empty. And the result was predictable. My sons pulled away. Not from God. From me. Because they learned that they were secondary. That the congregation came first. That their father's attention was a scarce resource that other people consumed before they could get to it.

The correction has been painful and ongoing. I have had to learn to leave the office. To turn off the phone. To tell a congregant that my evening belongs to my family. To resist the savior complex that tells me I must be available to everyone at all times. The church will survive without me for an evening. My sons will not survive without a father who is present.

If you are a pastor or a ministry worker reading this, hear me. Your family is your first ministry. Not your second. Not your backup. Your first. The congregation is important. Your family is primary. If you get that order wrong, you may build a great ministry and lose your children. I have watched it happen. Do not let it happen to you.

The costly hope for fathers is this. You already have access to everything you need. You do not need a book. You do not need a conference. You need to take the spiritual center of your home. You need to start blessing your children by name. You need to start praying with them out loud. You need to start repenting openly. You need to let them see, by your pattern of life, that a man's first work is before God, and everything else he does flows from that work or does not flow at all.

The next chapter is for parents in a different situation. For the single mother, the single father, the blended family, the household that does not look like the one I have described. It matters. God is in that household too.

But before we go there, I want to add something about the father who did not have a father. Because I am that man, and there are many of us, and the absence creates a particular kind of difficulty when it comes to the formation of your own children.

When you did not have a model, you are building the plane while flying it. You do not have a template. You do not have a voice in your memory that says, this is what a good father sounds like. You have a silence where that voice should be. And the silence can produce two opposite errors. Either you try too hard, compensating for what you did not have by becoming an overwhelming presence that smothers rather than forms. Or you withdraw, afraid that you will repeat patterns you cannot even name, because the patterns are absences rather than actions, and how do you avoid repeating an absence.

I have lived in both errors. In the early years of fatherhood, I compensated. I was everywhere. I was at every game, every practice, every school event. I was present in body to a degree that exhausted me, because I was terrified of being absent the way my father had been absent. And my presence, driven by fear rather than love, had an edge to it that my sons could feel. They could feel that I was there because I was afraid of not being there, not because I was free to be there. Fear-driven presence is a form of control. It looks like

devotion. It feels like surveillance.

Then I swung the other direction. I pulled back. I told myself I was giving them space. What I was doing was protecting myself from the intensity of fatherhood that I did not know how to regulate. The pulling back was not freedom. It was avoidance. And my sons felt that too. Children always feel the difference between a father who gives them space and a father who is retreating.

The correction came, as it often does, through my wife. Susanna sat me down one evening and said something that changed the trajectory of my fathering. She said, you are either trying to be the father you did not have, or you are running from the fear that you will fail the way he failed. Neither of those is you. Find yourself. Find the father God made you to be, not the one you are compensating for and not the one you are running from.

That conversation was a gift. It took me years to unwrap it fully, but the core of it was this. I could not parent from a wound. I had to parent from a healed place. And healing the father wound required me to take the wound to God rather than to my children. My sons are not responsible for healing the absence of my father. God is. And as God has done that healing, slowly, over years, the fathering that comes from me has become less driven by fear and more rooted in love. Less compensatory and more natural.

If you are a father without a father, hear me. You are not disqualified. You are not destined to repeat what was done to you, or what was not done. But you do need to bring the wound to God and to trusted people who can help you process it. A counselor. A mentor. A pastor who understands. A friend who will listen without judging. The wound does not have to be the thing that defines your fathering. But it will define your fathering if you leave it untreated, because untreated wounds leak into every relationship, and the relationship they leak into most is the one with the small person who looks up at you and calls you Dad.

I also want to speak to the fathers who are here but not present.

You are in the house. You come home every evening. You eat at the table. You attend the events. But your mind is elsewhere. Your phone is in your hand. Your work follows you home in your head and you cannot put it down. You are a body in a chair, and your children have learned to tell the difference between a father who is in the room and a father who is with them.

Presence is not proximity. I can be three feet from my son and a thousand miles away. I can be sitting at the dinner table thinking about a sermon, a budget meeting, a difficult phone call, and my son, who is telling me about something that happened at school, can feel the distance as clearly as if I had left the room. He will stop talking. He will look down at his plate. He will learn that his voice is not interesting enough to hold his father's attention. And that lesson, absorbed over a thousand dinners, will form something in him that no bedtime blessing can undo.

The discipline of presence is one of the hardest disciplines of fatherhood. It requires you to set things down. Not the phone only. The worry. The planning. The mental rehearsal of tomorrow's problems. It requires you to be in the room you are in, with the people who are in it, giving them the thing they need most from you, which is not your provision or your protection or your wisdom. It is your attention. Your eyes on their eyes. Your ears on their words. Your heart oriented toward them for the time you are together.

I practice this imperfectly. But I practice it. When I sit down for dinner, I put the phone in another room. When one of my sons is talking to me, I stop what I am doing and turn my body toward them. Not because I am naturally attentive. Because I have learned that the moments I am tempted to half-listen are the moments my sons are most likely to say the thing I need to hear. Children do not schedule their vulnerability. They tell you in the car on the way to practice. They tell you while you are making sandwiches. They tell you at nine thirty at night when you are ready for bed. And if you are not present in those unscheduled moments, you will miss the conversation that mattered most.

Be in the room, fathers. Not in the house only. In the room. Your children are forming their understanding of what a man is by watching you. Give them something worth watching.

CHAPTER 11

Single Parents, Blended Families, and the God Who Holds

I have written the last several chapters with a particular household in mind. Two parents. Married. Both present. Both professing faith. That is the picture that most Christian parenting books assume, and it is the picture I have assumed in much of this book because it is the household I live in and the household I know best. But if I stop there, I have failed a significant number of the people reading this. Because many of you are not in that picture. And the implication, rarely stated but always felt, is that if your household does not match the picture, the formation of your children is compromised beyond repair.

That implication is a lie. It needs to be named as such, clearly, so that the parent who is reading this in a house that does not match the picture can hear what follows without the lie in the way.

Name it. Single parents are doing the work of formation in millions of homes across this country. Single mothers, more often than not, but also single fathers. Some through divorce. Some through death. Some through circumstances they did not choose and would not have chosen. And the message they have received from the Christian parenting world, sometimes explicitly and sometimes through the silence of omission, is that their household is deficient. That the absence of a second parent, particularly a father, has created a deficit that cannot be overcome. That their children are statistically destined for worse outcomes. That the formation project is, at best, damaged goods.

I want to speak directly to that. It is half true and entirely unhelpful.

The half that is true is this. Two believing parents in a home create a formation environment that has structural advantages. More presence. More modeling. More reinforcement. A child who can see both a mother and a father walking with God has two windows into the character of God. That is real. I will not pretend it is not.

The half that is a lie is the implication that the absence of one parent makes formation impossible. It does not. The God who promises to be Father to the fatherless and who has particular care for the widow and the orphan is not a God who has left the single parent's household without resources. He is a God who has promised to fill what is missing. He meant it. And I have watched Him do it. I have watched single mothers raise children whose faith went the distance. I have watched single fathers carry a weight that would have crushed most people and produce households where Christ was more visible, not less, because the dependence on God was more real, not less. The single parent who is clinging to God because they have no other option is modeling a faith that the comfortable two-parent home sometimes lacks. Dependence teaches in ways independence cannot. A child who watches a parent depend on God, honestly, daily, with no backup plan, is learning something about the nature of God that the child in the comfortable home may never learn.

Reframe it. The single-parent household is not a broken version of the two-parent household. It is a different household with different challenges and different graces. The formation principles in this book apply to it. The four channels of the household catechism still operate. What you praise, what you worry about, what you repeat, what you rest in. Those channels are running in a single-parent home the same way they run in a two-parent home. The child is still being formed by proximity to the parent's actual life with God. The parent's faith is still the primary curriculum.

What is different is the weight. The single parent carries more weight. They carry the economic weight and the emotional weight and the logistical weight and the spiritual weight, and they carry it without the partner who was supposed to share it. That weight is real.

I do not want to minimize it or spiritualize it into something it is not. It is crushing, some days. Some weeks. Some years.

And here is where the church is supposed to come in. The church is supposed to be the extended family that the single-parent household needs. The church is supposed to provide the additional believing adults that the child needs. The church is supposed to be the uncles and aunts and grandparents and mentors that the household cannot provide on its own. This is not a program. It is the body of Christ functioning as the body of Christ. A single mother in a church that knows her name, that feeds her family, that includes her sons in the lives of godly men, that walks with her through the hard years, that does not pity her but partners with her, is a single mother who is not alone. And her children are not fatherless, because the church has fathers in it, and those fathers can extend something to her children that the absent father did not provide.

I want to be direct with the church for a moment. If you are a congregation that talks about the importance of the family and has no concrete support for single parents, you are not a family church. You are a church for a certain kind of family. The single parent in your congregation feels the difference. She walks into the mother-daughter event and sits alone. He comes to the men's retreat and does not hear his situation mentioned once. Their children are in the youth group and nobody has ever asked whether they have a believing adult in their life who is not their surviving parent. The church has to do better. Not out of pity. Out of the theology it already confesses. If the church is the body of Christ, and the body has members who are carrying more than they can carry alone, the body bears the burden with them. That is not optional. That is Galatians 6.

Now let me speak to the blended family, because the blended family has its own set of formation challenges that are different from the single-parent household and that are almost never addressed in Christian parenting literature.

The blended family is a household where children are being

formed by adults who do not all share the same history. The stepparent enters the formation environment mid-story. The child has a history with a biological parent that the stepparent was not part of. The child may have loyalties that compete. The child may resent the new adult. The child may be grieving the loss of the original family, and the presence of the new family, no matter how loving, is a constant reminder of what was lost.

Name it. Formation in a blended family is complicated. It requires more patience, more communication, and more grace than formation in a household where everyone has been together from the beginning. The stepparent who tries to claim full parental authority too quickly will usually be resisted. The biological parent who expects the child to transfer loyalty to the new spouse will usually be disappointed. The household that pretends the blending is complete when it is not will produce confusion in the child, because the child knows the truth even when the adults are performing it.

What I have seen work in blended families is this. The stepparent takes a posture of presence without presumption. They are present. They are consistent. They are kind. They do not force the relationship. They let it develop at the child's pace, not the adult's. The biological parent supports the stepparent's authority in age-appropriate ways without requiring the child to feel about the stepparent the way they feel about the biological parent. The household acknowledges, openly, that this family has a complex history and that the complexity is not a failure. It is a reality that God is present in.

The formation principles still apply. The household still has a catechism. What it praises, what it worries about, what it repeats, what it rests in. The child in a blended family is still absorbing the implicit theology of the home. The additional complication is that the child may be absorbing two household catechisms, one from each home, and the two may contradict each other. A child who spends weekdays in a home where Christ is the center and weekends in a home where Christ is irrelevant is receiving a divided catechism. That

is painful. It is also not fatal. Because the household where Christ is the center has something that the other household does not, which is the presence and power of the Holy Spirit, and the Spirit is not limited by custody arrangements.

The blended family parent needs to hear this: you are not at a disadvantage that disqualifies you from the work of formation. You are at a disadvantage that requires more of you. More prayer. More patience. More dependence on God. More willingness to hold the tension of a situation that does not resolve neatly. The formation that happens in a blended family is sometimes deeper than the formation that happens in a family that has never been broken, because the blended family has no illusions about its own sufficiency. It knows it needs God. That knowing is itself formative for the children who are watching.

The costly hope in this chapter is for every parent whose household does not match the picture on the cover of the Christian parenting book. The hope is that God is not limited by your family structure. He is not limited by your marital status. He is not limited by the complexity of your custody arrangement. He is not limited by your ex-spouse's hostility to the faith. He is not limited by your age, your energy, your resources, or your mistakes. He is limited by nothing. And He has placed your children in your care, in this household, in this configuration, and He intends to use you, in this household, to form them. Not despite the difficulty. Through it.

Let your children see you depend on God. Let them see you carry what is too heavy and bring it to the One who carries you. Let them see a faith that is not decorative but necessary. A faith that is not a luxury for the comfortable household but the lifeline of the household that has nothing else to hold onto. That is real formation. That is a faith the child will remember.

I want to add a practical word for single parents, because you need practical words more than you need theological ones. You already know God is with you. What you need is help.

First, accept help. Many single parents resist help because they feel they should be able to do this on their own, or because accepting help feels like admitting defeat. It is not defeat. It is wisdom. God designed the body of Christ to share burdens. You are not failing by letting someone watch your children so you can rest. You are not failing by asking another family to include your son in their camping trip. You are not failing by letting the grandmother take the kids for a weekend so you can breathe. You are cooperating with the design of the body.

Second, identify the believing adults your children need. Your child needs adult role models beyond you. If you are a single mother, your son needs godly men in his life. Not a replacement father. A presence. A man who can take him fishing, who can teach him to change a tire, who can be the male image of God that your household does not currently have. If you are a single father, your daughter needs godly women in her life. Not a replacement mother. A presence. A woman who can speak into her life in the ways only women can. Look for these people in your church. Ask your pastor to help you find them. And if your church cannot provide them, find a church that can. Your children's formation depends partly on the community around them, and building that community is one of the most important things you can do.

Third, do not let guilt drive your parenting. Many single parents compensate for the absent parent by being permissive, by avoiding discipline, by trying to be both the good cop and the bad cop and ending up as neither. Your children need a parent who is clear, consistent, and loving. They do not need a parent who is performing compensation. The guilt is understandable. It is not useful. Bring it to God. Let Him carry it. Then parent your children the way they need to be parented, which is with clarity, with warmth, and with the confidence that comes from knowing that God put them in your care and equipped you for the task.

Fourth, tell your children the truth about your household, in age-appropriate ways. Children in single-parent homes often carry

unspoken questions. Why is my family different. Is something wrong with us. Did I cause this. Answer those questions before the child has to ask them. Tell them the truth about your situation, at a level they can receive. Tell them that your family looks different and that God is in this family completely. Tell them that the absence of one parent does not mean the absence of God's provision. Tell them that you are doing this together, and that together includes God. Children can carry more truth than we think. What they cannot carry is silence. Silence breeds shame. Truth, spoken with love, breeds security.

I want to tell you about a single mother in my church who has taught me more about formation than most two-parent families I know. She was divorced when her children were young. The circumstances were painful. She did not choose them. She found herself raising three children on a teacher's salary in a small apartment with no family nearby.

What she did was this. She built a household catechism with the materials she had. She could not afford Christian school. She could not afford the retreats. She could not afford the summer camps. What she could afford was time, and she spent it lavishly. Every evening, she sat at the table with her children and asked them about their day. Not casually. With attention. She prayed with them before bed, not for sixty seconds but for ten minutes, naming each child's specific concerns. She read the Bible to them, not from a curriculum but from wherever she was reading herself, and she told them what it meant to her, in plain language, with her own struggles included.

Her children are now in their twenties. All three are walking with Jesus. All three credit their mother's faith, not the church's programs, as the primary reason they believe. One of them told me that the most formative thing about his childhood was hearing his mother pray. He said she prayed like she was talking to someone who was actually in the room. He said he believed God was real because his mother clearly believed God was real, and her belief was not inherited or performed. It was forged. In the fire of raising three children alone while trusting a God she could not see to hold what she could not

carry.

That woman's household was not the model. It was the principle.
And the principle worked because the presence was real.

CHAPTER 12

Grandparents and the Long Memory of Faith

There is a verse in Psalm 78 that most parents read as a parenting verse and most grandparents have never been told is about them. It reads: We will tell the next generation the praiseworthy deeds of the Lord, his power, and the wonders he has done. He decreed statutes for Jacob and established the law in Israel, which he commanded our ancestors to teach their children, so the next generation would know them, even the children yet to be born, and they in turn would tell their children.

Count the generations in that psalm. Ancestors. Their children. The next generation. Children yet to be born. Their children. That is five generations. The psalmist is not describing a one-generation project. He is describing a relay. And the relay depends on every runner, not only the parents. It depends on the grandparents. It depends on the great-grandparents. It depends on the old man in the congregation who has been walking with God for sixty years and who has a story that nobody has asked him to tell.

Name it. The church has largely sidelined grandparents from the formation conversation. The Christian parenting section at the bookstore is full of books for parents of toddlers, parents of teenagers, parents of prodigals. There are almost no books for grandparents, which is strange, because grandparents are one of the most formative presences in a child's life, and their absence from the conversation is a loss the church has not measured.

Grandparents carry something parents do not have. They carry time. Not schedule time. Deep time. They carry the memory of

decades. They carry the evidence of God's faithfulness over a span of years that the child's parents have not yet lived. A grandmother who has walked with God for fifty years carries fifty years of answered prayer, fifty years of sustained faith, fifty years of watching God work in situations that seemed impossible. That memory is not sentimental. It is evidentiary. It is the testimony of a life lived long enough to confirm what Scripture promises. And a child who hears that testimony, from a person they trust, in an ordinary conversation, is receiving something that no Sunday school curriculum can provide.

I think about my own congregation. Some of the most formative people in the lives of the young families are not the young families' peers. They are the older saints. The woman in her seventies who has buried a husband, survived cancer, raised four children, and still weeps when she sings How Great Thou Art. The man in his eighties who fought in a war, lost a child, rebuilt a marriage, and can tell you, with steady eyes, that God has never once abandoned him. These people are formation resources. Their lives are the evidence. And in many churches, they are sitting in the back row, unasked, while the children's ministry hunts for twenty-five-year-old volunteers.

Reframe it. The grandparent's role in formation is not supplementary. It is essential. It fills a gap that the parent cannot fill, which is the gap between claimed faith and demonstrated faith over time. A parent can tell a child that God is faithful. A grandparent can tell a child that God has been faithful for sixty years, and here is the specific evidence, and I have bet my life on it, and I am still here, and He is still good. The child hears both. They need both. But the grandparent's testimony carries a weight that the parent's claim does not yet have, because the grandparent has lived long enough to prove it.

Let me be specific about what grandparents can do that no one else in the child's life can do.

First, grandparents can tell the story. Every family has a faith story, and in many families, that story is being lost. The grandparent

knows how the family came to faith. They know who prayed. They know who sacrificed. They know the hard years. They know the answered prayers. They know the miracles, the small ones and the large ones. They know the failures and the recoveries. That story is the child's inheritance. It is not a luxury. It is the narrative in which the child's own faith makes sense. A child who knows that their grandmother came to Christ as a teenager in a small church in Alabama, that their grandfather survived a war and came home and built a life of faith from the rubble, that their great-aunt prayed for forty years for a wayward brother who came home in the end, that child is embedded in a narrative. The faith is not something new. It is something old. It has roots. It has tested itself. It has survived. And the child is the next chapter in a story that has been running for decades.

Tell the story. Tell it at the dinner table. Tell it at Thanksgiving. Tell it when the grandchild asks a question that opens the door. Tell it when they do not ask, because sometimes the story is the invitation they did not know they needed. Do not wait for a formal occasion. Tell it in the car. Tell it while making cookies. Tell it while walking. The informality makes it more real, not less. The child who hears their grandfather's conversion story while they are eating ice cream together has received a gift that will surface, years later, at the exact moment they need it.

Second, grandparents can pray with a patience that parents often cannot sustain. The parent's prayer is urgent. The parent is in the middle of the formation project, and the urgency of the daily crisis shapes the prayer. The grandparent's prayer is long. The grandparent has learned, over decades, that God works slowly. That unanswered prayer is not unanswered. That decades of intercession produce fruit that is not visible on any human timeline. The grandparent who prays for their grandchildren by name, daily, for years, is laying a foundation that the child will not understand until they are an adult. And some of the most powerful conversions I have witnessed in my pastoral ministry have been traced back, by the person who was

converted, to a grandmother who prayed.

Monica prayed for Augustine for decades. He was brilliant, rebellious, dissolute, and lost. She prayed. She wept. She followed him across the Mediterranean. She prayed more. He came home. The greatest theologian in the history of the Western church was a grandmother's prayer project. Do not tell me prayer does not work. It works on a timeline that is longer than ours.

Third, grandparents can be the stable presence when the parent is in crisis. There are seasons in a family's life when the parents are overwhelmed. Illness. Financial trouble. Marital difficulty. Job loss. Ministry burnout. During those seasons, the children feel the instability. They feel the parent's anxiety. They feel the ground shift. The grandparent, if they are present, can be the ground that does not shift. The grandparent can be the steady hand, the calm voice, the reminder that this family has been through hard things before and God has brought them through. The child who has a grandparent as an anchor during a storm is a child who learns that faith is not dependent on circumstances. Faith is dependent on God. And God does not shift.

Fourth, grandparents can love without the pressure of the parenting role. This is a gift that is unique to grandparents and that parents sometimes resent but children desperately need. The grandparent does not have to enforce the rules. The grandparent does not have to make the hard decisions. The grandparent gets to be the one who loves without agenda. And a child who has an adult in their life who loves them without agenda, who delights in them without trying to shape them, who is present without the pressure of the parenting project, is a child who has a picture of the unconditional love of God that the parent, who must also discipline and correct, cannot always provide.

I want to speak to grandparents directly now. Some of you feel sidelined. You feel like the young parents do not want your input. You feel like the culture has told you that your season is over. You

feel like you do not understand the world your grandchildren are growing up in, and therefore you have nothing to offer them.

None of that is true. You have everything to offer them. You have a life. You have testimony. You have prayer. You have presence. You have patience that the young parents do not have because they have not lived long enough to learn it. You have perspective that the young parents do not have because they are still in the middle of things you can see from a distance. You have stories. You have faith. You have love that is seasoned by years. All of that is formative. All of it is needed.

Do not wait for an invitation. Offer yourself. Call your grandchildren. Write them letters. Yes, actual letters, on paper, that they can hold and keep and read again when they are thirty and you are gone. Tell them what you believe and why. Tell them what God has done in your life. Tell them what you pray for them. Tell them you are proud of them. Tell them specific things you see in them that remind you of God's work. Do not assume they know. Tell them.

I want to address a tension that many grandparents face. It is the tension between wanting to guide and not wanting to overstep. The grandparent who sees their grandchild being raised in a way they disagree with faces a difficult choice. Speak up and risk the relationship. Stay silent and carry the worry. There is no formula for this. But I will offer a principle. The grandparent's primary gift to the grandchild is presence, not correction. If you must choose between being right and being present, choose presence. A grandchild who has you in their life, who knows you love them, who has heard your testimony, who has been prayed for by name, is a grandchild who has a resource they can draw on later, even if the parenting you disagree with produces the crisis you feared. You will be there. You will be the stable ground. That matters more than winning the argument with your adult child about bedtimes or school choices or screen limits.

The exception is moral or physical danger. If you see genuine harm, you speak. You speak clearly and you speak with love. But in

the gray areas, and most of parenting is gray area, the grandparent's gift is patience, prayer, and presence. Not control.

I want to close this chapter with a word to churches. Honor your elderly. They are not a demographic to manage. They are the long memory of the faith. They carry stories and testimonies that the young families need. Create intergenerational space. Let the old saints pray over the young families. Let the grandmothers hold the babies while the young mothers breathe. Let the grandfathers sit with the teenage boys and tell them what manhood has looked like over sixty years. Stop segregating by age group as though the generations have nothing to give each other. They have everything to give each other. The relay in Psalm 78 requires the handoff, and the handoff requires proximity. Put the generations in the same room. See what God does.

The costly hope for grandparents is this. Your role is not finished. It may be entering its most important phase. The prayers you pray now may be the prayers that bring your grandchildren home twenty years from now. The stories you tell now may be the stories they remember when everything else has been forgotten. The love you give now may be the picture of God's love that surfaces at the moment of their greatest need. You are not retired from the work of formation. You are in the deep end of it. Stay there. Pray. Tell the stories. Be present. Let the long memory of your faith become the foundation of theirs.

One final thought for grandparents. You are living in a culture that worships youth and discards age. The church has sometimes followed the culture in this, building its programs around the young and its strategies around the next generation, while the current generation of elders sits in the pews with decades of tested faith and nobody asks them to testify.

Resist the marginalization. You have something the young do not have. You have lived proof. The young parent tells their child that God is faithful. You can tell that child that God has been faithful for

sixty years, through the death of a spouse, through the loss of a career, through the illness that should have taken you, through the decades of prayer that were answered in ways you did not expect. Your testimony is not sentimental. It is evidentiary. It is the kind of evidence that a child needs, especially a child growing up in a culture that treats faith as outdated and God as unnecessary.

Tell the stories. Not once. Many times. Because the stories need to be embedded, and embedding requires repetition. Tell the story of how you came to faith. Tell the story of the hardest year of your life and how God carried you through it. Tell the story of the prayer that took twenty years to be answered. Tell the story of the marriage that almost broke and was rebuilt. Tell the story of the child who wandered and came home. These stories are the family's faith heritage. They are the evidence that the faith is not new. It is old. It is tested. It has held. And your grandchild is the next link in a chain that stretches back through you, through your parents, through the saints who held the faith before any of you were born.

Your grandchild may not seem interested when you tell the story. Tell it anyway. Because ten years from now, or twenty, or thirty, in a moment of crisis you cannot foresee, the story will surface. The grandchild will remember. And the memory of your faith will be the thing that holds when everything else gives way.

The next chapter is the hardest one in the book. It is about what happens when they walk away.

But before we go there, let me expand on the grandparent's four contributions, because they are not interchangeable and each one does something the others cannot.

The first contribution is story. A grandparent carries stories that the parent cannot tell because the parent was not there. Stories about the family's faith across generations. Stories about hard times that God brought the family through before the child was born. These stories locate the child inside a narrative larger than their own lifetime. The child is not the beginning of their family's faith story.

They are a chapter in a story that started before them and will continue after them. That continuity matters. It gives the child a sense of rootedness that the present tense alone cannot provide.

I think about my own sons and the fact that they do not have grandparents who can tell them stories of multi-generational faith. My mother came to faith later in life. The long arc of generational faithfulness, the kind where a grandparent can say, my grandmother prayed for me before I was born, and her mother prayed for her, and now I pray for you, that arc is not something we can give our sons. It is something I grieve, quietly, because I know the power of that kind of story and I know my sons do not have it.

If you are a grandparent who can tell that story, you are carrying something rare. Do not keep it to yourself. Tell it at Thanksgiving. Tell it on ordinary Tuesdays when you are babysitting. Tell them about the time God answered prayer in a way that changed the family. Tell them about the hardship that nearly broke your faith and how your faith survived. The child will not remember every detail. They will remember that their grandparent had a story with God, and that they are part of it.

The second contribution is prayer. A grandparent's prayer carries a weight that is difficult to describe. There is something about being prayed for by someone who has been praying for fifty or sixty years that a younger person's prayer does not replicate. The grandparent who prays for a grandchild has survived losses the child cannot imagine. Their prayer is not theoretical. It is the prayer of a person who has been in the furnace and has found God faithful. That prayer, spoken over a grandchild, carries the weight of a life behind it.

If you are a grandparent, your prayer for your grandchildren is among the most important things you can do for their formation. Pray by name. Pray with specificity. Pray for their character, their friends, their future spouses, their faith. And tell them you are praying. Let them know. The knowledge that someone is praying for you, someone with a long history with God, is a gift that compounds over

a lifetime.

The third contribution is stability. Grandparents represent permanence in a world that feels, to a child, like it is always shifting. The grandparent's house is the same. The grandparent's voice is the same. The grandparent's routine is the same. In a culture of constant change, the grandparent's sameness is not boring. It is anchoring. That stability matters for spiritual formation because it teaches the child that some things do not change. God does not change. The promises have not changed. The grandparent who has been faithful for decades is living proof that constancy is possible.

The fourth contribution is unconditional love. I use that phrase carefully because it is overused. But in this case I mean something specific. The grandparent loves the child without the complicating factors that attend parental love. The parent loves the child and is also responsible for the child's behavior. The parent's love is real, but it is entangled with authority and expectation. The grandparent's love is simpler. The grandparent is not managing the child. The grandparent is delighting in the child. That delight, received by the child without the complications of discipline, teaches the child something about the love of God that parental love alone cannot fully communicate.

The child who is delighted in by a grandparent learns what it feels like to be enjoyed rather than managed. To be celebrated rather than corrected. To be welcomed without having to perform. When the child eventually hears that God delights in His children, the child who has been delighted in by a grandparent has a felt reference for what that means.

Grandparents, your delight in your grandchildren is not indulgence. It is theology. It is a lived demonstration of what uncomplicated love feels like. Keep delighting. You are forming the child's capacity to receive the love of God.

I want to speak to the grandparent who is raising grandchildren. There are more of you than anyone counts. You stepped in when the biological parents could not or would not. You are raising children at

an age when you thought you would be resting. You are tired. You are scared that you are not enough. You wonder if you have the energy for this. You wonder if the cultural gap between your generation and theirs is too wide. You wonder if they resent you for not being their parents.

You are doing holy work. You are the stable ground under a child whose ground was taken away. You are the consistency in a life that has been inconsistent. You are the face of God's faithfulness to a child who has reason to believe that people leave. You do not need to be perfect. You need to be there. And you are. That is enough.

I want to close this section with a word to the grandparent who is estranged from their grandchildren. You have a son or daughter who has pulled away. The relationship is broken. You are not permitted to be in the grandchildren's lives the way you want to be. The grief of that estrangement is among the most painful things a human being can experience.

I cannot fix that in a chapter. What I can tell you is this. Pray anyway. You may not be in the room, but your prayers are not restricted by geography or relational distance. Keep the door open. Write the letters even if they are not answered. Send the gifts even if they are not acknowledged. Let your child and grandchild know, by every means available to you, that your love has not changed and that you are waiting for them.

Some of the most striking reunion stories I have witnessed have come after years of patient waiting. The grandparent who refused to give up. Who kept praying. Who kept sending the card on the birthday. The wait was long. The faithfulness was costly. And the reunion, when it came, was a resurrection.

CHAPTER 13

When They Walk Away

There is a kind of grief that Christian parents carry in public because they have to, but that breaks them in private. It is the grief of a child who has walked away from the faith. I have sat with parents in this grief. I have held their hands across my office desk. I have watched a mother's face collapse when she said, out loud, for the first time in months, I do not know if my son believes anymore. I have seen fathers go quiet for a long time and then say, I do not know what I am supposed to do with this. There is no chapter of this book I approach with more care than this one, because the people reading it are sometimes bleeding, and platitudes are not what they need.

Name it. Some of your children are going to walk away from the faith. Some of them already have. Some of them are walking away right now, inches at a time, and you can feel it but you cannot name it yet. This is a reality of Christian parenting that has been historically true in every generation and is especially pronounced in this one. It does not always mean you did something wrong. It does not always mean you did something right. It means you have a child who is becoming their own person before God, and that becoming is not happening on your timeline, and sometimes it takes them through places you wish they were not going. Pretending this is rare, or blaming it entirely on parental failure, does not help the parents living it. It adds guilt to grief. That is not Christian. That is cruel.

I need to distinguish between a few things, because the distinctions matter for how you pray and how you respond. There is the child who is in an active rebellion. There is the child who is in honest questioning. There is the child who has quietly concluded, on the merits, that Christianity is not true for them. There is the child who has been wounded by the church and is processing that wound.

There is the child who is in a sinful pattern they do not want to give up and who is using unbelief as a permission slip. There is the child who is not sure where they stand and who is ashamed to tell their parents about it. These are different. They require different responses. They all feel the same to the parent. They are not the same. The first pastoral work is to be honest about which one you are looking at, as best you can discern. That discernment changes how you pray, how you speak, and how you wait.

Let me take each one briefly, because the response matters.

The child in active rebellion is pushing against everything. They know what they were raised with. They are rejecting it, often loudly. The rebellion may involve choices that grieve you, a lifestyle you cannot endorse, language and attitudes that are the opposite of what you taught. This child is usually the easiest to identify and the hardest to respond to well, because the rebellion activates the parent's fear and anger simultaneously.

The child in honest questioning is not rebelling. They are thinking. They have encountered ideas that challenge what they were taught, and they are working through them. They may not attend church for a season. They may read authors you disagree with. They may say things that sound like unbelief but are actually the sound of a mind in the process of examination. This child needs space, not pressure. They need a parent who is not terrified by the questioning, because the parent's terror communicates that the faith cannot survive examination.

The child who has concluded that Christianity is not true is different from the child who is questioning. This child has arrived somewhere. They have thought about it. They may be at peace with their conclusion. They are not angry. They are not rebellious. They have made an intellectual decision. This child needs a parent who can respect the dignity of their thinking while maintaining their own convictions. They do not need a parent who treats their conclusion as a phase to be waited out.

The child wounded by the church is processing pain. Something happened in a church context, a leader's failure, a community's hypocrisy, an experience of being hurt by people who claimed to represent God. The child's departure is not from God. It is from the people who claimed to speak for God. This child needs a parent who can separate the church's failures from God's character, honestly, without defending the indefensible.

The child using unbelief as a permission slip for a sin pattern they do not want to give up is a different matter. This child has not examined the faith and found it wanting. They have found the faith inconvenient and are constructing a rationale for ignoring it. This is not an intellectual departure. It is a moral one. And the parent's response must be different, because the root is different.

The child who is unsure and ashamed may be the most common and the least visible. This child has not walked away. They have drifted. They do not know what they believe. They are afraid to say so. They are afraid of disappointing the parent. They are performing faith while the faith is evaporating behind the performance. This child needs a parent who creates space for honesty. Who says, you can tell me where you are, and I will not fall apart.

Reframe it. A child walking away from the faith is not the end of the story. It is a chapter. It may be a long chapter. It may even be the rest of your earthly life. It is not the verdict. God is not finished because you are past the age when you have control of the outcome. In fact, the whole New Testament is full of people who came to Christ long after their mothers stopped being able to make them. Augustine is one. Monica prayed for him for decades. Decades. He came home. Some of your children may take decades. You are going to have to do the hardest thing a parent of faith ever does, which is to entrust them to the Father over years of not knowing, without becoming either bitter or indulgent.

Here is what I have seen work, and here is what I have seen destroy families. I will go in both directions so you know what I

mean.

What works. Keep the door open. Keep the relationship. Keep the phone calls. Keep inviting them to dinner. Keep appearing for the grandchildren if there are grandchildren. Do not lecture them every time you see them. Do not turn every conversation into an evangelistic appeal. Do not treat them as a project. Treat them as a person you love, who is loved by Christ, whom Christ is pursuing in ways you cannot see. The parent who keeps the door open is the parent who is most likely to be the one the child comes back to when the season changes.

I knew a mother who did this for twelve years. Her daughter left the faith at nineteen. The mother kept calling. Kept inviting. Kept sending birthday cards with handwritten notes that said nothing about church and everything about love. Kept praying. For twelve years. The daughter came back at thirty-one. When someone asked the daughter what brought her back, she said, my mother never stopped loving me the way she loved me before I left. She did not try to fix me. She did not lecture me. She kept being my mother. And when I was ready to come back, she was the safest person in the world to come back to. That is the ministry of the open door. It does not guarantee the return. It makes the return possible.

What destroys. Making your love conditional on their belief. Withholding affection until they return. Weaponizing scripture in every conversation. Grilling them about their spiritual life the moment they walk in the door. Shaming them publicly. Triangulating other family members. Refusing to attend their wedding because they married someone you disapprove of. These are not Christian responses. They are the responses of a parent who has made the child's belief into an idol, and who is willing to harm the child for failing to give the idol what the idol demanded. It is a common response. It is never pastoral. It never leads back. It only hardens.

I want to say something that will bother some of the stricter corners of the Christian parenting world. Tough love, in the way that

phrase has been used over the last thirty years, has destroyed more relationships with prodigal children than it has restored. The father in Luke 15 did not chase his son and drag him home. He also did not cut him off in bitterness. He let him go. He watched for him. He ran to him when he saw him on the road. That is the pattern. Let go. Watch. Run to them when they turn. It is not complicated in its structure. It is brutal in its execution, because the watching is what breaks you. The years of watching and not knowing. That is the suffering. God does not promise to remove it. He promises to carry you through it.

Here is another thing. Your child's walking away is not a verdict on your parenting. I mean this carefully. It may expose some things in your parenting that need confession. It also may not. Many of the parents I have walked with in this grief were faithful parents. They did the work. They loved their children. They prayed over them. They made the hard decisions. And the child still walked. That is because children are not products. They are persons. Persons have agency. A child made in the image of God will, at some point, make their own response to God. You cannot make it for them. You can only raise them in a home where response is invited. Whether they respond is not in the end within your control. That truth is painful. It is also freeing, if you will let it be.

There is a specific sin pattern among grieving Christian parents that I want to name, because I have seen it destroy people. It is the spiral of self-blame. If I had done this differently. If I had not sent her to that school. If I had held on tighter. If I had let go sooner. If I had prayed more. If I had prayed less. If I had not been so strict. If I had not been so lenient. This is a trap. You can replay every parental decision forever and not find the one you can hold up as the cause. The grief wants a cause because a cause is manageable. Mystery is not manageable. Stay with the mystery. Confess where you were wrong, specifically. Do not confess a general indictment against yourself, because general indictments are not repentance. They are self-punishment. Repent of what you actually did. Entrust what is beyond that to God.

Another sin pattern. The weaponizing of the grief. Using the child's unbelief as a cudgel against your spouse. This happens more than I can say. Two parents grieve differently. One wants to push harder. The other wants to back off. They disagree, then they blame each other, then the marriage cracks. The marriage is not supposed to be the casualty of the child's wandering. The marriage is supposed to be the shared place where you carry the weight together. Guard the marriage. Pray together for the child. Refuse to turn against each other. Your unity under this cross is itself part of what God can use to draw the child home, because a home unified in prayer and love is magnetic even to a child who is running from it.

Practical advice, because you need some. Do not go silent with your child. Keep the ordinary rhythms of relationship. Text them about things that have nothing to do with faith. Ask them about work. Ask them about the dog. Send them a photo of something that made you think of them. Tell them you love them, often, without any strings. Invite them over. When they come, feed them well. Let the conversation be about whatever they want to talk about. If they bring up something spiritual, listen more than you speak. If they ask what you think, answer honestly, briefly, and without escalating. Do not turn every encounter into a summit. Most of the time, be their parent.

And when you pray, pray specifically and often. Pray by name. Pray the passages that match the place they are in. Pray with your spouse. Pray with other parents who are in the same grief. You are not alone. Do not walk this alone. The enemy wants you to walk it alone because isolation is where parents fall apart. Find two or three other believing parents and pray together for each other's children. Do it weekly. Do it for years. I have seen children come home out of those prayer rooms.

The costly hope in this chapter is slow and heavy. It is that God is not finished. It is that you do not know what He is doing. It is that the child you are grieving may be being drawn, right now, in ways you cannot perceive, by a Father who loves them more than you do. It is that your role is not to secure their return. It is to be the kind of

parent they would come home to, if they came home. Be that parent. That is what is in your hand. The rest is not.

Finally, prepare yourself for the possibility that you may not see the return in this life. It is hard to say. I say it because it is true. Some of your children may come home when you are old. Some may come home after you are gone. Some may come home in the last hour, in a way only God sees. Some, and we have to be honest, may not come home at all. This is the dark edge of the hope. You live in hope. You do not know the outcome. You do not control the outcome. You entrust the outcome to the Father who is both just and merciful, and whose mercy I would bet on, in the end, over my own evaluation of my child's trajectory any day. God is not a terrified parent. He is a steady one. Let Him teach you His steadiness in the waiting.

If you are the parent reading this in the middle of the grief, I want to say one last thing. You are loved by Christ. He sees your grief. He is not angry with you for it. He is near to you in it. The children of God grieve with hope. You are not grieving wrong. You are grieving because you love. Keep loving. Keep praying. Keep the door open. And let the Father do what only a Father can do. He is working. You cannot see it yet.

I want to close this chapter with a few words to the parents who are on the other side of this. Parents whose children did come back. I have watched it happen. I have watched it happen after five years and after twenty. I have watched children come back to the faith at thirty, at forty, at fifty. I have watched them come back quietly, without announcement, sometimes without even telling their parents until months later. I have watched them come back through a crisis, through a spouse, through the birth of their own child, through an illness that brought them to their knees.

The patterns of return are as varied as the patterns of departure. But I have noticed a few common threads. The child who comes back almost always says that the parent's steady love was the ground they returned to. They do not say the parent's arguments convinced them.

They say the parent's love outlasted their rebellion. They say the parent never gave up. They say the door was always open. They say the prayers were felt, even when they pretended not to feel them.

The child who comes back also often says that the faith they returned to is not the same faith they left. It is deeper. It is more honest. It has been tested by the departure and refined by the return. The child who comes back does not come back to a childhood faith. They come back to an adult faith that has been forged in the furnace of their own doubt and their own failure. That faith is often stronger than the faith of the child who never left, because it has been earned at greater cost.

If your child has come back, or if your child is in the process of coming back, receive them. Do not make them perform gratitude for your faithfulness. Do not say I told you so. Do not require them to affirm every doctrine before you welcome them. Welcome them the way the father in Luke 15 welcomed his son. With a ring and a robe and a feast. With extravagant joy. With tears that you have been holding for years. With the simple, devastating sentence: you were lost, and now you are found.

That is the gospel. That is the hope. That is the thing we have been building toward, in every chapter of this book, in every year of our children's lives. Not a guarantee. A hope. A costly, earned, grief-tested, prayer-soaked hope that God is the Father of our children, and that He is working, even when we cannot see it, even when the years are long, even when the silence is deafening.

He is working. Trust Him.

Now, let me close this book with a word about what the long obedience of raising believers actually looks like, over decades. That is the conclusion.

CONCLUSION

The Long Obedience of Raising Believers

If you have read this far, I owe you a few final words. Not a summary. You do not need me to restate what I already said. A summary at this point would insult your attention. What I owe you is something else. I owe you a word about how to carry this book into an ordinary Tuesday, because that is where parenting actually happens, and every book ever written on parenting is only as good as its ability to be lived out on a Tuesday when nobody is watching.

I want to tell you a small story before I close. One of my sons came to me a few years ago, at an age when I did not expect this, and asked if we could read through a book of the Bible together, the two of us. He picked Luke. I said yes. We spent the better part of a year in it, chapter by chapter, not every night, but regularly. Some nights were short. Some nights were long. Some nights the conversation wandered. Some nights he had a question that I did not expect from someone his age. One of those nights he asked me if I thought Jesus actually rose from the dead. I told him I did. He asked why. We spent an hour on that question. I did not give him a canned answer. I walked through what I actually believed, what the historical evidence is, what alternatives exist, and why the resurrection has held up for me under every alternative I have ever considered. He listened. He was quiet for a while. Then he said, I think I believe it too, Dad. Not as a declaration. As a small report, at the end of a year of reading together.

That conversation did not happen because I had a program. It happened because we had built the practice of reading and talking, slowly, over months. It happened because my life had given him

enough reason to think the question was worth asking me. It happened because I answered him honestly rather than defensively. That is formation. That is the thing. That is what I hope this book has helped you move toward, in whatever season you are in with your children.

If you have teenagers and you are feeling like you are late, you are not late. Start tomorrow. Start with a conversation. Start with an apology for what you have missed. Start with an invitation to read one passage of scripture together. Start small. Do not try to compensate all at once. Slow is fine. Slow is biblical. Slow is how most real formation has ever happened.

If you have young children and you are overwhelmed, you are not alone. The early years are crushing in their own way. Tend the four channels of your household catechism. Praise what is worth praising. Worry less. Repeat the right things. Rest in the right places. Do that slowly, over years. You are already doing more than you know.

If you are a single parent, the church is supposed to be around you. If it is not, find one that will be. God has a particular tenderness for the single parent. He promises to be the Father to the fatherless and the husband to the widow. He meant that. He will be. And you will find, in time, that He has held what you could not hold alone.

If you are a blended family, the complexity of your household is not a disqualification. It is the context in which God has placed you to do this work. The principles of formation apply in your home the same way they apply in any other. Your additional difficulty is also your additional dependence on God, and that dependence is itself formative for the children watching.

If you are grieving a child who has walked away, you are not alone either. Keep the door open. Pray by name. Trust the God who watches for prodigals on the horizon. Do not become bitter. Do not become indulgent. Be steady. Be present. Be a parent they would come home to. That is enough.

If you are a grandparent reading this, your role is enormous. You have been given a second chance, in some ways, at the work of formation. You have time your adult children do not have. You have stories they do not have. You have credibility built over decades. Use it. Pray for your grandchildren. Speak blessing over them. Give them your actual life, not a sentimental version. Be a living witness. The older generation matters. Do not believe anyone who tells you otherwise.

And if you are a parent who started this book thinking you already had this covered and ended it realizing you do not, welcome. That is most of us. I started this book in the same place, many years ago, and I have been brought back to the same conviction over and over. The formation of my children is a work I will never fully complete. It is a work I will never fully understand. It is a work I will never stop needing God's grace to do at all. I am still doing it. Some of my sons are approaching adulthood now. The work does not end when they leave home. It only changes.

This is the long obedience of raising believers. It is not dramatic. It is not glamorous. It does not make for good social media. It is slow and hidden and mostly unnoticed and mostly ordinary. It is done in kitchens and cars and living rooms and at bedsides. It is done over decades by parents who have decided, quietly, that they would rather be faithful than impressive. It is the work of being near your children, for a long time, with a life that is actually turned toward God, in a house where grace lands the first word and truth does not get softened. It is the work of trusting that God will meet your children at some point in ways you cannot orchestrate, and of making your home the kind of place where that meeting is at least plausible.

May God give you grace for this work. May He form you as you try to be a formation environment for your children. May He be the Father your children most need, through you and beyond you. May your house be the place where faith takes root in soil that was tended over years by parents who refused to give up. And may you, in the end, stand before Christ with your children beside you, not because

you were perfect parents, but because you kept coming back, and He met them.

Go. Raise them.

I want to close with something personal, because this book has been personal throughout and it should end the same way.

I started writing this book during a week when one of my sons was struggling. I will not name which son or the nature of the struggle, because his story is his to tell. But the timing was not accidental. I began writing about the formation of children in the faith at the exact moment when my own formation of my own child felt most fragile. I wrote about the household catechism while my household felt like it was running the wrong one. I wrote about answering questions while my son was asking questions I did not know how to answer.

That is the honest context of this book. It was not written from a summit of parental achievement. It was written from the valley. From the place where the principles I believe in were being tested by the reality I was living in. And what I discovered, in the writing and in the living, was that the principles held. Not because they produced immediate results. They did not. But because they were true. And true things hold you even when you cannot feel them holding.

The principle that formation is proximity to a formed life held, because even when my son was pulling away, he was still near enough to see what I was doing with my own fear. He watched me pray about it rather than rage about it. He watched me stay in the room rather than walk out of it. I do not know what he made of all that watching. I know that the watching was formation, whether it felt like it or not.

The principle that the household catechism runs on four channels held, because even in the hard week, the channels were still running. What I praised, what I worried about, what I repeated, what I rested in. Those channels did not shut down because one son was

struggling. They kept running. And I had to pay attention to them, because the other sons were still watching too. The household does not stop forming because one member is in crisis. It forms through the crisis.

The principle that your child's faith is in the end between them and God held, because I had to let go. Not of my parenting. Not of my prayers. Not of my presence. But of the outcome. I had to hand my son to God and say, He is Yours before he is mine, and You love him more than I do, and I trust You with him even though I cannot see what You are doing. That surrender is the hardest thing a Christian parent ever does. It is also the most important. Because the surrender is the final act of formation. It forms the parent.

I am still in the story. I do not know how it ends for my sons. They are still being formed. They are still choosing. And I am still in the room. Still praying. Still failing and repenting and trying again.

I think about my mother. The woman who raised me without a father, without faith, without a model for any of the things I have written about in this book. She did not form me in the Christian faith because she did not have it. But she formed me in something that the Christian faith would later fill. She formed me in honesty. She told me the truth about our situation. She did not pretend we were fine when we were not. She worked two jobs and she cried in the kitchen when she thought I was asleep and she got up the next morning and did it again. What I absorbed from her was not theology. It was resilience. It was the refusal to quit.

When I came to faith in college, everything my mother had formed in me found its proper home. The honesty became confession. The resilience became perseverance. The refusal to quit became faithfulness. My mother did not give me the faith. But she gave me the soil. And the soil received the seed, and the seed grew.

That is what you are doing. You are preparing soil. You are pulling weeds. You are watering ground. And the seed is not yours to manufacture. The seed belongs to God. Your job is to make the

ground as ready as you can, with the tools you have, in the time you are given.

The time you are given is shorter than you think. Your children will be grown before you are ready for them to be grown. Use the years. Not perfectly. Faithfully. Use them with the confidence that the God who entrusted these children to you is the same God who will pursue them long after they have left your house.

Hold it lightly. Hold it honestly. Hold it before God, who holds you and your children in His hands, and whose hands have never dropped anyone.

Go now. Into the kitchen. Into the car. Into the bedroom where the child is waiting for you to say the blessing. Go with the confidence that the small thing you do tonight is the thing that God will use. Not because it is impressive. Because it is faithful. And faithfulness, in the economy of God, is the only currency that never loses its value.

